TIM RULES 2

Save the School

The Complete Sequel — 50 Chapters

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CHAPTER 1

The Quietest Monday Ever

Monday

For exactly three weeks, my life was normal.

No secret rooms.

No stolen trophies.

No mysterious messages.

No teachers running down corridors looking terrified.

Just school.

Maths.

Homework.

Lunch.

More maths.

It was horrible.

Okay, maybe not horrible. But after you have helped solve a five-year-old Black Hawks mystery and found the Festival Cup with a rubber chicken, normal school feels a little too normal.

On Monday morning, I walked through the front doors and waited for something strange to happen.

Nothing did.

A Year Seven dropped his books.

A teacher told everyone to take off their hats.

Somebody's locker made a fart noise when it opened.

That was the most exciting thing all morning.

Noah met me outside the student council room.

"You're doing it again," he said.

"Doing what?"

"Staring at the walls like they're going to open."

"I wasn't staring at the walls."

"You tried to push the trophy cabinet."

"I thought it moved."

"It's screwed to the floor."

"That's exactly what a secret door would want me to think."

Noah shook his head.

Sophie was already inside the council room. She had organised our pens by colour, put three new folders on the desk, and stuck a large sheet of paper to the wall.

It said:

A NORMAL, SUCCESSFUL TERM

Underneath that, she had written:

NO MYSTERIES. NO CHAOS. NO CHICKENS IN MEETINGS.

Brad sat beside the last rule with Frank on his knee.

Greg was on my chair.

"That last rule seems targeted," I said.

"It is," Sophie replied.

I moved Greg and sat down.

Being student council leader had become much easier since the festival. People knew who I was. Teachers actually listened during meetings. The principal had given us a small budget for clubs and equipment.

I had even started to believe I knew what I was doing.

This was my first mistake.

"We need a project for this term," Sophie said.

"We could have another pizza Friday," I suggested.

"No."

"A longer lunch?"

"No."

"A shorter Monday?"

"Tim."

"Just checking."

Brad leaned back.

"We could build a chicken arena."

"No," Sophie said.

Noah raised his hand.

"What if we make homework optional?"

Sophie put down her pen.

"Does anyone have an idea that is actually possible?"

We went silent.

That was when the intercom crackled.

"Will Tim please come to the principal's office?"

Everyone looked at me.

I looked at Sophie.

She looked at her sheet of paper.

The one that said NO MYSTERIES.

"It's probably nothing," I said.

Noah nodded.

"That's what you said before Room 75."

THE PRINCIPAL'S ENVELOPE

The principal's office looked different.

The broken lock had been replaced. The old filing cabinet was gone. There was a new photograph on the wall showing everyone at the festival.

I was in the middle, holding Greg above my head.

The principal was at the edge, smiling nervously.

Some things had not changed.

"You wanted to see me?" I asked.

He held up a brown envelope.

"This arrived this morning."

My heart did a small jump.

A brown envelope is never just a brown envelope.

Sometimes it contains a test you forgot about.

Sometimes it contains a bill.

And sometimes it contains a clue that makes you spend two weeks underground.

The principal opened it.

Inside was a single sheet of paper.

He handed it to me.

At the top were the words:

CITY SCHOOLS REVIEW

Underneath, someone had typed:

Following recent concerns regarding finances, security, building safety, and student governance, Brookfield School will undergo a full review.

I read it again.

"Is this because of Mr. Harper?"

"Partly," the principal said.

"But we fixed the accounts."

"Yes."

"We found the cup."

"Yes."

"We stopped someone stealing festival money."

"Tim, I know what we did."

"Then why are we being reviewed?"

He sighed.

"Because the people at the city office only read reports. They do not see students chasing criminals through festivals or finding missing cups. They see a school with five years of confusing accounts, damaged buildings, and a head teacher who has written 'unusual student activity' in too many incident forms."

"That last one does sound bad when you say it."

"It sounded bad when I wrote it."

He took the paper back.

"The review begins next Monday. At the end of the term, the city will decide whether Brookfield should remain open in its current form."

I frowned.

"What does 'in its current form' mean?"

"It means they may merge us with Westbridge School."

For a second, I couldn't speak.

Westbridge was our biggest rival.

Their football team beat us almost every year.

Their science fair projects always had lights.

Their student council wore matching jackets.

And their leader, Lucas Stone, had once sent us a good-luck card before a tournament and then beaten us by thirty-two points.

"They can't merge us with Westbridge," I said.

"They can."

"What happens to our clubs?"

"I don't know."

"Our festival?"

"I don't know."

"Room 75?"

The principal gave me a look.

"That is not my biggest concern."

"But it's in the top ten, right?"

He put the envelope on his desk.

"The review is not a mystery for you to solve. It is a serious administrative process."

I nodded.

"Of course."

"There will be no investigating city officials."

"Understood."

"No entering offices without permission."

"Yes."

"No forming secret teams."

"Definitely not."

He narrowed his eyes.

"Why did you say that one so quickly?"

THE FIRST MEETING ABOUT THE END OF EVERYTHING

I called an emergency council meeting at lunch.

Sophie brought the folders.

Noah brought sandwiches.

Brad brought Frank.

I brought the bad news.

When I finished explaining, nobody spoke.

Then Noah raised his sandwich.

"So... if we fail the review, do we all have to wear Westbridge uniforms?"

"That is your first question?" Sophie asked.

"It's an important question."

Brad folded his arms.

"I'm not wearing their colours."

"We are not failing," I said.

Sophie looked at the review letter.

"We don't even know what the review measures."

"Then we find out."

"Tim, the principal told you not to investigate."

"He told me not to investigate city officials. He didn't say anything about reading the rules."

Sophie stared at me.

"I hate that you sometimes use logic."

I stood up.

"We have one term. We fix everything we can. We make the council better. We make the clubs better. We show them that Brookfield is worth keeping."

Noah lifted his sandwich again.

"And pizza Fridays?"

"If it helps."

Sophie pulled the large sheet of paper off the wall.

She turned it over and wrote:

SAVE BROOKFIELD

Underneath, she made four columns:

BUILDINGS. MONEY. CLUBS. STUDENT VOICE.

I pointed at the last one.

"That's us."

"They're all us," she said.

For the first time since the festival, I felt the familiar buzz in my stomach.

The feeling that something big was starting.

Then Greg pecked the review letter.

"Greg has identified the enemy," Noah said.

We laughed.

But when I looked at the words CITY SCHOOLS REVIEW again, I didn't feel like laughing.

We had saved one festival.

Now we had to save the whole school.

THE NOTE IN MY LOCKER

After school, I found a folded piece of paper in my locker.

Nobody saw me find it.

Nobody slipped it through the gap while I watched.

It was simply there, waiting under my maths book.

I almost threw it away.

After last term, paper in unexpected places usually meant trouble.

But I opened it.

The message was written in neat black ink.

ONE CUP WAS FOUND.

ONE SCHOOL REMAINS.

ASK THE FIRST HAWK WHAT WAS NEVER RETURNED.

Below the words was a small drawing of a hawk.

Not the old Black Hawks symbol.

This bird had its wings folded.

And underneath its feet was the number nine.

I read the message three times.

Then Noah appeared beside me.

"Normal term going well?" he asked.

I handed him the note.

He read it.

"Ah."

"Exactly."

"Does Sophie know?"

"Not yet."

"Does the principal know?"

"Not yet."

"Are we going to follow Rule 2 and not investigate alone?"

I folded the note.

"Definitely."

"Good."

I put it into my bag.

"First, we find Daniel."

Noah grinned.

"There it is."

"What?"

"The face you make when normal school is over."

I closed my locker.

The quietest Monday ever had lasted until 3:17 in the afternoon.

Which, for me, was probably a record.

CHAPTER 2

The First Hawk

Tuesday

Daniel Cross did not look like a former secret society member.

He looked like a man who owned too many sandwiches.

Noah and I found him at the community cafe after school. He was sitting at a corner table with a notebook, a cup of tea, and three unopened packets of biscuits.

"Emergency biscuits," he explained.

"Why three?" Noah asked.

"Because you came with him."

Daniel smiled at me.

I didn't.

The note was in my pocket, and its number nine seemed to be getting heavier.

Daniel had helped us understand the old Black Hawks. Five years earlier, he and six other students had tried to protect the school from Mr. Harper's plans. Their story had been hidden in photographs, tapes, old accounts, and Room 75.

If anyone knew what had never been returned, it was him.

I put the note on the table.

Daniel's smile disappeared.

He didn't touch it.

"Where did you get this?"

"My locker."

"Did anyone see who put it there?"

"No."

Noah reached for a biscuit.

Daniel moved the packet away.

"Those are emergency biscuits."

"This is an emergency," Noah said.

Daniel let him take one.

Then he read the note again.

"Ask the first hawk," he said quietly.

"That's you, right?" I asked.

"Yes."

"What wasn't returned?"

Daniel looked toward the window.

For a moment, I thought he was going to give us one of those long mysterious answers that sounds clever but explains absolutely nothing.

Instead, he opened his notebook.

"The Festival Cup was not the only thing we protected."

Noah stopped chewing.

I leaned forward.

Daniel turned to a blank page and drew a small rectangle.

"When we realised Harper was changing the accounts, we made copies. Emily kept the records. I kept the photographs. Another student kept the master list."

"What list?"

"Everything the school owned that had historical value. Cups. Banners. Old uniforms. The first festival programme. Documents from when Brookfield opened."

"Like an inventory?"

"More than that. It included letters from students and teachers. Promises about what the school was supposed to be."

Noah looked disappointed.

"So not treasure."

"Not everything valuable is treasure," Daniel said.

"That sounds like something a person says when there isn't treasure."

Daniel ignored him.

"We called it the Founders' Register."

I pointed to the note.

"And it wasn't returned?"

"No. After Harper discovered what we were doing, we hid things separately. The cup went missing. The accounts were scattered. The register disappeared."

"Who had it last?"

Daniel closed his notebook.

"Clara Bell."

THE EIGHTH NAME

I knew six of the old Black Hawks' names by then.

I had seen them in photographs and heard Daniel talk about them.

But Clara Bell was new.

"She wasn't on the list," I said.

"No."

"Was she the seventh Black Hawk?"

Daniel shook his head.

"She helped us, but she was never officially part of the group."

Noah brushed biscuit crumbs off his shirt.

"Secret clubs need better record keeping."

"We were fourteen," Daniel said.

"So are we. Sophie has a spreadsheet."

"Of course she does."

I pulled the note toward me.

"Where is Clara now?"

"That's the difficult part. She moved away after school. I haven't spoken to her in years."

"Did she take the register?"

"I don't think so. She cared about Brookfield more than anyone."

"Then why does the note say it was never returned?"

Daniel finally picked it up.

He studied the folded-wing hawk.

"Because this isn't about an object."

Noah sighed.

"Here comes the mysterious answer."

Daniel tapped the number nine.

"The Black Hawks had seven members. Emily wrote six rules for our group. The seventh was never written down."

"What was it?"

"Leave the school better than you found it."

I waited.

"That's seven," I said. "This says nine."

"Yes."

"Did Clara add two rules?"

"Clara believed the school charter had nine promises. She used to say the first eight were for the city, but the ninth was for the students."

The cafe door opened and a cold wind moved across the table.

Daniel lowered his voice.

"If someone is using that symbol, they know about Clara."

"Can you find her?"

"I can try."

I took out my phone.

"Tell us what you need."

Daniel gave me a serious look.

"You have a school review starting next week. You should focus on that."

"Saving the register could help the review."

"Or it could distract you from it."

"Why can't it do both?"

Noah nodded.

"Tim is very good at doing two dangerous things at once."

Daniel almost smiled.

Then he tore a page from his notebook and wrote an address.

"Clara's mother used to run the Brookfield second-hand bookshop. It closed years ago, but Clara still owns the building. Start there in daylight. Take Sophie. Do not enter if the building is locked."

Noah and I both nodded.

Daniel pointed at us.

"I mean actually locked. Not 'the door is stuck, so Brad climbs through a window' locked."

"That happened one time," I said.

"It hasn't happened to me yet. Please keep it that way."

SOPHIE'S CONDITIONS

Sophie agreed to come immediately.

Then she made us agree to six conditions.

No breaking in.

No lying to teachers.

No going alone.

No touching old electrical equipment.

No bringing rubber chickens.

No missing the council's review preparation meeting.

"That is a lot of conditions for one bookshop," Noah said.

"Those are general life conditions," she replied.

We met Brad outside school and explained everything.

He looked at Daniel's address.

"So tomorrow, we're going to an abandoned bookshop to find a missing book that might save the school?"

"Yes," I said.

"And I can't climb through a window?"

"No."

He thought about it.

"Can I bring Frank?"

"No," Sophie said.

Brad sighed.

"This club has changed."

THE CITY LETTER

Before I went home, the principal called me back into his office.

This time, Sophie was invited too.

A second letter had arrived.

The review would be led by a city schools director named Adrian Vane.

There was a photograph attached.

He had silver hair, a dark suit, and the expression of someone who had never lost a game of anything.

Under his photograph was a short statement.

Brookfield's future will be assessed according to measurable standards, not sentimental attachments.

Sophie read the line twice.

"He's talking about the festival."

"And the cup," I said.

"And everything else we did."

The principal nodded.

"Mr. Vane has already proposed a merger plan. Westbridge would become the main campus. Some Brookfield buildings would be sold."

I felt my face get hot.

"He decided before visiting?"

"He says it is only a proposal."

Sophie put the letter down.

"Then we'll give him evidence that changes his mind."

The principal looked at both of us.

"Good. Do it through the review. No shortcuts."

We promised.

Walking out, I thought about the Founders' Register.

Clara Bell.

The ninth promise.

And Adrian Vane's sentence about sentimental attachments.

For the first time, I wondered whether the review and the mystery were really two separate problems.

Or whether someone had started both at exactly the same time.

CHAPTER 3

The Bookshop With No Books

Wednesday

The old bookshop still had books in the window.

That was the first disappointing thing.

I had expected an empty building with cobwebs, broken floorboards, and at least one owl.

Instead, BELL'S BOOKS was painted in faded gold letters above a clean window. Inside the glass were three dictionaries, a plant, and a sign that said OPEN BY APPOINTMENT.

Sophie checked the address.

"Daniel said it closed years ago."

"It did close," a voice behind us said. "People simply refused to stop needing books."

We turned around.

A woman with short grey hair stood on the pavement carrying two shopping bags. She looked at us, then at Brad, who was wearing his sports kit and holding Frank under one arm.

Sophie stared at the chicken.

"You brought him?"

"He was already in my bag," Brad said.

"How was he already in your bag?"

"Long story."

The woman smiled.

"You must be Daniel's students."

"You know Daniel?" I asked.

"I know everyone who ever owed me a library fine."

She unlocked the door.

"I'm Clara Bell."

THE BACK ROOM

The shop was tiny.

Shelves covered every wall. Books were stacked under tables and between old display stands. It smelled like dust, tea, and the cardboard boxes my grandmother kept in her garage.

Clara led us into a back room.

There were no books there.

Only school photographs.

Hundreds of them.

Brookfield sports teams.

Festival stalls.

Teachers with strange hairstyles.

Students standing in front of the same front doors I walked through every morning.

Clara put her shopping bags down.

"Daniel called last night. He told me about the note."

"Do you have the Founders' Register?" I asked.

"No."

"Do you know where it is?"

"No."

Noah looked around.

"Is this where you tell us a mysterious answer?"

Clara laughed.

"No. I prefer useful answers."

She took a cardboard folder from a shelf.

Inside was a photocopy of an old document.

BROOKFIELD SCHOOL — OPENING CHARTER

There were eight numbered promises.

Safe classrooms.

A library.

Fair access to clubs.

A yearly festival.

Student representatives.

Care for school property.

Honest accounts.

A school that served its neighbourhood.

At the bottom, someone had typed a ninth line and then crossed it out so heavily that the words could not be read.

"There it is," I said.

Clara nodded.

"The ninth promise."

"Why was it removed?"

"Officially? It was repetitive. Unofficially? It made a promise the city didn't want to keep."

Sophie studied the page.

"What did it say?"

Clara looked at the crossed-out line.

"Brookfield shall not be closed, merged, or relocated while its students can demonstrate that the school still serves its community."

Nobody spoke.

Even Frank stopped moving.

I read it again.

"That's exactly what the review is about."

"Yes," Clara said.

"If we have the original charter with that promise—"

"It may not legally stop the merger," Sophie interrupted. "But it proves the school was founded with student consultation."

Clara smiled at her.

"You must be Sophie."

"Why?"

"Daniel said you would be the one to mention evidence instead of treasure."

Noah raised his hand.

"He said I would mention treasure."

Clara laughed again.

THE MISSING ORIGINAL

The photocopy was useless without the original.

Clara explained that the Founders' Register contained the original charter, letters, and records of student promises from the first year Brookfield opened.

She had hidden it shortly before leaving school.

"Where?" I asked.

"In the place where every student promise was made."

We waited.

She waited too.

Noah leaned toward me.

"She said she didn't do mysterious answers."

Clara heard him.

"I said I preferred useful answers. You haven't asked the useful question."

Sophie thought for a second.

"What happened on the day you hid it?"

Clara's expression changed.

"Harper was searching lockers. Daniel had already moved the cup. Emily was copying accounts. I had the register in my bag. I needed somewhere nobody would think to search."

"Room 75?" Brad asked.

"No. Everyone in our group knew about Room 75. I needed a place outside our plan."

She opened the cardboard folder again and removed a festival programme.

On the back was a handwritten list.

PROMISE DAY

1. Library reading

2. Council speeches

3. Festival stalls

4. Trophy presentation

5. Tree planting

"A tree?" I said.

"The founders planted a tree for every new school year. Students wrote promises and read them beside it."

Brookfield still had one enormous oak tree behind the sports field.

We played there at lunch.

Brad had once tried to climb it and got stuck.

Noah had eaten lunch beneath it almost every day.

"You hid a book under a tree?" he asked.

"Not under it," Clara said. "Near it. Inside the old promise box."

"There is no promise box."

"There was. A metal box attached to a stone marker. The marker may still be there."

I put the programme into my bag.

"We'll look after school."

Clara held up one finger.

"One more thing."

Of course.

"When I left the register, I sealed the box. Only a member of the current student council could open it without damaging the lock."

Brad frowned.

"How would a lock know?"

"It doesn't. It has the old council badge shape. You need the badge."

I reached into my pocket and pulled out my STUDENT COUNCIL LEADER badge.

Clara shook her head.

"Not that one. The original."

THE BADGE IN THE CUP

The original council badge had been missing for years.

But I knew something that had also been missing for years.

"The Festival Cup," I said.

Clara smiled.

"Daniel told me you were quick."

We called him from the shop.

He answered on the second ring.

"Did you find her?"

"Yes. Did you ever look underneath the base of the Festival Cup?"

There was a pause.

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because I was more focused on not getting caught."

Fair enough.

The cup was locked in the school display cabinet. We needed permission, a screwdriver, and probably six forms signed by Sophie.

Before we left, Clara stopped me.

"Tim."

"Yes?"

"The note you received. The folded-wing hawk wasn't our symbol."

"We know."

"It was mine."

I looked at her.

"Then who sent it?"

"That's what worries me. I only ever drew it on one thing."

She pointed to the photocopied charter.

"The cover of the Founders' Register."

Someone had seen the register.

Recently enough to draw the symbol.

And they wanted me to find it.

UNDER THE OAK

At 3:30, we stood behind the sports field with a garden trowel, the festival programme, and absolutely no official permission to dig.

Sophie checked the school's site plan on her phone.

"The stone marker should be here."

There was grass.

Lots of grass.

Noah turned in a circle.

"Maybe the tree ate it."

Brad pushed Frank into my arms.

"Hold him. I'll find it."

He walked to the oak and began tapping the ground with a stick.

I looked at Sophie.

"Are we investigating?"

"Yes."

"Without a secret name?"

"We can discuss names later."

Brad stopped near a patch of longer grass.

"Here."

Under the grass was a flat stone.

We brushed away mud and found nine small lines carved around its edge.

In the centre were the words:

WHAT WE PROMISE, WE BECOME.

Attached to the side was a metal box green with age.

Its lock was shaped like a tiny shield.

Exactly like the original council badge.

Noah grinned.

"Okay. That is pretty good treasure."

Sophie looked back toward the school.

"We need the cup."

I handed Frank to Noah.

"And we need to hurry."

Because across the field, a man in a dark suit was standing beside the principal.

Even from far away, I recognised the silver hair.

Adrian Vane had arrived five days early.

And he was watching us.

CHAPTER 4

Mr. Vane Arrives Early

Thursday

Mr. Vane did not like rubber chickens.

I learned this before he learned my name.

He was standing in the entrance hall on Thursday morning when Brad's bag started squeaking.

The sound came from inside it.

Squeak.

Pause.

Squeak.

Squeak.

Every student nearby turned around.

Brad kept walking.

Mr. Vane raised one eyebrow.

"Is there an animal in your bag?"

"No," Brad said.

Frank squeaked again.

Brad looked down.

"A very small one."

The principal appeared from his office.

"Mr. Vane, this is Brad, one of our student representatives."

Mr. Vane looked at Brad's bag.

"And is the chicken also a representative?"

"Frank is more of an adviser," I said.

Sophie kicked my shoe.

Mr. Vane turned to me.

"Tim, I presume."

"Yes."

He held out his hand.

I shook it.

His grip was firm, quick, and about as warm as the metal box under the oak.

"I have read a great deal about you."

"Good things?"

"Detailed things."

Noah appeared beside me.

"That's usually bad."

Mr. Vane's gaze moved to him.

"Noah."

Noah stopped smiling.

"He really has read the files."

The principal led us toward the hall.

Mr. Vane had asked to address the school before lessons.

Five minutes later, hundreds of students sat watching him straighten a sheet of paper on the lectern.

He didn't need a microphone.

His voice filled the room anyway.

THE PROPOSAL

"Brookfield has a proud history," he began.

That sounded nice.

It wasn't.

People who are about to change something always start by saying its history is proud.

"The city must decide how best to use its school buildings. Westbridge offers modern classrooms, improved sports facilities, and a larger student body. A merger could provide many advantages."

Students began whispering.

Mr. Vane continued.

"Over the coming weeks, I will assess academic performance, attendance, finances, safety, and student leadership. I expect full cooperation."

A hand went up near the front.

It belonged to Mia, one of the students who had helped during the festival.

"What happens to our clubs?"

"That would depend on demand."

"Our festival?"

"Traditions can be reviewed."

"Our council?"

"Westbridge already has an effective council."

More whispering.

Mr. Vane smiled slightly.

"Change can feel uncomfortable. But sentiment should not prevent improvement."

I felt Sophie tense beside me.

He wasn't here to discover whether Brookfield worked.

He was here to prove that Westbridge was better.

After assembly, students surrounded me in the corridor.

"Can he close the school?"

"Are we moving?"

"Do we get new lockers?"

"Will lunch be earlier?"

I answered none of the questions correctly because I didn't know.

Then Lucas Stone appeared.

LUCAS STONE

The Westbridge council leader wore a navy jacket with a silver badge.

Of course he did.

He was tall, neat, and smiling like he had already won something.

"Tim."

"Lucas."

"I heard about the review."

"You seem upset."

He laughed.

"I didn't write the proposal."

"But you knew about it."

"My council received a summary. We're preparing to welcome Brookfield students if the merger happens."

Sophie folded her arms.

"And if it doesn't?"

Lucas kept smiling.

"Then we'll see you at the City Schools Showcase."

Mr. Vane stepped beside him.

"An excellent point. The showcase takes place at the end of term. Each school presents its student leadership, community work, and plans for improvement. I have added it to the review criteria."

Lucas nodded.

"Westbridge has won three years in a row."

I looked at his silver badge.

"There's always a first time to lose."

Noah made a quiet noise that might have been a laugh or a cough.

Lucas leaned closer.

"This isn't a talent show, Tim. Weird noises won't be enough."

Then he walked away.

Brad cracked his knuckles.

"I can put Frank in his jacket."

"No," Sophie said.

"You didn't even let me finish."

"You were going to put Frank in his jacket."

She knew him too well.

THE CUP'S BASE

We had more important things than Lucas.

At lunch, the principal unlocked the display cabinet.

Mr. Vane stood nearby, reviewing papers.

He noticed us immediately.

"Why are you removing that trophy?"

"Student research," Sophie said.

That was technically true.

The principal placed the Festival Cup on his desk.

Daniel met us there. As an alumni volunteer, he could help without making the visit look suspicious.

At least, that was the plan.

Mr. Vane watched everything.

Daniel turned the cup over.

A small panel was screwed into the base.

Noah handed him a screwdriver.

"Please be a secret compartment," he whispered.

The screws turned slowly.

One.

Two.

Three.

Four.

The panel came loose.

Inside was a folded piece of cloth.

Daniel opened it.

A tarnished shield-shaped badge rested in the middle.

STUDENT COUNCIL — BROOKFIELD

Noah punched the air.

Mr. Vane looked up.

"What is that?"

"The original council badge," the principal said.

Daniel handed it to me.

The metal was cold and heavy.

Mr. Vane walked over.

"Why was it hidden inside a cup?"

"To keep it safe," I said.

"From whom?"

The room became quiet.

The principal answered for me.

"That is part of an old school matter. It has been resolved."

Mr. Vane looked at me.

"Many old matters seem to follow your council."

He wrote something in his notebook.

I wished I could see it.

Then he changed the subject.

"The review panel will visit your next council meeting. Please prepare a complete record of your current projects."

Sophie nodded.

I didn't.

Because at that moment I was thinking about the metal box, the charter, and the fact that Mr. Vane had arrived one day after the note appeared.

DIGGING IN PUBLIC

After school, we returned to the oak tree.

This time the principal came with us.

So did Clara.

Unfortunately, so did Mr. Vane.

"I am assessing student activity," he said.

"We're gardening," Noah replied.

He looked at the muddy trowel in Noah's hand.

"With a council badge?"

Nobody answered.

I slid the badge into the shield-shaped lock.

It fitted perfectly.

The lock clicked.

Noah whispered, "Yes."

Inside the box was a bundle wrapped in waxed cloth.

I lifted it out.

It was lighter than I expected.

Too light.

Clara's face changed.

I unwrapped the cloth.

There was no register.

Only a narrow key and another note.

The key had a small paper tag marked:

BPL — 009

The note read:

THE REGISTER HAS MOVED.

THE NINTH PROMISE IS STILL ALIVE.

DO NOT LET THE SCHOOL BE SOLD TWICE.

At the bottom was the folded-wing hawk.

Mr. Vane took the note before I could stop him.

He read it.

"What does 'sold twice' mean?"

"I don't know," I said.

It was true.

But Clara was staring at the key.

And Mr. Vane was staring at Clara.

For a split second, they looked like two people who recognised each other.

Then the moment vanished.

Mr. Vane folded the note.

"I will keep this as part of the review."

"No," I said.

Everyone looked at me.

I held out my hand.

"It's addressed to the student council. You can have a copy."

Sophie nodded.

"We'll make one immediately."

Mr. Vane's mouth tightened.

Then he handed it back.

"Very well. A copy."

The principal took the key.

"And I will keep this in the office safe."

As we walked inside, Clara moved beside me.

"BPL means Brookfield Public Library," she whispered.

"Do you know what 009 is?"

"No. But the library archive opens on Saturday."

I looked ahead at Mr. Vane.

He was speaking quietly to Lucas on his phone.

I only heard one sentence.

"They found the key."

My stomach turned.

Noah saw my face.

"What happened?"

"He knows."

"About the key?"

"About everything."

Sophie stopped walking.

"Then Saturday can't wait."

But it had to.

And by Saturday morning, the library archive would be gone.

CHAPTER 5

The Empty Archive

Friday

The library did not burn down.

It did not flood.

Nobody stole the building.

When we arrived on Friday afternoon, Mrs. Patel, the librarian, simply told us that Archive 009 had been collected that morning.

"By whom?" Sophie asked.

"A city records team."

My stomach dropped.

"Was Mr. Vane with them?"

"He signed the collection order."

Noah looked at me.

"I hate being right before bad things happen."

We stood between shelves of returned books while Mrs. Patel searched her computer.

Clara had come with us. Daniel was parking outside. Brad had wanted to come, but Sophie said four students and a former Black Hawk were enough for one library desk.

Mrs. Patel frowned at the screen.

"Nine boxes were transferred to Westbridge's records centre. The order says 'temporary storage during Brookfield review.'"

"Can we get them back?" I asked.

"Not without city permission."

"Can we see what was inside?"

She turned the monitor.

There was a list.

Most of it was ordinary.

Old newspapers.

Council minutes.

Building plans.

School magazines.

At the bottom was one item with no description.

BPL-009/77 — RESTRICTED

Clara leaned closer.

"That wasn't there before."

"You know the archive?" Sophie asked.

"I used to volunteer here. Box nine held the founders' documents. There was no item seventy-seven."

I thought about the narrow key.

It was still in the principal's safe.

Whatever item seventy-seven was, someone had moved it before we could look.

Mrs. Patel printed the collection record.

At the bottom, beneath Mr. Vane's signature, was a second name.

L. STONE — STUDENT RECORDS ASSISTANT

"Lucas," I said.

Sophie's jaw tightened.

"He knew before assembly."

Noah shook his head.

"Westbridge has student records assistants? Do their students get jobs before they finish being students?"

Clara didn't laugh.

She was looking at the collection time.

9:05 a.m.

Mr. Vane had signed the order before he watched us open the promise box.

He didn't need to see the key.

He already knew where it led.

A REASONABLE PLAN

Sophie made me promise not to do anything stupid.

This was difficult because she would not define stupid until after I suggested something.

"We are not breaking into Westbridge," she said.

"I didn't say we should."

"You were thinking it."

"I was thinking about asking to visit."

Noah nodded.

"With our faces and everything."

"We have a legitimate reason. The archive belongs to Brookfield's history. We request supervised access."

Clara agreed.

Mrs. Patel offered to submit the request.

It would take three working days.

"The showcase preparation starts Monday," Sophie said. "We can't spend the weekend waiting."

So we did something almost as strange as breaking into Westbridge.

We worked on the review.

THE SCHOOL WE COULD PROVE

On Saturday morning, the council room looked like a paperwork explosion.

Sophie had created five folders.

Attendance.

Clubs.

Community.

Finances.

Student projects.

Brad was counting sports equipment.

Noah was interviewing students about why Brookfield mattered.

I was supposed to write the council introduction.

After twenty minutes, I had written:

BROOKFIELD IS GOOD BECAUSE IT IS OURS.

Sophie read it.

"No."

"Why?"

"Because Adrian Vane will frame that sentence and use it to prove we have no evidence."

She was right.

We needed facts.

Mia came in carrying attendance sheets.

"The homework club has doubled since January."

Ethan brought the festival accounts.

"Every expense is recorded. Every receipt is there."

Kyle arrived with photographs from the community clean-up.

Brad reported that the sports shed had one broken door, three flat footballs, and enough cones to build a small orange house.

"Can we say sports are improving?" he asked.

"No," Sophie said.

"Can we say we have cones?"

"No."

By lunch, the evidence wall was filling up.

For the first time, the review looked less like a speech and more like a story.

Not a story about a perfect school.

A story about a school that fixed things.

Noah stuck up his interview notes.

One Year Seven said Brookfield mattered because her older brother had gone there.

A teacher said the homework club helped students who had nowhere quiet to work.

The dinner staff said the festival raised money for the community kitchen.

One student wrote:

I LIKE THAT EVEN THE WEIRD KIDS GET TO DO IMPORTANT THINGS.

Noah pointed at it.

"I assume that means me."

"It means all of us," I said.

THE FIRST COUNCIL SHOWCASE

On Monday, Mr. Vane entered our meeting with two panel members and Lucas.

We had prepared chairs, agendas, and a chicken-free room.

Frank and Greg were locked in Brad's sports locker.

I could still hear occasional squeaking, but Mr. Vane pretended not to notice.

Sophie presented our folders.

Mia explained the homework club.

Ethan showed the festival accounts.

I spoke about the council elections, the festival, and the changes we had made.

I did not mention secret rooms.

Or dying-printer noises.

Or hitting things with rubber chickens.

Mr. Vane listened without smiling.

When we finished, he asked one question.

"How much of this improvement depends on you personally?"

I didn't understand.

"On me?"

"Your leadership. Your friendships. Your rather unusual methods. If you left tomorrow, would these systems continue?"

Sophie opened her mouth, but he raised a hand.

"I would like Tim to answer."

I looked around the table.

Everyone was watching.

A term ago, I would have said yes immediately.

Not because it was true, but because I liked the sound of being important.

Now I thought about Sophie's folders.

Mia's attendance sheets.

Ethan's receipts.

Noah's interviews.

Brad's ridiculous cone count.

"No," I said. "Not all of it depends on me. That's the point. We built jobs for other people. The council isn't one student."

Mr. Vane wrote something down.

Lucas looked almost disappointed.

Then Mr. Vane asked Sophie for the original financial records.

She handed him copies.

He asked for our review calendar.

She gave him a colour-coded schedule.

He asked who had checked the evidence.

"All of us," she said.

For the first time, he looked slightly annoyed.

Good.

THE RETURN REQUEST

At the end of the meeting, Mrs. Patel called.

Our request to view Archive 009 had been approved.

Wednesday.

Westbridge records centre.

One hour.

Supervised.

I felt relieved until she added the condition.

"Only two students may attend. Mr. Vane selected the names."

"Who?" I asked.

"You and Lucas Stone."

Noah nearly dropped his interview folder.

"That's not supervision. That's a trap with a visitor badge."

Sophie agreed, but there was no time to appeal.

I would go.

Lucas would be there.

And somewhere in nine boxes of Brookfield history was item seventy-seven, waiting behind a lock shaped for the key in our office.

That evening, I found another note in my bag.

I had checked my bag at lunch.

This one had appeared during the council meeting.

The paper showed a photocopy of an old key tag.

BPL-009/77.

Below it, someone had written:

HE DOESN'T WANT THE REGISTER.

HE WANTS THE DEED INSIDE IT.

At the bottom, instead of a hawk, there was a drawing of the school.

A line crossed through it.

On the other side stood a building with the Westbridge logo.

I turned the note over.

There was one final sentence.

ASK YOUR PRINCIPAL WHO SOLD BROOKFIELD THE FIRST TIME.

I looked toward the principal's office.

The light was still on.

For five years, he had kept a secret about Room 75.

Now I had to ask him for another one.

And I was running out of reasons to trust the adults who said a mystery was already solved.

CHAPTER 6

The Principal's Second Secret

Tuesday

The principal did not say, "I don't know what you're talking about."

That was how I knew he knew exactly what we were talking about.

He read the note, closed his office blinds, and sat down.

Sophie stood beside me.

Noah stood near the door as if he expected someone to listen through it.

"Who sold Brookfield the first time?" I asked.

The principal rubbed his eyes.

"Nobody sold the school."

"The note says—"

"I know what the note says. It is using an old argument to make you suspicious."

"Is it working?" Noah asked.

Sophie elbowed him.

The principal opened a drawer and removed a folder marked LAND TRANSFER — 1986.

"Brookfield was originally built on land donated by the Bell family. Years later, the city rearranged several school sites. Part of our land was transferred to the council, and another section was leased back."

Clara Bell's family.

The bookshop.

The founders' charter.

It all connected.

"Why would Mr. Vane want a deed?" I asked.

"Because the original donation agreement may contain restrictions on how the land can be used."

Sophie understood first.

"If the land was donated only for a neighbourhood school, he can't simply sell it."

"Exactly," the principal said. "But without the original document, the restriction is difficult to prove."

Noah looked at the folder.

"So the school isn't being sold twice. The land is."

The principal nodded.

"Perhaps."

I hated perhaps.

Perhaps meant adults had more information but weren't ready to call it an answer.

"Did Clara know?"

"Her family knew."

"Does Mr. Vane know?"

"He was a junior city officer when the last land review happened."

I put the note on his desk.

"Then this isn't just a student mystery."

"No."

"And you still want us to stay out of it?"

The principal looked at me for a long time.

"I want you to stop treating every locked door as a personal challenge."

"That wasn't an answer."

"It was the only one you need."

THE WESTBRIDGE INVITATION

My visit to Westbridge was scheduled for Wednesday afternoon.

By Wednesday morning, everyone had advice.

Sophie gave me a list of questions.

Noah told me not to eat anything Lucas offered.

Brad told me to take Frank.

Daniel told me to photograph every box label.

Clara told me to look for her family's initials.

The principal told me not to open anything without permission.

Even my mother had advice.

"Be polite."

"Why does everyone think I won't be polite?"

Noah raised his hand.

"Because you told Lucas there would be a first time for him to lose."

"That was polite. I didn't mention his jacket."

Westbridge looked exactly like its brochures.

New windows.

Clean walls.

A digital sign that welcomed visitors by name.

Mine was spelled correctly, which felt unfriendly.

Lucas met me at reception.

"Ready to see how a real council works?"

"Ready to see our archive."

He smiled.

"Always straight to the mystery."

A woman from the city records office supervised us. Her name was Mrs. Doyle. She gave me a visitor badge, checked the principal's key against the collection record, and led us downstairs.

The records centre was dry, bright, and extremely organised.

Nine boxes waited on a table.

BROOKFIELD PUBLIC LIBRARY — ARCHIVE 009.

"One hour," Mrs. Doyle said.

Lucas sat opposite me.

I opened the first box.

Newspapers.

The second.

School magazines.

The third.

Building plans.

Everything smelled like old paper.

I worked faster.

Box four held council minutes from 1962.

Box five contained photographs of the original library.

Box six was full of festival programmes.

Box seven contained maps.

Box eight held a folder marked BELL DONATION — COPIES.

Lucas watched me pull it out.

"Find something?"

"Not yet."

The copies described the land but did not include the final signed page.

Then I opened box nine.

It was empty.

ITEM SEVENTY-SEVEN

"Where is it?" I asked.

Mrs. Doyle checked her list.

"BPL-009/77 was removed during cataloguing."

"By whom?"

She looked uncomfortable.

"Mr. Vane."

Lucas stopped smiling.

Just for a second.

I noticed.

"Did you know?" I asked him.

"He said some items were being checked."

"Did you help collect these boxes?"

"I signed the student assistance form."

"Did you see a register?"

"No."

He answered too quickly.

Mrs. Doyle called Mr. Vane.

He arrived ten minutes later with a thin document case.

"The item is a legal record," he said. "It is not suitable for unsupervised student research."

"You approved this visit," I said.

"To the archive. Not to restricted city documents."

"The archive belongs to Brookfield."

"Currently, it belongs to the city."

He placed the document case on the table but did not open it.

I could see a metal clasp.

It matched the narrow key.

"That key came from our school."

Mr. Vane looked at Mrs. Doyle.

She nodded.

He held out his hand.

"Then I suppose we should see what it opens."

The principal had trusted me with the key for the visit.

I took it from its protective envelope.

My hand was shaking.

Not because I was scared.

Because Mr. Vane seemed too willing.

I inserted the key.

It turned.

Inside was a single sheet of paper and a photograph.

The paper was a copy of the Bell land donation.

The final page.

The restriction was clear.

The land shall continue to serve as a neighbourhood school unless the duly elected student representatives and community members agree otherwise.

Sophie had been right.

Mr. Vane couldn't simply sell it.

Then I saw the photograph.

It showed seven students beside the oak tree.

Daniel.

Emily.

Clara.

Four others.

And behind them stood a younger Adrian Vane.

He wasn't wearing a city suit.

He was wearing a Brookfield teacher's jacket.

"You taught here?" I asked.

"For one year."

"Were you involved with the Black Hawks?"

"No."

But on the back of the photograph, written in faded ink, were eight initials.

The last two were A.V.

Lucas read them over my shoulder.

For once, he had nothing clever to say.

THE EMPTY SPACE

I photographed the deed and both sides of the photograph.

Mr. Vane allowed it.

That worried me more than if he had refused.

"Where is the Founders' Register?" I asked.

"I have never seen it."

"Then why did you remove this?"

"Because a property review requires property documents."

"Did you write the notes?"

"No."

"Do you know who did?"

He closed the document case.

"Your visit is over."

Lucas walked me outside.

Without Mr. Vane beside him, he looked less confident.

"Did you know he taught at Brookfield?" I asked.

"No."

"Did you know about the deed?"

"No."

"Would you tell me if you did?"

Lucas stopped at the gate.

"No."

At least he was honest.

Then he added something unexpected.

"My dad works with the development company that wants the site."

I stared at him.

"What company?"

"Stonebridge Learning Group."

"Stonebridge?"

"Named before the merger proposal. It's a coincidence."

"Do you actually believe that?"

He looked back at the modern windows.

"I believe Westbridge is a good school."

"So is Brookfield."

For a moment, we weren't rivals.

We were two students standing between schools that adults were moving around like furniture.

Lucas lowered his voice.

"Check the photograph dates."

"Why?"

"Because Mr. Vane said he taught there one year. The staff records say two."

Then he walked away.

I had come looking for a register.

Instead, I had found a deed, an eighth Black Hawk, and a reason to wonder whether Lucas was helping me or leading me somewhere.

Both possibilities were bad.

But the second one was more interesting.

CHAPTER 7

The Eighth Black Hawk

Thursday

Daniel dropped the photograph.

Not literally.

Former Black Hawks probably practised not dropping evidence.

But when I showed him the picture on my phone, his hand jerked hard enough to spill tea on the cafe table.

"Adrian Vane," he said.

"You remember him?"

"Yes."

"Was he the eighth Black Hawk?"

Daniel grabbed a napkin.

"There was no eighth Black Hawk."

Noah pointed to the initials.

"There is literally an A.V."

"He wanted to join."

Daniel said it so quietly I almost missed it.

Emily sat across from us. She had come as soon as Daniel called.

She looked at the photograph and shook her head.

"He wasn't a student. He was a trainee teacher."

"Why are his initials on the back?" I asked.

"Because he took the photograph."

Noah frowned.

"If he took it, why is he in it?"

Emily turned the phone over as if the answer might be on the back of my case.

"Timer camera," Daniel said. "He insisted on being in the picture."

The tea spread toward the emergency biscuits.

Noah rescued them.

Daniel continued.

"Adrian taught history. He knew Clara's family and became interested in the charter. When Harper started changing things, Adrian offered to help."

"Did he?"

"At first. He gave us information about city meetings. Then he told us to hand over the evidence."

"To him?"

"To the city, he said. We didn't trust him."

Emily took over.

"Clara discovered he had copied our list. He knew about the register, the cup, and Room 75. We stopped meeting with him. Soon afterwards, Harper found our first hiding place."

My mouth went dry.

"You think he told Harper."

"I think secrets have a way of reaching people who want them," Emily said.

Not a yes.

Not a no.

Another perhaps.

THE TEACHER WHO DISAPPEARED

Adrian Vane's two years at Brookfield had been reduced to one in his official city record.

Daniel remembered the second year clearly.

"He returned as a temporary administrative assistant. He worked on building plans and land records."

"Then he left?"

"After the Black Hawks broke up."

Noah ate an emergency biscuit.

"So he spent two years trying to find the register, failed, and has now come back with a merger plan."

"That's my suspicion," Daniel said.

I looked at Emily.

"Why didn't you tell us about him last term?"

"Because last term was about Harper. Adrian had been gone for years. I didn't think he mattered."

"People should make a list of everyone who might matter later."

Emily gave me a tired smile.

"We were students, Tim."

"So are we. We have spreadsheets."

She laughed, but Daniel didn't.

He was still looking at the crossed-out photograph.

"Adrian believes rules are only useful when powerful people write them. The ninth promise gives power to students. He would hate it."

"Can he destroy the register if he finds it?"

"Not if you make the evidence public first."

That became our plan.

Find the register.

Copy everything.

Share it with the school and community.

Prove Brookfield still served its neighbourhood.

And win the City Schools Showcase for good measure.

Noah wrote a list.

1. Find old book.

2. Save school.

3. Beat Lucas.

4. Lunch.

Sophie would have moved lunch higher, but she wasn't there.

SOPHIE'S BAD NEWS

Sophie missed the meeting because Mr. Vane had asked her to attend a student leadership interview.

When she returned, her face was pale.

"He has my council records."

"Copies?" I asked.

"Originals. He requested them after our meeting."

"Everything?"

"Agendas. Budget drafts. Election records. Even the first list I made before you became leader."

Noah looked impressed.

"He has evidence of how bad we were?"

"Yes."

I sat down.

"Can he use it against us?"

"He already did. He asked why our first fundraiser lacked receipts, why Brad attended only half the meetings, and why one agenda says 'Noah snack investigation.'"

"That was a real investigation," Noah said.

Sophie ignored him.

"He also asked whether the school would be safer under an experienced council like Westbridge's."

I felt anger rise in my chest.

"What did you say?"

"I said an experienced council should be able to answer questions without needing its director in the room."

Daniel raised his eyebrows.

Noah clapped once.

Sophie didn't look proud.

"He told me confidence is not evidence."

She put a sheet of paper on the table.

It was a report titled STUDENT GOVERNANCE RISK.

Under weaknesses, Mr. Vane had written:

Over-reliance on informal friendship groups.

Insufficient separation between social and council activities.

Repeated involvement in unauthorised investigations.

At the bottom was a recommendation.

Temporary replacement of Brookfield student officers during review.

"He wants to remove us," I said.

"He wants to remove you," Sophie replied. "The report names me as a possible interim leader if I cooperate."

The room went silent.

Sophie looked directly at me.

"I said no."

I nodded.

"Thank you."

"But, Tim, we need to stop giving him reasons. No more running around after notes during school. No more secret meetings without telling the principal. We win the review by being better than his report."

She was right.

I knew she was right.

Then my phone buzzed.

A message from an unknown number.

WESTBRIDGE BASEMENT. ROOM B2. TONIGHT. THE REGISTER IS THERE.

Noah read it over my shoulder.

Sophie saw our faces.

"No."

"We haven't said anything," I said.

"You don't have to."

She took my phone.

"We verify the message. We tell Daniel. We do not go tonight."

THE VERIFIED LIE

Daniel called Westbridge's caretaker.

He was an old Brookfield parent and agreed to check room B2.

It was a cleaning cupboard.

No register.

No files.

No secret door.

Just mops.

The message had been designed to make us trespass.

If we had gone, Mr. Vane's report would have gained a perfect new paragraph.

Sophie didn't say, "I told you so."

She just wrote UNKNOWN SENDER beside the message and filed it under evidence.

That was worse.

At home, I realised something.

The person sending notes knew our next moves.

They knew about the archive.

They knew we would be tempted by a message.

They had sent the first note before Mr. Vane arrived.

What if the notes weren't helping us find the register?

What if they were helping someone watch how we searched?

I called Daniel.

"Clara's symbol was on the register cover," I said. "Who else saw it?"

"Adrian. Harper. Emily. Me."

"Anyone else?"

There was a long pause.

"Lucas's father."

I sat up.

"How?"

"He was a parent governor. He helped with a building survey before everything happened."

Lucas's father.

Stonebridge Learning Group.

Mr. Vane.

The development plan.

The mystery wasn't getting bigger.

It was getting smaller.

And the people inside it were standing very close together.

CHAPTER 8

Operation Normal Council

Friday

Sophie called it Operation Normal Council.

Noah called it Operation Boring Name.

The plan was simple.

For two weeks, we would do exactly what an excellent student council was supposed to do.

Meet.

Listen.

Plan.

Help.

Keep receipts.

No running across fields with old keys.

No questioning former teachers in cafes.

No attempting to read other people's notebooks upside down.

I lasted eleven minutes.

At 8:11 on Friday morning, a Year Eight student named Oliver came to the council room with a problem.

"Someone removed our chess club from the activities board."

Sophie picked up a pen.

"Was the club cancelled?"

"No. The room booking disappeared too."

"Who has access?"

"Mr. Vane's review team. They're checking room use."

I leaned forward.

"Why would a review team cancel chess?"

Sophie gave me a warning look.

I leaned back.

Oliver continued.

"They said Room 14 needs to stay empty for building assessments."

Room 14 was beside the library.

It had a stained ceiling, six wobbly chairs, and a cupboard nobody could open.

Of course it was involved.

Sophie offered to find the chess club a new room.

I offered to inspect Room 14.

Sophie offered to expel me from Operation Normal Council.

I agreed to inspect the available classrooms instead.

THE CHESS CLUB RELOCATION

We moved chess club into the dining hall annex.

Then the drama club lost its room.

Then the coding club's laptops were moved for an inventory.

Then the basketball team discovered that Westbridge students had booked our sports field for a joint practice.

Each decision was small.

Each one had a sensible explanation.

Together, they made our clubs feel like guests in their own school.

At lunch, Sophie spread the room changes across her desk.

"He's disrupting our activities before measuring them."

"Can you prove it?"

"No."

"Can we stop it?"

"Yes. We make the clubs impossible to ignore."

That afternoon, we launched Brookfield Open Week.

Every club would run an event.

Students, families, and neighbours could visit.

The chess club would hold a tournament.

The drama club would perform.

The coding club would demonstrate games.

The sports teams would run challenges.

The cooking club would sell food.

Even the gardening club joined, although Brad asked whether watching plants grow counted as an event.

Noah designed posters.

They said:

BROOKFIELD IS OPEN. COME BEFORE IT ISN'T.

Sophie changed the second sentence to:

DISCOVER WHAT OUR COMMUNITY MEANS TO US.

Noah said his version had more urgency.

Sophie said his version looked like a closing-down sale.

I agreed with both and walked away before they asked me to choose.

THE EMPTY ROOM

Open Week took over my life.

I visited clubs after school.

I carried chairs.

I tested microphones.

I learned that chess clocks are more complicated than they look.

I also learned that helping people is slower than investigating mysteries and involves far more forms.

On Tuesday afternoon, Oliver asked me to collect chessboards from Room 14.

The building assessment had finished.

The room was unlocked.

I went alone because it was only twenty steps from the council room and I was carrying a permission slip.

Inside, the cupboard door stood open.

The one nobody could open.

There were no chessboards inside.

There was a loose section of wall.

And a rectangular patch of dust where something had recently been removed.

I did not touch it.

This was growth.

I took a photograph and called Sophie.

She arrived with the principal and Mr. Vane.

Mr. Vane looked at the cupboard.

"My assessors found damaged panelling. It was made safe."

"What was inside?" I asked.

"Nothing."

"There's a dust mark."

"From stored equipment."

"Where is the equipment?"

"Disposed of."

The principal examined the wall.

"Did the assessors find any documents?"

"No."

Mr. Vane answered immediately.

Too immediately.

I looked at the floor.

A tiny triangle of paper was trapped beneath the cupboard's foot.

Sophie saw it too.

While Mr. Vane explained disposal policies, she crouched and pulled it free with tweezers.

It was part of a page number.

— 9 —

And a line of typed text.

... representatives of the student body shall...

The ninth promise.

Mr. Vane stopped talking.

For once, he couldn't claim the paper was imaginary.

Sophie placed it in an evidence sleeve.

"Room 14 contained the register."

"Or one page," the principal said.

"Recently," I added.

Mr. Vane's face remained blank.

"Then your assessors will be eager to cooperate with the review."

He walked out.

I looked at Sophie.

"That was a threat, right?"

"Yes."

"Good. For a second I thought we were becoming friends."

THE OPEN WEEK DISASTER

On Thursday, everything went wrong.

The drama club's backdrop tore.

The coding club lost Wi-Fi.

The chess tournament schedule was printed with the wrong times.

The cooking club received forty vegetarian pies labelled beef and forty beef pies labelled vegetarian.

The sports field sprinkler turned on during setup.

Noah stood in the mud holding a poster.

"Operation Normal Council is going great."

None of the problems proved sabotage.

Old backdrop.

School Wi-Fi.

Printing mistake.

Labelling mistake.

Timer fault.

But all on the same day?

Sophie moved through the chaos giving instructions.

"Drama, use the blue curtains. Coding, download the offline versions. Chess, handwrite new boards. Cooking, cover the labels and list ingredients clearly. Brad, turn off the sprinkler."

"How?"

"Find out."

I started with the microphone.

It didn't work.

Of course.

Visitors would arrive in forty minutes.

I had spent weeks learning how to be a normal council leader.

Now I needed to be the other kind.

I climbed onto a chair.

"Everyone listen!"

Nobody did.

I picked up Greg from Brad's bag and squeezed him.

SQUEEEEEEAK.

The hall went silent.

"Thank you. We have forty minutes. Stop fixing your own problem by yourself. Pair up. Drama helps coding. Cooking helps chess. Sports team, move everything off the wet field. If you need an adult, find one. If you need a chair, ask before taking it."

Noah raised his hand.

"Can I take a chair without asking?"

"No."

"Just checking."

Everyone moved.

Sophie smiled at me.

It was a small smile, but it meant a lot.

"That was leadership," she said.

"Greg helped."

"Greg can have an assistant badge."

By four o'clock, the school was ready.

Then the front doors opened and Mr. Vane walked in with the review panel.

Behind them came Lucas and six Westbridge students.

And behind them, carrying a large cardboard box, was Mrs. Doyle from the records centre.

The label on the box read:

BROOKFIELD FOUNDERS' DOCUMENTS — DISPOSAL APPROVED.

My microphone chose that moment to start working.

It screamed so loudly that everyone covered their ears.

Except Mr. Vane.

He just looked at the box.

And smiled.

CHAPTER 9

Brookfield Is Open

Friday

The disposal box contained old copies.

Not the register.

Not the deed.

Not anything worth saving, according to Mr. Vane.

He explained this while I stood on a chair holding a rubber chicken.

It was not my strongest leadership image.

Mrs. Doyle looked embarrassed.

"These were identified as duplicates. The disposal label is automatic."

Sophie asked for the disposal list.

Mr. Vane handed it over.

Everything matched.

Another sensible explanation.

Another reason we could not accuse him of anything.

Then the visitors arrived, and I stopped caring about the box for a while.

THE SCHOOL IN ACTION

By five o'clock, Brookfield was full.

Parents played chess in the dining hall.

Students performed short scenes in the corridor because the stage curtains were still being repaired.

The coding club demonstrated a game where a hawk delivered books to a library.

Noah called it historically accurate.

The cooking club sold every correctly labelled pie.

The gardening club gave away small plants in paper pots.

Brad ran a basketball challenge and somehow persuaded Mr. Vane to take a shot.

He missed.

Frank squeaked.

I decided not to record the score.

I spent the evening moving between rooms with a clipboard.

At first, I tried to make everything look perfect.

Then I realised the visitors weren't looking for perfect.

They were watching students solve problems.

A Year Seven helped an elderly neighbour use the coding club's laptop.

Mia translated instructions for a parent who had never visited the school before.

Ethan explained the homework club's budget to two city panel members.

Oliver checkmated Lucas in nine moves.

That last one was especially satisfying.

Lucas stared at the board.

"Again."

Oliver reset the pieces.

"Club membership costs two pounds."

Lucas paid.

Perhaps Westbridge and Brookfield could survive each other after all.

THE COMMUNITY WALL

Sophie had placed a large sheet of paper near the entrance.

It said:

WHAT DOES BROOKFIELD MEAN TO YOU?

By six o'clock, there was no empty space left.

Messages overlapped in different handwriting.

My first friend.

My mother's classroom.

The only club where I wasn't weird.

Hot lunches.

The festival.

A place to start again.

The oak tree.

Teachers who noticed.

One note simply said:

NINE PROMISES. KEEP THEM ALL.

I showed Sophie.

"Same handwriting?"

She compared it with the locker note.

"Similar. Not exact."

Noah joined us.

"Maybe we have more than one mysterious person."

"Great," I said. "A mysterious group."

"Like the Black Hawks?"

"Not helpful, Noah."

But he was right.

What if the notes weren't from one person?

What if someone was passing them between students?

That explained how one appeared during a supervised meeting.

It also meant the sender might be inside the school.

THE REGISTER PAGE

Near closing time, Clara arrived with Mrs. Patel.

They carried a wooden display frame from the public library.

Inside was Brookfield's first festival programme.

Clara placed it on the community table.

"People should remember what the school was built for."

Visitors gathered around.

She told stories about the original neighbourhood.

About students raising money for the library.

About the Bell family donating land so children could walk to school.

About a promise that the school would remain theirs as long as they proved it served the community.

Mr. Vane stood at the back.

He did not interrupt.

When Clara finished, an old man in a brown coat raised his hand.

"I was here when that tree was planted."

Clara recognised him.

"Mr. Okafor?"

He smiled.

"You were the girl who kept correcting the speeches."

"That sounds like Clara."

The old man looked at the frame.

"The programme isn't complete."

Clara frowned.

"What do you mean?"

"There was a second page. We printed the promises on one side and the land agreement on the other."

"Do you have it?"

"No. I gave my copy to the school."

"Where?"

He pointed toward the display cabinet.

"The time capsule."

Everyone turned.

There was a small brass capsule at the bottom of the cabinet, used to hold programmes from recent festivals.

I had walked past it hundreds of times.

The principal unlocked it.

Inside were photographs, a school badge, three coins, and a rolled programme.

Sophie put on gloves.

She unrolled it carefully.

The second page was there.

Eight promises.

The ninth, crossed out.

And on the back, a partial copy of the land agreement.

Not enough to prove everything.

Enough to prove Mr. Okafor's memory was right.

Then something fell from inside the roll.

A key tag.

WESTBRIDGE B2.

Noah looked at me.

"The cleaning cupboard."

This time, there was a key attached.

THE CUPBOARD WE DIDN'T ENTER

We did not go to Westbridge.

We did not sneak out.

We did not even touch the key after photographing it.

Sophie called Mrs. Doyle.

Daniel called the Westbridge caretaker.

The principal called Mr. Vane into his office and asked him to witness the entire conversation.

The caretaker opened B2 on speakerphone.

"Mops," he said.

We waited.

"Buckets."

More waiting.

"And an old panel behind the shelves."

Daniel closed his eyes.

"Don't move anything. We'll arrange a supervised visit tomorrow."

Mr. Vane agreed.

He had no choice with six adults listening.

The next morning, behind the shelves, they found a metal document box.

Inside was not the full register.

It was a bundle of council minutes from five years ago.

The minutes recorded a meeting between Adrian Vane, Mr. Harper, and a development consultant named Richard Stone.

Lucas's father.

The subject was:

FUTURE USE OF BROOKFIELD SITE.

The final line read:

Student objections to be managed through closure of informal groups and removal of historical materials.

The Black Hawks hadn't broken up because they lost interest.

They had been deliberately stopped.

And now, five years later, the same three names were connected to the review.

Mr. Vane read the minutes without speaking.

I expected him to deny them.

Instead, he said, "This document is not authenticated."

Clara stepped forward.

"Then let's authenticate it in public."

She pointed to the community wall outside.

Hundreds of messages.

Hundreds of people who had come through the doors.

"At the showcase."

For the first time, Mr. Vane looked worried.

Not much.

Just enough.

CHAPTER 10

The First Setback

Monday

Winning feels best right before everything goes wrong.

On Monday morning, the local newspaper published a story about Brookfield Open Week.

There was a photograph of the crowded hall.

A quote from Clara about the ninth promise.

A paragraph about the community wall.

Even Greg appeared in the background.

For two hours, I felt unstoppable.

Then the attendance report arrived.

Brookfield's attendance had dropped.

Not much.

One point eight percent.

But Mr. Vane's review thresholds were exact.

We were now below the required level.

A water leak closed six classrooms.

A flu bug spread through Year Eight.

Two buses broke down on Friday.

None of it was the council's fault.

It still appeared in the same column.

UNSATISFACTORY.

At lunch, Mr. Vane announced that the city had paused all discretionary spending at Brookfield.

The coding club couldn't replace its damaged laptops.

The sports shed door stayed broken.

The drama club's new curtains were cancelled.

And the student council budget was frozen.

Noah looked at his empty sandwich bag.

"Can they freeze lunch?"

"No," Sophie said.

"Just checking."

OUR OWN MONEY

We needed money.

Again.

Last term, fundraising had involved a school festival, a mystery, and several bad ideas.

This time, we had no budget and a review panel watching every receipt.

Sophie proposed a sponsored read.

Noah proposed selling pizza.

Brad proposed a rubber-chicken tournament with an entry fee.

I proposed combining all three.

Sophie put her head in her hands.

"One event. One clear budget."

We chose a community sponsored read.

Students would collect sponsors for every chapter read during one weekend.

The public library would help track totals.

Money would go directly to club equipment and review improvements.

No cash in council bags.

No mysterious envelopes.

No Noah eating the profits.

It was sensible.

It was measurable.

It was also not enough.

The frozen budget was only one problem.

Mr. Vane's report on Open Week praised the community turnout but criticised our safety procedures, room bookings, and cash handling.

The cooking club had used the wrong form.

The drama club had exceeded its room capacity by four people.

The sports team had moved cones without a site supervisor.

Brad stared at the report.

"They're criticising cones?"

"Orange safety equipment," Noah said. "Very dangerous."

I wanted to argue.

Instead, Sophie created a corrections list.

Every mistake.

One owner.

One deadline.

No excuses.

By Thursday, every correction was complete.

Mr. Vane signed the sheet.

"Efficient," he said.

It sounded like an insult.

THE MISSING SIGNATURE

On Friday, our sponsored-read forms disappeared.

Two hundred forms had been stored in a locked office drawer.

On Saturday morning, the drawer was empty.

Without sponsor forms, students could not prove donations.

The public library had blank copies, but the signed agreements were gone.

Mrs. Patel called the principal.

The principal called Mr. Vane.

Mr. Vane called a review meeting.

"This is precisely why financial controls matter," he said.

Sophie placed the drawer key log on the table.

Only three people had accessed the office.

The principal.

The office manager.

Mr. Vane.

He looked at the log.

"Are you suggesting I took student fundraising forms?"

"No," Sophie said. "I'm stating who had access."

Noah leaned toward me.

"She's getting scary."

Mr. Vane's office copy of the key log showed a fourth entry.

S. PATEL — STUDENT COUNCIL.

Sophie's full name was Sophie Patel.

She stared at the forged entry.

"I didn't sign that."

The handwriting looked like hers.

Very like hers.

Mr. Vane closed his folder.

"Until this is resolved, the fundraiser is suspended."

I stood up.

"Someone is setting her up."

"That is a serious accusation."

"Yes."

"Do you have evidence?"

I looked at the two logs.

One without her name.

One with it.

"No."

"Then I suggest you focus on recovering the forms."

Sophie gathered her papers.

Her hands were shaking.

I had seen her face during festivals, mysteries, elections, and disasters.

I had never seen her look like this.

Outside, she stopped in the corridor.

"He wants me to resign."

"You can't."

"If I stay, every council record becomes questionable."

"If you leave, he wins."

"No, Tim. If I stay without fixing this, the council loses."

She walked away.

Noah and I stood there.

Brad arrived carrying two basketballs.

"What happened?"

"Sophie might quit."

He dropped both balls.

"Then we find the forms."

"And prove she didn't sign," I said.

Noah looked down the corridor.

"How?"

I thought about the office camera.

The key log.

The photocopier.

The collection times.

And the fact that Mr. Vane always seemed to know which evidence would appear next.

"We stop chasing the register for one weekend."

Noah nodded.

Brad picked up the basketballs.

"Finally. A mystery about our own team."

I didn't like that description.

But it was true.

The school could wait two days.

Sophie couldn't.

THE CAMERA GAP

The office camera recorded everything except twelve minutes on Friday afternoon.

The office manager had been at lunch.

Mr. Vane said he was in a meeting.

The principal was teaching.

Twelve minutes was enough to take the forms, forge the log, and leave.

It was also enough for someone to make the camera fail.

Noah checked the photocopier history.

At 12:14, someone had copied twenty pages.

At 12:16, the camera stopped.

At 12:28, it restarted.

The copy code belonged to the student council.

Our code.

I felt sick.

Whoever did this had more than a key.

They had our passwords, our routines, and Sophie's handwriting.

Brad looked at the copy count.

"Twenty pages. Two hundred forms are more than twenty pages."

Noah nodded.

"So they copied something else."

"The log," I said. "They needed a clean sample of her signature."

Sophie's signature appeared on every agenda.

Anyone could copy one.

But only a few people knew which drawer held the forms.

Our council.

The office staff.

Mr. Vane.

And Mia, who had helped file them on Friday.

I looked at Noah.

He looked at Brad.

Nobody wanted to say her name.

Then Mia walked around the corner carrying a plastic folder.

"Why are you all outside the office?"

Inside her folder was one of the missing sponsor forms.

She saw us looking at it.

Her face changed.

"I can explain."

And that's when the fire alarm went off.

CHAPTER 11

Mia's Form

Monday

Fire alarms are very useful when you want everyone to leave a building.

They are less useful when you are about to ask your friend why she has stolen evidence.

We walked outside with the rest of the school.

Mia stayed with us.

The alarm kept ringing.

Students talked.

Teachers counted heads.

Brad held both basketballs under one arm and tried to look casual.

Sophie stood on the other side of the playground with Mr. Vane.

She saw us and started walking over.

I had about thirty seconds.

"Where did you get the form?" I asked Mia.

"From the recycling box beside the photocopier."

"Why did you have it?"

"Because it had my name on it. I sponsor the reading club. I thought the forms had been thrown out by mistake."

Noah looked at the paper.

It was a sponsor form.

Mia's name and address were at the top.

On the back was a rough copy of Sophie's signature.

Not a real form.

Practice paper.

Mia saw it too.

"I didn't do this."

"I know," I said.

I said it because I trusted her.

Then I worried that trusting my friends was exactly what the forger expected.

Sophie arrived.

Mia explained everything again.

The alarm stopped.

Mr. Vane called everyone back inside.

Sophie took the form without accusing anyone.

"We check the recycling box. Together. With the office manager."

The box was empty.

No more forms.

No signatures.

Just a broken pencil and a Westbridge visitor sticker.

The sticker had Lucas's name on it.

I groaned.

"Of course it does."

THE TRAP INSIDE THE TRAP

Lucas had visited Brookfield on Friday.

He had attended a review meeting and left at 11:40.

The camera gap began at 12:16.

He could have returned.

He could have given his sticker to someone.

He could have dropped it near the copier at any time.

There were too many possibilities.

Noah suggested interviewing him.

Sophie said no.

"Not because I trust him. Because this evidence is too convenient. Someone wants us chasing Lucas."

"Who?"

"Whoever benefits when we look ridiculous."

Mr. Vane benefited.

Richard Stone benefited.

Anyone supporting the merger benefited.

That was not a small list.

Sophie put the form in an evidence sleeve.

"We need the originals, not another suspect."

Brad bounced one basketball.

"They took two hundred forms. You can't hide those in a pocket."

Noah nodded.

"Unless they have very big pockets."

We ignored him.

"Paper is heavy," Sophie said. "Two hundred signed forms, folders, and copies would need a box."

The office had no box.

The corridor camera showed nobody carrying one.

The recycling collection had left at 12:30.

We ran to the caretaker's room.

The recycling truck was still outside.

For once, something was going right.

Then the caretaker told us the school paper had already been compacted.

Noah looked through the small window in the truck.

Two hundred forms were somewhere inside a mountain of crushed paper.

"Treasure hunt?" he asked.

"Worst one ever," I said.

THE PAPER MOUNTAIN

The driver agreed to let us search the sealed section after he returned to the recycling depot.

We needed gloves, permission, and an adult who understood why student council work sometimes involved garbage.

The principal came.

So did Mr. Vane.

Sophie stayed at school to continue her interview.

That worried me, but there was no time to argue.

At the depot, we searched for three hours.

Old worksheets.

Newspapers.

Food wrappers.

A drawing of a dinosaur wearing a tie.

At 4:42, Noah found the first sponsor form.

Then Brad found a whole bundle.

The forms had been placed inside a cardboard folder marked CITY REVIEW — CONFIDENTIAL.

The same folders Mr. Vane used.

He looked at the label.

"These are available to all review staff."

"Who took them?" I asked.

"We don't know," the principal said.

But we knew someone wanted it to look like him.

Or someone wanted us to think it was too obvious to be him.

My head hurt.

Behind the forms was another folder.

Sophie's agendas.

Twenty copied pages.

And a sheet of paper with twelve attempts at her signature.

The forger had thrown away everything.

Including the evidence.

THE REAL SIGNATURE

Back at school, Sophie compared the practice sheet with the forged key log.

"They copied my signature from the March agenda. See this loop? I stopped writing it that way in April."

"Can you prove it?"

She gave me every agenda since March.

Her signature changed gradually.

The forgery copied the old version exactly.

The office manager confirmed Sophie had used the new signature on Friday.

The principal checked the original March agenda.

It had been signed out to Mr. Vane's review team on Thursday.

Not directly to him.

To his administrative assistant.

A woman named Helen Ward.

She had been at Open Week.

She had carried folders into the council room.

She had stood beside the photocopier during the fire drill.

And on Friday, she had called in sick.

Mr. Vane stared at the signature log.

"I will interview her."

"No," the principal said.

Mr. Vane looked up.

"Excuse me?"

"You are part of the access list. This needs an independent investigation."

For the first time, the principal sounded like the person in charge.

Mr. Vane agreed.

The fundraiser was reinstated.

Sophie was cleared.

And Helen Ward's city account was suspended.

It should have felt like victory.

Instead, I kept thinking about Lucas's visitor sticker.

Helen could have used it.

But Lucas had still known about the archive before we did.

He had still warned me about his father's company.

And he had still told me to check the dates.

Perhaps he was helping.

Perhaps he was guilty.

Perhaps he was both.

SOPHIE STAYS

On Tuesday morning, Sophie returned to the council room with a new folder.

It said:

OPERATION NORMAL COUNCIL — SECOND ATTEMPT.

Noah cheered.

Brad gave her a high five.

I smiled so much my face hurt.

Sophie sat down.

"I am not resigning."

"Good," I said.

"But I am changing the rules."

Of course.

She wrote three new points on the board.

Every document has two owners.

Every password changes weekly.

No investigation starts without a purpose and an exit plan.

Noah raised his hand.

"What's an exit plan?"

"What we do if the door locks."

"Run?"

"No."

"Panic?"

"No."

"Make dying-printer noises until someone rescues us?"

Sophie considered it.

"Only if the phone is dead."

That was why I needed her.

She understood emergencies.

Later, when everyone had gone, she stopped me.

"Thank you for searching the recycling truck."

"You would have done the same."

"Yes. But I would have made a spreadsheet first."

"You probably would have found them faster."

She smiled.

Then she handed me one of the forged signature sheets.

On the back was a faint indentation.

Someone had written on another page above it.

Sophie shaded the marks lightly with a pencil.

Words appeared.

B2 IS ONLY THE BEGINNING. ASK LUCAS ABOUT THE HOUSE.

Below them was a phone number.

Not Helen Ward's.

Richard Stone's.

I looked at Sophie.

"This time, we ask in public."

She nodded.

"And we bring everyone."

CHAPTER 12

The House on Stonebridge Road

Wednesday

Richard Stone lived in a house with two front doors.

One for visitors.

One, Noah said, for people who owned development companies and wanted to avoid questions.

We used the visitor door.

Richard was not happy to see us.

He was even less happy to see Daniel, Emily, Clara, and the principal.

Sophie had arranged the meeting through Mrs. Doyle and the city review office.

Mr. Vane came too.

That made six adults, four students, and one very uncomfortable Lucas.

His father looked at him.

"Did you know about this?"

"No," Lucas said.

It was the same answer he had given me at Westbridge.

This time, I believed him less.

Sophie put the copied minutes on the dining-room table.

"Can you explain this meeting?"

Richard read the first page.

"It was a preliminary discussion. Schools consider development options all the time."

"Five years before the current proposal?" the principal asked.

"Yes."

"And why did it mention closing informal student groups?"

"I didn't write the minutes."

"But you attended."

"Yes."

Mr. Vane stood by the window.

He said nothing.

Daniel put the photograph beside the minutes.

"You helped Adrian search for the Founders' Register."

Richard's jaw tightened.

"Clara's family had documents relevant to the land. We needed to understand the restrictions."

Clara stepped forward.

"You asked my mother to sell the bookshop."

"It was a commercial offer."

"You told her Brookfield would be demolished within a year."

"That was a projection."

"She refused."

"And the development did not proceed."

Richard spread his hands as if that settled everything.

Noah leaned toward me.

"He's very good at making bad things sound boring."

THE HOUSE THAT WAS A SCHOOL

Lucas had been quiet throughout the meeting.

Then he picked up the photograph.

"There's a house in the background."

Clara nodded.

"The old caretaker's cottage."

"Where is it?"

"Demolished when the sports field was extended."

Lucas turned to his father.

"Is that why you keep the model?"

Richard froze.

"What model?" I asked.

Lucas left the room.

His father called after him.

He didn't stop.

We heard footsteps upstairs.

Mr. Vane moved toward the door, but the principal blocked him politely.

"Lucas is retrieving school evidence."

"This is a private house."

"Then perhaps we should continue with a city investigator present."

Mr. Vane stayed.

Lucas returned carrying a wooden architectural model.

It showed Brookfield before the sports field extension.

The old caretaker's cottage stood beside the oak tree.

On its roof was a tiny painted hawk.

Clara touched the model.

"Where did you get this?"

"My father kept it in his study," Lucas said. "I thought it was just a design model."

Richard sat down heavily.

The room changed.

Everyone could see he had lost control of the conversation.

Lucas opened the base of the model.

There was a hollow compartment.

Empty.

"I checked this morning," he said. "After Helen Ward called him."

His father looked at him.

"You listened to my call?"

"You shouted."

"What did she say?" Mr. Vane asked.

Lucas looked directly at him.

"She said the students had found the wrong house."

Noah frowned.

"How can a house be wrong?"

Clara answered.

"Because there were two."

THE SECOND COTTAGE

The model included a smaller building behind the first cottage.

A storehouse.

It had not been demolished.

It had been moved.

Richard admitted that the development company had preserved it.

"Where?" Sophie asked.

"Westbridge."

Noah laughed once.

Nobody else did.

The storehouse was now part of Westbridge's grounds office.

Room B2 had been inside its old foundations.

The key, the minutes, and the fake message had all pointed there.

But the register had moved again.

"Who moved it?" I asked.

Richard looked at Mr. Vane.

So did everyone else.

Mr. Vane's expression barely changed.

"I secured historical materials during the current review."

"Where is the register?" Clara demanded.

"I don't know."

"You keep saying that," I said.

"Because it is true."

Richard picked up the minutes.

"Adrian, tell them."

Mr. Vane turned to the window.

For a moment, I thought he might actually leave.

Then he spoke.

"The register was in the grounds office until last month. When the review began, I authorised its transfer to a secure city archive."

"Which archive?"

"It never arrived."

Noah raised his hand.

"So you lost the book that proves the school can't be sold?"

Mr. Vane glared at him.

"I did not lose it. The transport company returned an empty case."

"Who signed for delivery?"

"Helen Ward."

Everything came back to Helen.

Her sick day.

Her forged signature.

Her phone call.

Her empty case.

Lucas's phone rang.

He looked at the screen.

"Helen."

Mr. Vane held out his hand.

Lucas didn't give it to him.

He answered on speaker.

"Lucas?" a woman said.

"Yes."

"Tell your father I'm sorry."

"Where is the register?"

She breathed shakily.

"Safe."

"Where?"

"With someone who remembers the promises."

"Helen," Mr. Vane said. "This is Adrian Vane. Return the material immediately."

She laughed.

It was not a happy sound.

"You still think giving orders makes you right."

"You're committing theft."

"No. I'm returning school property."

The line clicked.

She was gone.

LUCAS'S CHOICE

Richard demanded to know why Lucas had helped us.

Lucas stood beside the model.

"Because you told me the merger was about better classrooms."

"It is."

"Then why did you need to hide what happened five years ago?"

Richard had no answer.

Mr. Vane left first.

Richard followed him into the hall.

Their voices rose behind the door.

Lucas stayed with us.

I expected him to ask us not to tell anyone.

Instead, he took off his silver Westbridge council badge and put it on the table.

"What are you doing?" I asked.

"Choosing which facts I can defend."

Sophie studied him.

"If you help us, people will say you betrayed your school."

"I know."

"If you lie to us, I'll find out."

"I know."

Noah leaned toward me.

"Are we friends now?"

"No," Lucas and I said together.

Some things were too soon.

But when we left, he came with us.

And he carried the model.

CHAPTER 13

Two Councils

Thursday

Having Lucas at Brookfield was weird.

Students stared.

Brad asked whether he had come to spy on our cones.

Sophie gave him a visitor badge and a list of rules.

Noah asked whether Westbridge really had a hot-chocolate machine.

Lucas said yes.

Noah looked betrayed.

We met in the library, not the council room.

Lucas did not get a seat at the main table.

Trust had limits.

He placed the school model beside my laptop.

"The transport company used for the register is owned by Stonebridge Learning Group."

"Your father's company," I said.

"Yes."

"Did Helen work for it?"

"Before she worked for the city. She was my father's assistant."

Sophie added this to the evidence map.

Our map now had so many lines that it looked like a spider had fallen into a bowl of red string.

"Why would Helen steal the register from your father and Mr. Vane?"

Lucas hesitated.

"Maybe she didn't want them to destroy it."

"Or she wanted money," Noah said.

"Or both."

Lucas nodded.

He didn't defend her.

That made me trust him slightly more.

THE WESTBRIDGE RECORD

Lucas had brought his own council records.

Westbridge's showcase project was impressive.

They had raised money for new science equipment.

They had an attendance mentoring programme.

They had organised inter-school sports.

They had photographs of everything.

Brookfield's project was a wall covered in corrections, club lists, and half-finished sponsor forms.

"We can't beat this," I said.

Sophie looked up.

"Not by copying it."

"What do we have that Westbridge doesn't?"

Noah raised his hand.

"A chicken named Greg."

Sophie ignored him.

"Community."

Lucas nodded.

"Westbridge students come from all over the city. Brookfield is a neighbourhood school. Your Open Week proved that."

I looked at the community wall photographs.

"Then that's our project. Not just a presentation. A plan for what Brookfield will do next year."

Sophie started writing.

A homework club open to local primary students.

A public-library reading partnership.

Community sports afternoons.

A yearly promise day beside the oak tree.

A student-led history archive.

Lucas added one more.

"Joint events with Westbridge."

Brad laughed.

Then he realised Lucas was serious.

"Why would we help your showcase?"

"You wouldn't. I'd help yours. Westbridge can present a partnership instead of a takeover."

"Will your council agree?"

"I'll ask them."

Sophie capped her pen.

"This only works if both schools keep their own identities."

"That's the point," Lucas said.

I looked at him.

Perhaps there was a first time for both of us to lose.

And win something better.

THE READING WEEKEND

The sponsored read began on Friday.

I had sponsored myself to read twenty chapters.

Then Mum sponsored me.

Then Daniel.

Then Clara.

By Saturday morning, I had to read two hundred and forty chapters or owe everyone an explanation.

Noah had been sponsored per page because he said chapters were inconsistent.

Sophie had a spreadsheet.

Of course.

Students read everywhere.

Under blankets.

On buses.

Beside the sports field.

In the public library.

Brad listened to an audiobook while practising basketball.

Sophie said it counted if he could answer questions.

He scored nine out of ten.

Frank listened too.

On Sunday afternoon, I reached chapter one hundred and twelve.

My eyes felt like they had been rubbed with paper.

Noah sat beside me on the library floor eating emergency biscuits.

"Whose idea was this?"

"Sophie's."

"Next time she can raise money by sitting still."

"That's basically what reading is."

"Yes, but without movement."

Lucas arrived with a stack of Westbridge forms.

His council had joined the fundraiser.

Not for Westbridge.

For Brookfield clubs.

I stared at the totals.

"Why?"

"Because a partnership needs evidence."

"And because Oliver beat you at chess?"

"That too."

By midnight, we had raised enough to replace the laptops, repair the sports shed, and fund Open Week for another year.

The accounts were public.

Every form was scanned.

Two adults checked every payment.

Mr. Vane signed the audit without finding a single error.

Sophie smiled for almost a full minute.

A NEW NOTE

On Monday, the council room door was unlocked.

I had locked it myself.

Inside, nothing was missing.

But a book lay on my chair.

The Brookfield school history.

Not the register.

A ordinary library copy.

A strip of paper marked page seventy-five.

The page showed an old photograph of the caretaker's cottage.

In the doorway stood a girl holding a book.

The caption named her:

HELEN BELL — JUNIOR LIBRARIAN.

I read it again.

Helen Bell.

Not Helen Ward.

Noah looked over my shoulder.

"Helen changed her surname."

"She's related to Clara."

Clara confirmed it that afternoon.

Helen was her niece.

She had visited the bookshop as a child.

She knew the stories, the charter, and the folded-wing hawk.

"Did she see the register?" I asked.

"Yes. I showed her when she was twelve."

Clara sat down.

"Then she could have drawn the notes."

"Would she?"

Clara looked sad.

"Helen always wanted to protect things. Sometimes she thought that meant deciding who was allowed to see them."

The first note had told me to ask the first hawk.

The archive note had warned me about the deed.

The fake Westbridge message had nearly made us trespass.

Helen had helped and manipulated us.

Just like Mr. Vane, she believed she knew best.

Unlike him, she had taken the register to keep it safe.

The book on my chair had one more mark.

A phone number written inside the back cover.

This time, it was Helen's.

And beneath it:

I WANT TO TALK TO TIM ALONE.

Sophie read it.

"No."

I nodded.

"I know."

"But you're going to want to."

"Yes."

She handed me my phone.

"Then we arrange a public place, tell Daniel, and sit at the next table."

Noah grinned.

"Operation Alone With Four Other People."

It was becoming our best kind of plan.

CHAPTER 14

Emergency Biscuits

Tuesday

Helen Ward chose the community cafe.

Daniel chose the table.

Noah chose the biscuits.

Sophie chose two seats close enough to hear everything while pretending not to listen.

Helen arrived carrying a flat document bag.

She was younger than I expected.

Her city identification badge was gone.

She sat opposite me and put both hands around a cup of tea.

"You found the register," I said.

"Yes."

"Do you have it?"

"No."

Noah groaned at the next table.

Helen looked at him.

He pretended to be very interested in a spoon.

"Why the notes?" I asked.

"Because I needed you to find the deed before Adrian buried it."

"You could have told the principal."

"He kept secrets for five years."

"You could have told Clara."

"She would have called Daniel, and Daniel would have tried to protect everyone by waiting."

At the next table, Daniel suddenly coughed.

Helen smiled faintly.

"You could have told me the truth."

"I did. In pieces."

"You nearly got us caught at Westbridge."

"I needed to know whether Adrian would let you search. I sent the message after the caretaker confirmed the room was empty."

"That doesn't make it okay."

"No."

She didn't argue.

That made it harder to stay angry.

THE DOCUMENT BAG

Helen opened the bag.

Inside was a photograph of the Founders' Register.

Its cover was dark green.

A folded-wing hawk was drawn in the corner.

Below it were nine handwritten promises.

"Where is it?" I asked.

"Somewhere Adrian cannot reach."

"That's not an answer."

"It's the only answer until the city agrees to an independent review."

Sophie stood up and came over.

So much for pretending.

"You forged my signature."

Helen's expression tightened.

"Yes."

Noah stopped eating.

Even Daniel looked surprised that she admitted it so easily.

"Why?" Sophie asked.

"Because Adrian was about to suspend the council. I needed evidence that would force an independent investigation."

"You made it look like I stole from my own school."

"I intended the forms to be found quickly."

"They were compacted in a recycling truck."

Helen closed her eyes.

"That was not the plan."

Noah leaned toward me.

"Her plans have the same problem as ours."

Sophie sat down.

"You don't get to decide what risks other people should take."

Helen nodded.

"You're right."

It took a moment for Sophie to respond.

People rarely agreed with her that quickly during an argument.

Helen continued.

"I will give a full statement. I'll accept whatever happens. But the register cannot become part of Adrian's review. He'll use it to claim the community has already agreed to the merger."

"How?" I asked.

"The register contains more than promises. It includes the last community vote from five years ago."

THE MISSING VOTE

Five years ago, a small group of parents and students had voted on the first development proposal.

According to the city record, they had approved it.

According to Clara, they had rejected it.

The signed ballot sheets were inside the register.

If the city record was false, the original development plan was invalid.

So was any claim that the current merger was simply continuing an old decision.

"Who changed the record?" I asked.

"Richard signed the summary. Adrian submitted it. Harper removed the objections."

All three.

Again.

"But the vote was only advisory," Sophie said.

Helen nodded.

"Yes. The deed makes the current vote binding only if student representatives and community members participate together. That is why Adrian wants to replace your council. He needs representatives he controls."

Mr. Vane's report.

The proposed temporary officers.

Lucas's welcome plans.

It wasn't just about making us look bad.

It was about choosing who could say yes.

I felt cold.

"When is the vote?"

Helen looked at me.

"At the City Schools Showcase."

"The showcase is a presentation."

"That's what everyone thinks. The city agenda includes a community consultation immediately afterwards. The panel will use the showcase attendance as evidence of participation."

Sophie understood before I did.

"He wants applause to count as consent."

Helen nodded.

"And if Brookfield students don't attend, he'll record it as no objection."

Noah put down his biscuit.

"So we have to go, but we can't agree with anything."

"Yes."

"That sounds like every family wedding."

Nobody laughed.

THE CONDITION

I asked Helen to bring the register to the showcase.

She refused.

"If Adrian knows it's there, he'll take it."

"Then give it to the independent reviewer."

"There isn't one yet."

"Make one."

She looked at Sophie.

Sophie looked at Daniel.

Daniel looked at the principal, who had just arrived with Emily.

Adults had a habit of looking at each other when students asked obvious questions.

Finally, the principal said, "We request a city oversight officer. Someone outside Adrian's department."

Helen agreed.

"Once the oversight officer has the ballot records, I'll hand over the register."

"How do we know you will?"

She opened her document bag again.

This time, she removed a key.

A large brass key with the number nine on it.

"The register is in a locked cabinet. This is one key. Clara has the other."

Clara reached into her bag and produced an identical key.

Helen placed hers on the table.

"Two people must agree."

I picked it up.

It was heavier than the archive key.

"Where's the cabinet?"

Helen smiled for the first time.

"Inside the school."

I closed my eyes.

"Of course it is."

THE CABINET WITHOUT A ROOM

We searched every cabinet at Brookfield.

The display cabinet.

The office cupboard.

The library archive drawers.

The sports shed.

Even the mysterious cupboard in Room 14.

None had two locks.

Helen refused to help.

"The location is the only protection left."

By Friday, I had stopped looking for cabinets and started looking for doors.

The principal found me beside Room 75.

"No."

"I haven't done anything."

"You are holding two keys."

"Clara gave me hers for the search."

"No."

"I need to check one lock."

"No."

Noah arrived.

"He's very consistent."

The principal took both keys and locked them in the school safe.

Good.

At least they were protected.

Then he handed me an envelope from the city.

The independent oversight officer had been appointed.

Her name was Justice Moyo.

She was a retired head teacher and community mediator.

Her first meeting would be on Monday.

Her second would be at the showcase.

And her first instruction was simple:

NO FURTHER STUDENT INVESTIGATIONS.

I read it twice.

Noah looked at my face.

"So... normal council again?"

"Normal council."

"Third attempt?"

"Third attempt."

I put the letter in my bag.

Then I realised what Helen had meant.

Inside the school could mean Brookfield.

But Brookfield wasn't the only school with our name on its old records.

The original Brookfield building had become Westbridge's library.

The cabinet was there.

And now we were forbidden to investigate.

CHAPTER 15

Justice Moyo

Monday

Justice Moyo did not look like a retired head teacher.

She looked like someone who could stop an argument by raising one finger.

She proved this during her first meeting.

Mr. Vane began explaining why the city review should remain under his control.

Justice raised one finger.

He stopped.

Noah whispered, "I need to learn that."

Justice listened to everyone.

The principal.

Sophie.

Daniel.

Clara.

Helen, who joined by video.

Lucas.

Even Richard Stone.

She took no sides and accepted no documents without checking where they came from.

When my turn came, she asked only one question.

"What do you want?"

"To keep Brookfield open."

"Why?"

"Because it's ours."

She waited.

I remembered Mr. Vane's criticism.

"Because the homework club helps sixty students a week. Because local families use the field and library. Because students can walk here. Because we have evidence that the council and community were not properly consulted."

Justice nodded.

"Better."

Sophie looked relieved.

Justice closed her notebook.

"The showcase will proceed. No vote will be recorded without a separate, clearly announced consultation. Any historical documents will be held by my office. Both councils will cooperate."

Mr. Vane objected.

Justice raised her finger again.

He stopped.

It really was impressive.

BEFORE THE MEETING

I expected Justice to begin with the evidence.

Instead, she asked everyone to explain one thing they had done wrong.

Mr. Vane went first.

"I assumed opposition was an inconvenience."

Helen went second.

"I assumed good intentions excused dishonesty."

Clara admitted she had kept quiet too long.

Daniel admitted he enjoyed mysteries more than resolutions.

Sophie said she sometimes treated correcting people as helping them.

Noah said he sometimes ate before asking whether food was communal.

Justice wrote that down too.

When my turn came, I said, "I think being brave means going first. Sometimes it means waiting until everyone else is ready."

Justice nodded.

"Then we can begin."

The exercise did not change the evidence. It changed the room. We were no longer pretending one side had arrived with clean hands and the other with all the guilt.

THE COOPERATION RULE

Justice required Brookfield and Westbridge to share one showcase booth.

Lucas and I had to present together.

Brad thought this was a terrible idea.

Noah wanted to know whether Westbridge would bring the hot-chocolate machine.

Sophie wanted a joint agenda by Wednesday.

Mr. Vane wanted Lucas removed as Westbridge leader.

Justice denied the request.

"Students are not city employees. Their councils manage their own elections."

For once, Lucas looked grateful.

We started planning.

The booth would have two halves.

Brookfield's community projects.

Westbridge's academic and sports programmes.

In the middle, a joint map showing events shared by both schools.

No merger.

No takeover.

Partnership.

Mr. Vane read the proposal.

"The review concerns Brookfield, not a promotional campaign for cooperation."

Justice replied before I could.

"Then the cooperation will demonstrate whether a merger is necessary."

He stopped arguing.

THE SECOND KEYHOLE

On Wednesday, Lucas took me through Westbridge's library.

Officially, we were measuring the showcase display boards.

Unofficially, I was looking at the oldest wooden cabinet in the room.

It stood against the back wall.

Two locks.

Both brass.

One marked B.

One marked C.

Bell and Clara?

No.

Brookfield and Community.

I didn't touch it.

Justice's instruction was clear.

Instead, I described it to her.

She arranged a supervised opening on Friday.

Mr. Vane attended.

So did Helen by video.

Clara brought her key.

The principal brought Helen's key from the safe.

Justice inserted them.

Both turned.

The cabinet opened.

Empty.

Noah hit his forehead with his palm.

"Again?"

Inside lay a small card.

TOO LATE.

Mr. Vane looked at Helen's video image.

"What did you do?"

"Nothing. That cabinet has been empty for months."

Clara examined the shelf.

There was a rectangular dust mark.

A book had been there recently.

Justice found a sign-out sheet inside the door.

The last entry was dated two weeks earlier.

H. WARD.

Helen nodded.

"I moved it."

"Where?"

"I told you. Safe."

Justice's voice became very quiet.

"Ms. Ward, I am now the authorised independent officer. You will tell me."

Helen hesitated.

Then she said, "The public library. Rare-books storage."

Mrs. Patel shook her head.

"No. I checked there myself."

"Not the public branch," Helen said. "The mobile library."

THE MOBILE LIBRARY

Brookfield's old mobile library was a blue van.

It visited neighbourhoods every Thursday.

It was currently parked outside the city depot for repairs.

Justice called the depot.

The van had been signed out that morning.

By Helen.

Using her suspended city account.

Everyone looked at her video image.

She was no longer sitting in her kitchen.

Behind her was a window.

Outside the window, I could see the oak tree.

"You're at Brookfield," I said.

Helen ended the call.

We ran.

Well, Justice walked very quickly.

Retired head teachers do not run unless absolutely necessary.

The blue van was parked behind the sports field.

Its side door stood open.

Helen sat inside with the Founders' Register on her lap.

Mr. Vane stepped toward her.

Justice raised her finger.

He stopped.

Helen looked exhausted.

"I was bringing it to you."

"Why here?" Justice asked.

"Because this is where the promises belong."

She held out the register.

Justice put on gloves before taking it.

Then she opened the cover.

Nine promises.

The folded-wing hawk.

Letters, photographs, ballot sheets, and the original charter.

All there.

We had found it.

Noah let out a shout.

Brad lifted Frank.

Sophie laughed.

I just stood there.

After weeks of searching, the register looked too small to hold so much trouble.

Justice turned to the ballot section.

The pages were gone.

Only rough edges remained where they had been torn out.

Helen's face went white.

"I didn't do that."

Mr. Vane finally smiled.

"Then perhaps you should not have kept it in a van."

Justice closed the register.

"No one touches anything else."

But someone already had.

The proof we needed most had disappeared between the cabinet and the oak tree.

And Helen had been driving the only vehicle that contained it.

CHAPTER 16

The Van Search

Tuesday

A mobile library is not designed to be a crime scene.

There are books on the walls.

A tiny staircase.

Stickers telling you to return items on time.

It is difficult to look serious while standing beside a poster of a smiling badger.

Justice Moyo managed.

She sealed the van and arranged for an independent city team to examine it.

No students were allowed inside.

For once, I didn't argue.

Much.

Helen sat in the principal's office with her hands folded.

She looked smaller without her city badge.

"I didn't remove the ballot pages."

Justice asked when she had last seen them.

"Two weeks ago, in the Westbridge cabinet."

"Did you check the register after moving it?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because I was afraid. I wrapped it, locked the rare-books case, and hid the case under the mobile library's floor panel."

Noah looked at me.

"A secret floor in a van. That's new."

Justice ignored him.

"Who knew where you had moved it?"

"No one."

"Who had access to the van?"

"The depot staff. Mrs. Patel. Any librarian with a city vehicle key."

"Richard Stone's transport company services the depot," Lucas said.

Everyone turned to him.

He looked pale but continued.

"They repair the mobile libraries. Their logo was on the service sheet."

Justice asked him to write down everything he knew.

Mr. Vane stood near the window.

"Convenient," he said.

Lucas faced him.

"What?"

"That you keep producing accusations against your father."

"I'm producing facts."

"After helping his assistant hide evidence?"

Lucas flinched.

Helen shook her head.

"He didn't help me."

"But he knew?"

"Not until the archive visit."

Mr. Vane looked at me.

"And yet you all trust him now."

I didn't answer immediately.

Trust was not a switch.

Lucas had lied before.

He had also given us evidence that hurt his own family.

"No," I said. "We check him like everyone else."

Lucas looked surprised.

Sophie nodded.

It was the right answer.

THE FLOOR PANEL

The city team photographed the van before opening the floor.

The rare-books case was still there.

Locked.

Both keys present.

No sign of force.

Inside, the register remained exactly as Justice had found it.

The missing pages could not have been removed after the case was locked without leaving marks.

That meant they had been taken earlier.

At Westbridge.

Or before Helen moved it.

Helen looked relieved for one second.

Then Justice pointed out that she was still the last person known to have handled the complete register.

"Great," Noah whispered. "The evidence cleared her by making her guilty again."

Mr. Vane requested Helen's immediate arrest.

Justice refused.

"This is an administrative inquiry. The police can decide whether a crime occurred. My job is to preserve the evidence."

She sealed the register in a new evidence bag and placed it in her own document case.

Then she addressed all of us.

"No one searches the van, the depot, Westbridge, or any private property. Is that clear?"

Everyone agreed.

Even Noah.

THE SERVICE SHEET

We did not search.

We read the copy of the service sheet Justice provided.

The van had entered the depot on Monday.

On Tuesday, Stonebridge Transport replaced its battery.

On Wednesday, a librarian named J. Moyo signed for a routine inspection.

Justice Moyo.

Her own name.

She stared at it.

"I did not inspect this vehicle."

Another forged signature.

Whoever was moving evidence had copied Sophie's name, Helen's access, and now Justice's identity.

This wasn't just old corruption.

Someone was actively framing every person involved.

The service sheet listed one mechanic.

Theo Grant.

Noah recognised the name.

"He runs the school car-boot sale."

"How do you know?"

"He sells doughnuts from the same van."

Sometimes Noah's knowledge was more useful than city records.

Justice contacted Theo.

He admitted servicing the van.

He also admitted finding a paper envelope beneath the driver's seat.

"What did you do with it?" Justice asked.

"I gave it to the man who booked the repair."

"Who was that?"

"Mr. Vane."

Everyone turned.

Mr. Vane's expression did not change.

Justice held out her hand.

"Where is the envelope?"

"In my office."

"Did you open it?"

"Yes."

"Did it contain ballot pages?"

"No."

"What did it contain?"

He hesitated.

"A list of payments."

"To whom?"

"Helen Ward."

THE PAYMENT LIST

The list showed five payments from Stonebridge Learning Group to Helen.

One every year for five years.

The latest was two months earlier.

Helen looked at the figures.

"I worked for them before I joined the city. These are old consulting payments."

"The latest payment?" Justice asked.

"For transport archives. Nothing to do with the school."

Richard had paid her.

Mr. Vane had kept the list secret.

The mechanic had found it in the van.

It was too much like another planted clue.

Justice bagged the paper and scheduled formal interviews.

Mr. Vane was now a witness in his own review.

Justice suspended him from decision-making until the inquiry ended.

He did not argue.

He simply picked up his briefcase and left.

As he passed me, he stopped.

"You think this proves the school should stay open."

"It proves people hid things."

"It proves people are weak, Tim. Institutions survive because they have systems stronger than individuals."

"Brookfield has people who care."

"And when you leave?"

He walked away.

I hated his question because it stayed with me.

The showcase project could not be about me.

Or Sophie.

Or even the Black Hawks.

It had to work after we were gone.

THE VAN'S LAST HIDING PLACE

That evening, Mrs. Patel called the council.

She had remembered something.

The mobile library did not just carry books.

It carried a locked return box for neighbourhood residents.

The box had not been searched because it was bolted to the outside.

Justice's team opened it the next morning.

Inside were library books, two bus tickets, and a folded sheet of paper.

Not the ballot pages.

A delivery receipt.

It confirmed that Stonebridge Transport had delivered the original ballot box to Westbridge five years earlier.

The destination was not the records centre.

It was the student council office.

Lucas read the receipt twice.

"I've been in that office every day for two years. There's no ballot box."

Noah leaned toward me.

"Maybe it's hidden in the hot-chocolate machine."

Lucas went still.

"What?" I asked.

"The machine was donated by my father five years ago."

Noah's mouth fell open.

"I was joking."

For the first time, so was I.

But none of us laughed.

CHAPTER 17

Hot Chocolate Evidence

Wednesday

Westbridge's hot-chocolate machine had a very large base.

Large enough for water containers, electrical parts, and, according to Noah, a lifetime supply of biscuits.

Justice arranged for it to be disconnected and inspected.

The Westbridge principal was not amused.

Students gathered outside the dining hall while technicians removed the side panel.

Inside were pipes, wires, filters, and a metal box wrapped in plastic.

Noah pointed through the crowd.

"I should get a finding fee."

"Hot chocolate?" Lucas asked.

"Acceptable."

The metal box bore the Brookfield council crest.

The original ballot box.

Justice carried it to a table and checked the seal.

Broken.

Of course.

Inside were blank ballot sheets.

Hundreds of them.

No votes.

No signatures.

Nothing useful.

Brad looked over Lucas's shoulder.

"Your school hides a lot of empty things."

It was true.

The archive box.

The cottage model.

The cabinet.

The hot-chocolate machine.

Every discovery felt like opening a smaller box and finding another disappointing box.

Justice examined the lid.

There were scratches around the lock.

Someone had opened it repeatedly.

A narrow slip of paper was caught inside the hinge.

She removed it with tweezers.

This time, there were names.

Seven student signatures.

Daniel Cross.

Emily.

Clara Bell.

Adrian Vane.

Richard Stone.

Harold Harper.

And one I did not recognise.

Martha Moyo.

Justice's older sister.

THE FIRST PRINCIPAL

Justice sat down.

For the first time since I had met her, she looked completely surprised.

"Martha was Brookfield's first student council president."

"Your sister went here?" I asked.

"Yes. So did I."

Mr. Vane had appointed a retired head teacher with no current connection to the city department.

He had not known she was a Brookfield student.

Justice touched her sister's signature.

"Martha wrote the ninth promise."

Clara shook her head.

"The founders wrote it."

"Martha drafted the student version. My mother kept a copy."

"Where is your mother now?"

"She lives with me."

Noah smiled.

"For once, the next clue is in someone's kitchen and not under a school."

Justice called her mother.

Mrs. Moyo senior was ninety-two and still kept every important paper in labelled biscuit tins.

Noah approved immediately.

That afternoon, we visited Justice's house.

There were no secret doors.

No locked archives.

Just tea, cake, and twelve biscuit tins arranged on a dining table.

The label on the ninth tin read:

BROOKFIELD — MARTHA'S COUNCIL.

Inside were letters, badges, photographs, and a handwritten copy of the student charter.

The ninth promise matched Clara's version.

At the bottom was an additional sentence.

A promise unused does not disappear. It waits for the next students to carry it.

I read it twice.

This was better than treasure.

MARTHA'S STORY

Martha Moyo had died ten years earlier.

Justice told us about her while her mother sorted photographs.

Martha believed student councils should not be clubs for confident children.

They should train everyone to speak.

Every class had a representative.

Every meeting began with one student who had never spoken before.

Every decision had a public record.

"That sounds like Sophie's dream," Noah said.

Sophie was already taking notes.

Justice smiled.

"It was difficult. Students argued. Meetings ran long. Adults became impatient. But no one could claim the students had not been consulted."

The current review was the opposite.

Short meetings.

Selected representatives.

Complex documents.

Decisions explained after they were made.

I looked at the handwritten promise.

"We need to rebuild that."

"The old system?" Sophie asked.

"Not exactly. A new one that does the same job."

Justice nodded.

"That could be your showcase."

Not just a booth.

Not just a map of clubs.

A working community council.

Every class represented.

Every neighbourhood group invited.

Every decision recorded.

No secret votes.

No applause counted as consent.

A system that would still work when I left.

Mr. Vane's question again.

And finally, an answer.

NOAH'S FINDING FEE

Justice did award Noah a finding fee.

One cup of hot chocolate.

Not from the evidence machine. From a new machine installed after the inspection.

He accepted it with both hands.

"For services to school history."

Lucas paid for it.

Brad said Noah had done nothing except make a joke.

Noah said jokes were an underappreciated form of research.

Sophie said the finding fee did not set a council precedent.

Noah asked whether it could set a snack precedent.

Mr. Vane said no.

The discussion was recorded in the informal minutes, which Noah checked more carefully than any official document.

THE OTHER TIN

Before we left, Justice's mother opened a smaller tin.

Inside were photocopies of ballot pages.

Not all of them.

Seven sample ballots from the original vote.

Each said REJECT DEVELOPMENT.

Each was signed.

One had Adrian Vane's name.

He had voted against development five years ago.

I stared at it.

"He was on our side."

"Once," Justice said.

"Why would he change?"

"Ask him."

Mr. Vane agreed to meet Justice the next morning.

He looked at the sample ballot for a long time.

"I believed the first proposal was bad."

"And this one?" she asked.

"This one keeps the educational provision. The building changes. The students move."

"That's not the same thing," I said.

He looked at me.

"Buildings cost money. Communities change. Sentimental promises do not repair roofs."

"Neither do secret votes."

His face tightened.

Justice placed the payment list beside the ballot.

"Why did you conceal this?"

"Because Helen's payments are not evidence of wrongdoing. They make her look guilty and destroy the inquiry's credibility."

"You protected her?"

"I protected the review."

Noah leaned toward me.

"Every adult says that right before something confusing happens."

Mr. Vane heard him.

"Yes. And every student thinks confusion makes them clever."

He stood.

Before leaving, he put the sample ballot back on the table.

"Martha Moyo was wrong about one thing. A promise can disappear. You just have to make enough people stop repeating it."

Then he was gone.

I looked at Justice.

"Did he help us?"

"Not intentionally."

That seemed to be his specialty.

CHAPTER 18

Noah Is in Charge

Thursday

Justice Moyo's next decision was deeply unfair.

She banned me from speaking for one whole council meeting.

Not because I had broken a rule.

Because I kept answering questions meant for other people.

"Leadership includes making space," she said.

Sophie was appointed chair.

Noah was appointed spokesperson.

Noah pointed at himself.

"Me?"

"Yes."

"The person who talks?"

"Yes."

"Voluntarily?"

"Yes."

He looked terrified.

I would have laughed, but I wasn't allowed to speak.

The meeting began with thirty students packed into the council room.

Class representatives.

Club leaders.

Two parents.

Mr. Vane observing silently.

Lucas taking notes for Westbridge.

Justice sitting at the back.

Noah stood beside the whiteboard with a stack of cards.

His first sentence was, "Welcome to the meeting where Tim can't save us."

Everyone laughed.

Even Justice smiled.

I wrote on my notepad:

I WASN'T GOING TO.

Noah read it upside down.

"Sure."

THE NEW COUNCIL

Sophie presented the community-council idea.

Every class would elect two representatives.

Clubs would send one each.

Parents and neighbours would have a separate forum.

Decisions would require student and community voices.

Minutes would be posted where everyone could read them.

Then the questions started.

"What if students don't want to attend?"

"What if parents disagree?"

"Who counts the votes?"

"What about private problems?"

"Will meetings take all lunch?"

Noah looked at Sophie.

Sophie looked at the agenda.

I reached for my pen.

Justice raised one finger.

I put it down.

Noah took a breath.

"We don't know yet."

The room became quiet.

That was not the answer anyone expected.

He continued.

"But we can test it. One issue. One meeting. One public decision. If it fails, we fix it."

A Year Seven representative raised her hand.

"Can the test be about lunch queues?"

Noah wrote it on the board.

"Yes."

Brad raised his hand.

"Can it be about sports equipment?"

"One issue," Noah said.

"Can lunch queues be a sports problem if you run?"

"No."

For the first time, the meeting sounded like actual students instead of a council brochure.

NOAH'S PLAN

The lunch-queue test was brilliant.

Not because lunch queues were the biggest problem facing the school.

Because everyone understood them.

The dining hall had two serving lines and one narrow entrance.

Older students crowded near the front.

Year Sevens waited outside.

Clubs lost meeting time.

Students bought food after the bell.

Noah split the representatives into groups.

One group timed the queues.

One interviewed students.

One spoke to the kitchen staff.

One designed signs.

I was assigned to hold a stopwatch.

It was the perfect job for me.

No speaking.

No secret doors.

Just numbers.

By Friday, we had evidence.

The problem was not the number of serving lines.

It was the drink station.

Everyone paid for food, then walked back through the queue to reach drinks.

Moving the station would shorten the line.

The kitchen staff had suggested it two years earlier.

Nobody had followed up.

The solution cost nothing.

We moved it during lunch.

The average wait dropped by six minutes.

Students cheered.

Noah looked amazed.

"We fixed something without a mystery."

Sophie smiled.

"That's normal council."

THE REPORT

Mr. Vane watched the entire trial.

At the end, he asked Noah who deserved credit.

Noah looked at the representatives.

"The kitchen staff found the problem. The students measured it. Sophie checked the form. Tim held the stopwatch."

"What did you do?"

"I stopped people from giving up when we didn't have an answer."

Mr. Vane wrote it down.

I wanted to hug Noah.

I also wanted to ask whether I could speak now.

Justice nodded as if she knew.

"Not yet."

On Monday, the new lunch system was still working.

On Tuesday, a Westbridge delegation visited to study it.

Lucas stood beside the moved drink station taking notes.

"Your big innovation is a table?"

"No," Noah said. "Listening to the kitchen staff."

Lucas wrote that down too.

The local newspaper published a short story.

This time, my name was not in the headline.

Noah's was.

BROOKFIELD STUDENT FIXES LUNCH BY LISTENING.

Mum put it on the fridge.

Noah took a photograph.

Brad asked whether being famous meant he could skip homework.

It did not.

THE EMPTY CHAIR

At the next council meeting, I arrived early.

My usual chair had a sign on it.

OBSERVER.

Noah's chair had the agenda.

Sophie sat beside him.

For a second, I felt jealous.

Not angry.

Just left out.

I had started the council project.

I had found the first note.

I had brought everyone together.

Now the meeting worked better without me talking.

Then the Year Seven representative arrived and asked whether I could help her time a different queue.

I held the stopwatch again.

By the end of lunch, she had presented her own proposal.

Two students who had never spoken in a council meeting spoke.

Three clubs volunteered for the next trial.

Nobody asked me what to do.

It felt strange.

It also felt exactly right.

Afterwards, Justice returned my speaking privileges.

"Do you understand why?"

"Yes."

"Would you have learned it if I had simply explained?"

"No."

She smiled.

"Good."

Noah handed me the agenda.

"You can have spokesperson back."

"Keep it."

"Really?"

"Until you put hot chocolate on the official budget."

He thought about it.

"No promises."

I laughed.

For the first time since the review began, the school did not feel like something I had to save by myself.

It felt like something other people were already saving.

CHAPTER 19

Brad Gets an Offer

Monday

Brad received a letter from Westbridge.

It was not about the merger.

It was about basketball.

Their coach offered him a place in the City Youth Development Squad.

Training would happen at Westbridge three afternoons a week.

Students in the squad usually transferred schools.

Brad read the letter at lunch.

Then he folded it and put it under his tray.

Noah read it over his shoulder because Noah had no respect for folded paper.

"You're leaving?"

Half the table turned around.

Brad glared at him.

"No."

"But it's a good squad," I said.

"So?"

"So you should think about it."

He looked at me like I had betrayed him.

"I thought we were saving Brookfield."

"We are. That doesn't mean you can't train somewhere else."

"What if the merger happens?"

"Then we're all training somewhere else."

Brad picked up his tray and left.

Frank remained on the bench.

Noah picked him up.

"Do you think he forgot Frank because he's upset or because Frank is a chicken?"

"Both," Sophie said.

THE FRIENDSHIP PROBLEM

I found Brad beside the sports shed.

The repaired door now opened properly.

He was kicking a football against the wall.

Each kick sounded harder than the last.

"You should take the offer," I said.

"Why?"

"Because you're good."

"Westbridge doesn't want me. They want our best player before the showcase game."

"Maybe both."

"They want me to wear their jacket."

"It's training, not a loyalty oath."

He kicked the ball again.

"You sound like Mr. Vane."

That hurt.

"Why?"

"Everything is a system. Join the better programme. Move to the better building. Forget who you played with."

I picked up the ball when it bounced back.

"This isn't about buildings. It's about you getting a chance."

"And if I go, everyone says Brookfield's own council doesn't believe in it."

He was thinking about loyalty.

I was thinking about opportunities.

Neither of us was completely wrong.

I hated that.

THE SHOWCASE MATCH

The City Schools Showcase included a friendly basketball match.

Brookfield versus Westbridge.

Brad was Brookfield's captain.

Lucas was Westbridge's student coordinator, although he spent more time organising water bottles than playing.

The match was supposed to demonstrate cooperation.

Then someone posted a message online.

BRAD LEAVING BROOKFIELD BEFORE IT CLOSES.

There was a photograph of him reading the offer.

Only six people had seen the letter.

Our table.

A teacher.

Lucas.

The coach.

Brad thought Lucas had posted it.

Lucas denied it.

Sophie checked the account.

New.

Anonymous.

Profile picture: a Westbridge badge.

Too obvious again.

I was getting tired of obvious clues.

Students began arguing online.

Brookfield called Brad a traitor.

Westbridge called him a future champion.

Nobody asked Brad what he wanted.

At practice, two Brookfield players refused to pass to him.

Brad threw down the ball and walked off.

The showcase team was falling apart.

Noah suggested replacing basketball with chess.

Oliver agreed.

Everyone else said no.

BRAD'S DECISION

On Wednesday, Brad asked to use the council meeting.

He stood at the front with the letter.

"I'm joining the development squad."

Students began whispering.

He continued.

"I'm not transferring. I'll train at Westbridge and play for Brookfield until the city makes us stop."

Lucas nodded.

"The coach agreed?"

"Yes."

"Then Westbridge will support that."

A Brookfield player stood up.

"Why should we keep you captain?"

Brad looked at him.

"Because I know where every one of you likes the ball. Because I stay after practice when you miss shots. Because I care whether we win. Not because of the name on my shirt."

Nobody spoke.

Then Noah raised his hand.

"Also because he can actually do push-ups."

Laughter broke the tension.

The team voted.

Brad stayed captain.

Afterwards, he found me outside.

"You were right about the offer."

"You were right about loyalty."

"Don't make it a big thing."

"I won't."

"And don't write it in your diary."

"Too late."

He punched my shoulder.

It hurt.

Things were back to normal.

THE MISSING LETTER

Sophie asked to see Brad's original letter.

The online photograph showed a corner of the council room in the background.

The picture had been taken through the window while we sat at lunch.

Anyone outside could have done it.

But the text had been written by someone who knew the review.

The post said:

ONE COUNCIL ALREADY ACCEPTS THE MERGER.

Brad hadn't accepted anything.

Someone wanted Westbridge and Brookfield fighting before the community consultation.

Justice requested the account records.

The account had been created from a school library computer.

Our library.

At 12:42 on Monday.

The login belonged to Ethan.

He was as shocked as we were.

His password had been written on a budget sheet stored in the council room.

The same room Mr. Vane's review team had used.

The same room Helen had visited.

The same room Lucas had worked in.

Another circle.

No clean suspect.

Sophie changed every password again.

Justice reminded us not to investigate.

So we did the only thing we could.

We made the truth public.

Brad posted his own statement.

No insults.

No accusations.

Just his decision.

Lucas shared it.

The Brookfield team shared it.

Within an hour, the anonymous account deleted itself.

The screenshot remained.

And in the corner, barely visible, was the reflection of the person holding the phone.

Silver hair.

Dark suit.

I showed Mr. Vane.

He looked at the reflection.

"It could be me. It could be Richard Stone. It could be half the city office."

"Were you outside the council room on Monday?"

"Yes."

"Did you take the photograph?"

"No."

"Did you see who did?"

He paused.

"Helen Ward."

Of course.

She was back again.

But this time, Mr. Vane offered to testify.

"I didn't report it because she asked me to meet her. She said she had the ballot pages."

"Did she?"

"No. She showed me an empty envelope."

"Where?"

"The old bookshop."

I looked at the time on the post.

12:42.

Mr. Vane had been outside at 12:38.

Helen had been holding the phone.

At least, that was his story.

And the only way to test it was to visit the bookshop without telling her we knew.

CHAPTER 20

The Bookshop Camera

Thursday

Clara's bookshop had one security camera.

It pointed at the front door.

It had not worked for six years.

Noah tapped it.

"Let me guess. Empty box."

Clara looked offended.

"No. It is a fully functional empty box."

We were not there for the camera.

We were there for the shop's online-order computer.

It faced the pavement outside.

Its video-call software had automatically recorded a test on Monday.

Clara had discovered the recording while searching old receipts.

On the screen, Mr. Vane stood outside the council-room window.

I could see Brookfield across the street in the reflection of the bookshop glass.

Beside him was Helen.

She held a phone.

He pointed toward the window.

She took a picture.

Then she handed him the phone.

Mr. Vane typed something.

Posted something.

Deleted something.

My stomach tightened.

He had lied.

Not about being there.

About who posted it.

Justice watched the recording twice.

Mr. Vane sat at the end of the table.

"I posted the statement."

"Why?" she asked.

"To force Brad's decision into the open."

"You accused a student of betrayal."

"I used the words already circulating among students."

"You wrote them."

"Yes."

He didn't apologise.

He didn't explain that he had been trying to help.

He simply accepted the fact.

Justice removed him from the review panel entirely.

The city would appoint a temporary administrator while the investigation continued.

Richard Stone's company was suspended from transporting school records.

Helen admitted creating the anonymous account.

Again, she said it was necessary.

Again, someone else paid the price.

Sophie stared at the video.

"Everyone keeps saying the school is in danger, so they can do whatever they want."

Justice nodded.

"That is often how rules disappear."

THE BALLAD ENVELOPE

Helen had shown Mr. Vane an empty envelope at the bookshop.

He had kept it.

Justice made him hand it over.

On the front were the words:

ORIGINAL BALLOTS — RETURN TO BROOKFIELD.

On the back was a partial fingerprint and a drop of brown wax.

Clara recognised the wax.

"The promise box."

The metal box beneath the oak had been sealed with the same wax.

Someone had placed the envelope there recently.

We returned to the stone marker with Justice and the principal.

The box was empty except for mud.

But the wax on its lid had been broken and resealed.

The original badge key still worked.

Only four people had access to it.

The principal.

Sophie.

Me.

Mr. Vane.

The badge had spent two days in the office safe.

Mr. Vane had signed it out once.

For the archive visit.

I had carried it that day.

He could have taken a mould.

Or used it while I searched boxes.

Again, too many possibilities.

Noah crouched beside the stone.

"There's writing underneath."

We had cleaned the top but never turned it over.

With the caretaker's help, we lifted the stone marker.

On the underside was a second inscription.

BALLOT COPIES WITH THE NINTH CLASS.

"What is the ninth class?" I asked.

Clara shook her head.

Justice's mother would know.

She did.

"Before schools used year groups, Brookfield called its original student representatives the Ninth Class. Nine students from different neighbourhoods."

"Where would they keep copies?"

"The class book."

The class book was not a register.

It was a yearly album made by students.

Each class produced one.

The first Ninth Class album was in Brookfield's library.

I had seen it during Open Week.

It contained drawings, photographs, and promises.

We found it on the history shelf.

Inside the back cover was an envelope.

Inside the envelope were nine copied ballot pages.

All rejected development.

Each signed by a community representative.

Not enough to prove the full vote.

Enough to prove the official summary had lied.

Justice photographed every page.

Then she called the city and formally halted the merger timetable.

For the first time in weeks, the school was not counting down to a vote.

I sat beneath the oak tree with Noah, Sophie, Brad, and Lucas.

We had done it.

Partly.

The register was safe.

The review was independent.

The city had to consider real evidence.

Noah leaned against the trunk.

"So we're finished?"

Sophie laughed.

"The showcase is in three weeks."

"And the ballot pages are still incomplete," I said.

Brad threw a ball at Lucas.

"And we have a game to win."

Lucas caught it.

"You have a game to try."

There it was.

Normal rivalry.

Much better than corruption.

A WEEK WITHOUT AN ANONYMOUS ACCOUNT

For seven days after the post was deleted, nobody created a new one.

The silence was almost suspicious.

Then students started using their own names.

A Brookfield player posted that Brad had helped him practise.

A Westbridge student posted a photograph of the joint warm-up.

Lucas published the actual training schedule.

The truth turned out to be much less dramatic than the anonymous account. It was also harder to manipulate because everyone could check it.

Brad kept the original offer letter in his sports folder. Under the coach's signature, he wrote: TRAIN ANYWHERE. REMEMBER WHO PASSES TO YOU.

Noah said it needed more snacks.

Brad said it did not.

THE NINTH CLASS ALBUM

That evening, I took the album home to scan it.

Justice had approved a digital archive.

Every page would be available to students and families.

At the back, behind the ballot envelope, I found a folded list of addresses.

Nine neighbourhoods.

Nine students.

Nine promises.

The final address had no name.

Only a room number.

75.

I almost closed the book.

Room 75 was supposed to be finished.

Then I noticed the handwriting.

It matched the notes in my locker.

Not Helen's.

Not Clara's.

Someone else had been writing the folded-wing hawk all along.

And the final line of the address list read:

WHEN THE SCHOOL IS SAFE, RETURN WHAT YOU BORROWED.

I looked at my shelf.

The original council badge sat beside Greg.

I had forgotten to return it after opening the promise box.

The note was not about the register.

It was about the badge.

Someone had been inside my house.

Or inside my bedroom.

Or the note had been written before I ever borrowed it.

Both possibilities were impossible.

One had to be true.

CHAPTER 21

Return to Room 75

Friday

I did not go into Room 75 alone.

This sentence deserves its own paragraph because everyone who knew me would otherwise assume I had.

Sophie came.

Noah came.

Brad came.

Justice came.

The principal unlocked the door and stood beside it with the expression of a man who had hoped never to use that key again.

Room 75 looked smaller than I remembered.

Dusty shelves.

Old boxes.

A table with one wobbly leg.

The place where the Black Hawks had hidden their evidence was now an ordinary storage room with a very unordinary history.

I put the original council badge on the table.

"I borrowed it."

"You had permission," the principal said.

"Still borrowed."

Justice read the note from the album.

"Who wrote it?"

Sophie compared the handwriting with our evidence photographs.

"Not Helen. Not Clara. Not Mr. Vane."

Noah picked up a box.

"Maybe Room 75 writes notes."

Nobody answered.

We had all experienced stranger things.

Justice made us catalogue everything before moving it.

Box one: festival ribbons.

Box two: broken trophies.

Box three: attendance registers.

Box four: damaged cameras.

Box five: school maps.

No secret compartments.

No ballot pages.

No clue that explained the note.

Then Brad tried to put the badge on his jacket.

It wouldn't fasten.

The pin had folded back.

Inside the pin mechanism was a tiny rolled piece of paper.

Sophie removed it with tweezers.

The note was old.

Not new.

RETURN WHAT YOU BORROWED.

Someone had written the same instruction decades earlier.

The handwriting matched the album because both were written by Martha Moyo.

The note in my album had been there for years.

I had discovered it after taking the badge.

A coincidence.

Noah looked disappointed.

"So nobody broke into your house?"

"No."

"That's good."

"I know."

"But less interesting."

THE NINTH DRAWER

The old note had another line on the back.

THE NINTH CLASS KEEPS THE NINTH DRAWER.

There were nine drawers in the Room 75 cabinet.

We opened them in order.

One: pens.

Two: film.

Three: keys.

Four: envelopes.

Five: photographs.

Six: empty.

Seven: minutes.

Eight: maps.

Nine: stuck.

Brad reached for it.

Sophie stopped him.

"Not with force."

Noah tapped the top of the cabinet.

The drawer slid open.

We stared at him.

"What? Old things like being tapped."

Inside was a cassette tape and a list of nine names.

The Ninth Class.

Martha Moyo was number one.

Clara's grandmother was number two.

The others were community representatives from the school's first year.

Next to each name was a location.

Library.

Church hall.

Shop.

Sports club.

Cafe.

Bus depot.

Community centre.

Oak tree.

Home.

"Ballot copies," Sophie said. "They gave one to every representative."

"And the ninth?" I asked.

Noah read the list.

"Home."

Justice looked at her mother's address written beside it.

"I have the ninth. We need the other eight."

Eight locations.

Eight possible copies.

Eight people who might have kept a school promise for decades.

The showcase was three weeks away.

Finally, we had a plan that did not involve a locked door.

We had to ask an entire neighbourhood.

THE OLD CASSETTE

The tape contained a recording of the first promise day.

Students read the charter beside the oak tree.

Adults cheered.

Someone played a piano badly.

Then Martha Moyo spoke.

"If anyone tells you this school belongs to the city, remind them the city is made of people. If anyone tells you it belongs to the students, remind them students grow up. It belongs to everyone who needs it, now and next."

Noah stopped smiling.

Sophie stopped writing.

Even Brad stood still.

The recording continued.

"And if anyone says a promise is too old, tell them they are standing under a tree that was planted before they were born."

Through the window, I could see the oak.

Its branches moved in the wind.

I understood what our showcase needed to be.

Not a defence of one building.

A renewal of the promises.

The city could review Brookfield.

The community could choose its future.

But nobody would decide quietly.

THE FIRST COPY

We visited the cafe first.

The original representative had owned it before Daniel took over the lease.

Her daughter still worked there.

She remembered a school envelope in the back of a recipe book.

Inside was ballot copy number two.

REJECT DEVELOPMENT.

The second location was the church hall.

The envelope was framed behind a piano.

Copy number three.

REJECT DEVELOPMENT.

The third was Clara's bookshop.

Copy number four.

REJECT DEVELOPMENT.

By Sunday evening, we had four.

On Monday, the bus depot gave us number five.

The sports club gave us number six.

The community centre had lost number seven in a flood.

The original library held number eight.

We had seven of nine, including Justice's mother's copy.

All rejected development.

Only the community-centre copy was missing.

The official summary claimed a narrow vote in favour.

Seven surviving ballots already proved the summary false.

Justice took them to the city.

The old development approval was withdrawn.

The current proposal lost its legal foundation.

Mr. Vane's merger plan was effectively dead.

Or should have been.

On Tuesday morning, the city announced a new proposal.

Not a merger based on the old development.

An emergency closure based on building safety.

An engineering report said Brookfield's main hall was structurally unsafe.

The report had been commissioned by Mr. Vane two months earlier.

The hall was closed immediately.

The showcase was moved to Westbridge.

And students were told to prepare for temporary classrooms.

I stood outside the sealed hall with my friends.

We had won the old argument.

Someone had simply started a new one.

CHAPTER 22

The Crack in the Hall

Wednesday

There was a crack above the stage.

I had seen it before.

Everyone had.

It ran from the ceiling to the top of the old curtain rail and looked a little like a lightning bolt.

Last term, Noah had named it Gerald.

Now Gerald was evidence.

The engineering report described structural movement, roof instability, and immediate risk.

A photograph showed the crack highlighted in red.

The report recommended closure of the main building until further investigation.

Not just the hall.

The classrooms beside it.

The library.

The council room.

Half the school.

Noah read the report.

"Gerald got promoted."

"This isn't funny," Sophie said.

"I know. If I don't joke, I'll think about moving to Westbridge."

Temporary classrooms would arrive next week.

The city said they would stay for at least a year.

Parents were furious.

Teachers were worried.

Students were mostly excited about classrooms with wheels.

Mr. Vane was no longer on the review panel, but his report remained part of the evidence.

Justice ordered an independent inspection.

It would take ten days.

The showcase was in fifteen.

The closure decision would happen immediately afterwards.

The timing was perfect for anyone who wanted Brookfield empty.

THE INDEPENDENT ENGINEER

The new engineer was Dr. Aisha Rahman.

She wore bright yellow boots and asked students what they had noticed.

Mr. Vane's engineer had not spoken to us.

Dr. Rahman spent an hour listening to the caretaker, teachers, and students.

Brad told her the sports hall floor shook during basketball.

Oliver told her the chess club ceiling leaked.

Sophie showed her repair reports.

I told her when Gerald had first appeared.

"Three years ago," I said.

The caretaker confirmed it.

Dr. Rahman photographed the crack.

"Three years is important. Rapid movement and old settlement are different problems."

"Can you tell from looking?"

"No. I tell by measuring."

Finally, an adult who refused to give an immediate answer.

I liked her.

She installed small monitors across the hall.

They would measure movement every hour.

Until then, the hall stayed closed.

THE SHOWCASE WITHOUT A HALL

We had planned to hold part of the showcase at Brookfield.

Now everything would happen at Westbridge.

Lucas offered extra space.

His council helped move our displays.

It should have brought us closer.

Instead, Brookfield students complained that we were presenting our school in the building that wanted to replace it.

Westbridge students complained that their showcase had been taken over.

The online arguments returned.

Lucas and I spent a whole evening deleting insults from the joint event page.

Noah suggested replacing all comments with pictures of Greg.

For once, it seemed like a sensible moderation policy.

Sophie reorganised the booth.

Instead of two halves, we would build a circle.

Brookfield projects.

Westbridge projects.

Shared projects.

Community promises.

No school at the centre.

The students at the centre.

It looked good on paper.

Then Westbridge delivered our display boards to the wrong hall.

Brad's team found their practice time cancelled.

The Brookfield microphone disappeared again.

And Mr. Vane arrived at Westbridge with a city security pass.

Justice had removed him from the panel.

She had not banned him from public events.

He walked around our booth taking photographs.

"What are you doing?" I asked.

"Observing."

"For whom?"

"Myself."

He stopped at the community-council diagram.

"You think this will protect the school?"

"It will protect the decisions."

"From what?"

"From anyone who thinks they already know the answer."

He looked at me.

"That includes you."

Then he walked away.

He was right.

That was the annoying part.

THE STUDENT MEASUREMENTS

While we waited for Dr. Rahman's results, the coding club built a public page showing the hall monitors.

Students could see whether the crack moved.

Most days, the numbers barely changed.

That did not make the building safe by itself, but it stopped rumours from growing faster than the damage.

One message claimed the roof had moved thirty centimetres overnight.

Oliver checked the graph.

Thirty millimetres became zero point three millimetres when someone read the units correctly.

Sophie added a lesson about units to the evidence workshop.

Noah asked whether Gerald could be measured in chickens.

Dr. Rahman said no.

THE SCHOOL NEWSPAPER

The student newspaper published a front-page diagram of the hall.

No rumours.

No red circles.

Just a labelled explanation of what was known, what was being measured, and when the next report would arrive.

Underneath, the editor printed a box titled QUESTIONS WE CANNOT ANSWER YET.

It contained three honest uncertainties.

Mr. Vane said admitting uncertainty would weaken public confidence.

A Year Seven wrote a response saying invented certainty was worse.

He read the response twice and asked the newspaper to include his original comment beside it.

The next issue contained both.

For once, the school learned about a dangerous building without turning the danger into a legend.

EMILY'S CONFESSION

That evening, Emily asked me to meet her at the bookshop.

She had Martha Moyo's album open on the table.

"The notes in your locker," she said. "I wrote the first one."

I sat down.

"Not Helen?"

"Helen wrote the later ones. I started it."

"Why?"

"Because when I heard about the review, I recognised Adrian's methods. I needed you to ask Daniel about the register."

"You could have asked him yourself."

"I did. He said the register was gone."

"You could have told me."

Emily looked ashamed.

"After everything that happened last term, I didn't want to pull you into another adult mess. Then I realised the students were the only people Adrian couldn't control."

"So you used me."

"Yes."

She didn't soften it.

I respected that.

I also wanted to leave.

Emily continued.

"I wrote the first note and the archive warning. Helen wrote the others. The message about Westbridge B2 was hers. The note in the album was Martha's."

"What about the note saying Mr. Vane wanted the deed?"

"Mine. I was guessing."

"It was true."

"That doesn't make guessing evidence."

Sophie would have liked her.

I folded my arms.

"Why tell me now?"

"Because I need you to stop treating every clue as instructions. The people sending notes were frightened. We made mistakes. You turned some of them into bigger ones."

It hurt because it was true.

Every secret message had made me feel chosen.

Important.

Like only I could solve things.

But leadership wasn't being chosen by a mysterious note.

It was listening when nobody was watching.

"Okay," I said.

Emily looked surprised.

"Okay?"

"Yes. No more notes. If someone has information, they sign their name."

She smiled.

"That is a very good rule."

THE SIGNED MESSAGE

The next morning, a message appeared beneath the showcase display.

It was signed.

DR. RAHMAN.

All it said was:

THE CRACK IS OLD. THE HOLES ARE NEW.

Underneath was a photograph of six small holes drilled into the hall's roof supports.

They had not appeared in Mr. Vane's engineering report.

But they appeared in the latest structural photographs.

Someone had damaged the supports after the first inspection.

And Gerald the crack had nothing to do with it.

CHAPTER 23

Six Small Holes

Thursday

Six holes can change an entire school.

Dr. Rahman explained it with a pencil.

She held it between both hands.

"This is a roof beam. It can carry weight if its full shape is intact."

Then she drew six dots near the middle.

"Drill here repeatedly and you weaken it. The damage may not cause immediate collapse, but an engineer has to treat it seriously."

"Could someone do it accidentally?" Sophie asked.

"One hole, perhaps. Six in matching positions? No."

The holes had been drilled during the review.

Mr. Vane's engineer had photographed the beams before they appeared.

The building had been locked after school.

Access logs showed three contractors.

A roof inspector.

A network installer.

A Stonebridge Transport crew moving archive boxes.

All had signed in.

All had adult supervision.

None should have been alone long enough to drill six holes.

Justice requested security footage.

The relevant cameras had been switched off for privacy during student interviews.

A sensible decision with a suspicious result.

Again.

THE NETWORK CABLE

Brad noticed something in the photographs.

A black cable ran through one of the new holes.

"Why is there a wire?"

Dr. Rahman zoomed in.

It was a network cable.

The coding club had requested better Wi-Fi in the hall.

A city contractor installed it two weeks earlier.

The work order specified drilling through wooden panels, not structural supports.

The installer had used the wrong route.

Perhaps incompetence.

Perhaps instructions.

Justice interviewed him.

He said a city supervisor had pointed to the beams and told him where to drill.

The supervisor's name was on the work order.

H. WARD.

Helen again.

This time, she did not admit it.

"I never approved building work."

The signature was forged.

Same method.

Different target.

Someone wanted her responsible for every problem.

Or she was responsible and had learned to deny things selectively.

I didn't know which possibility was worse.

THE REAL SUPERVISOR

The installer remembered the supervisor.

Not a woman.

A man.

Silver hair.

Dark suit.

Mr. Vane.

Justice showed him photographs.

He identified Mr. Vane immediately.

Mr. Vane denied being in the hall.

His calendar said he was at a city meeting.

Twelve officials confirmed it.

The installer had spoken to someone who looked like him.

Richard Stone also had silver hair.

He often wore dark suits.

The installer had not met him before.

Shown a second set of photographs, he hesitated.

Then he pointed to Richard.

"That's him."

Lucas was sitting beside his father when the identification happened.

Richard stood up.

"This is ridiculous."

The installer held his ground.

"You told me the beams were decorative. You said the school was being rewired before demolition."

Lucas looked at his father.

"Demolition?"

Richard said nothing.

Justice suspended all Stonebridge contracts and referred the damage for criminal investigation.

The hall remained closed.

Damage was damage, whoever caused it.

But Dr. Rahman confirmed the main building could be used with temporary supports.

The repairs would take weeks, not years.

The emergency closure argument collapsed.

Brookfield would stay open while the review continued.

Students cheered when the principal announced it.

Lucas did not.

His father had been escorted out by investigators.

I found him beside the empty showcase booth.

"Are you okay?"

"No."

I didn't know what to say.

My usual answer was to find a clue.

There was no clue that made this better.

"My dad knew I wanted the partnership," Lucas said.

"Maybe he thought he was protecting Westbridge."

"By damaging yours?"

I sat beside him.

"You helped stop it."

"I also helped collect the archive. I believed him."

"So did a lot of adults."

"That doesn't make it better."

"No."

We sat quietly.

Then Noah arrived with two cups of hot chocolate.

One from the Westbridge machine.

One from a flask.

He handed them to us.

"The machine is innocent."

Lucas laughed despite himself.

Not much.

Enough.

LUCAS AT THE GATE

The next morning, Lucas would not come through Brookfield's front gate.

He said students would blame him for his father.

Brad solved the problem by meeting him at the pavement with two basketballs.

"You can stand here feeling guilty or come inside and help me practise."

Lucas chose practice.

A few students stared. Nobody insulted him.

Oliver asked whether Westbridge was still entering the chess tournament.

Mia asked him to check the homework-club forms.

Being given ordinary jobs helped more than another speech about forgiveness.

By lunch, he was sitting at our usual table. His father was still under investigation. Our friendship was still complicated. But Lucas had somewhere to sit.

THE CONTRACTOR'S APOLOGY

The network installer wrote a letter to the students.

He said he had followed instructions without asking enough questions and was sorry his work had frightened everyone.

Mia invited him to the safety meeting.

He explained how students could report exposed cables and why only qualified people should inspect structural damage.

Noah asked whether a rubber chicken counted as qualified testing equipment.

The installer said no.

Brad put Frank away.

The apology did not remove his responsibility, but it turned him from a mysterious suspect into a person who could help prevent the next mistake.

Sophie attached his safety guidance to the final report.

THE SUPPORTS

Temporary supports arrived at Brookfield on Friday.

They were bright red steel frames.

The hall looked like it was wearing scaffolding on the inside.

Dr. Rahman marked safe areas.

The city allowed us to hold one final event there before the showcase.

Promise Day.

Every class would read a promise beside the oak.

Clubs would display their work.

Families would vote on whether to support the community-council plan.

Not the merger.

Just the process.

Justice insisted the distinction be printed everywhere.

No hidden consent.

No confusing forms.

Sophie designed the ballot.

One question.

One box for yes.

One for no.

One space for comments.

No signatures required unless people wanted to volunteer.

Noah tested the form on his little sister.

She understood it in twenty seconds.

It passed.

Mr. Vane requested permission to attend.

Justice allowed it.

"I thought he was suspended," I said.

"He is still a former teacher and a resident. A public meeting means public."

He stood at the back during Promise Day.

When Martha Moyo's recording played, he closed his eyes.

Perhaps he remembered being young enough to vote against the development.

Perhaps he was thinking about his career.

I couldn't tell.

Then the community vote opened.

And someone stole the empty ballot box before the first vote was cast.

CHAPTER 24

The Empty Ballot Box

Saturday

The empty ballot box was under the stage.

The person who took it did not know it was empty.

They had grabbed it from the registration table and run through the hall.

Brad saw them.

Noah shouted.

I chased them.

Then I remembered Rule 2, stopped, and told an adult instead of running through a side door.

Personal growth is sometimes very annoying.

The caretaker found the box five minutes later.

The thief had escaped through the main entrance.

Students described a grey hoodie.

Adults described a city jacket.

Brad described "someone fast."

No useful identification.

Justice closed the voting area.

Sophie brought out the spare ballot box.

Because of course Sophie had a spare.

Noah labelled it:

BALLOT BOX 2 — THE ONE NOBODY EXPECTED.

Justice made him change it to:

OFFICIAL BALLOT BOX.

The vote restarted.

THE PROBLEM WITH PUBLIC MEETINGS

For the next hour, people argued.

Not about whether they liked Brookfield.

About what saving it meant.

One parent wanted a merger because Westbridge had better science rooms.

A teacher worried about larger classes.

A neighbour wanted the school field open every weekend.

A student wanted no changes at all.

Mr. Vane stood beside the coffee table debating with Clara.

Daniel wanted the old Black Hawks recognised.

Emily wanted their mistakes acknowledged too.

Justice listened to everyone.

The community council did not feel neat anymore.

It felt loud, slow, and inconvenient.

Noah leaned toward me.

"Listening was easier when the kitchen staff already knew the answer."

"Yes."

"Are we sure this is better?"

"Yes."

"Even when people disagree?"

"Especially then."

At noon, the last ballot was cast.

Two student representatives and two community volunteers counted together.

One hundred and eighty-four people supported the community-council trial.

Twenty-seven opposed it.

Nine left comments only.

The result did not decide the merger.

It proved people wanted a voice in whatever came next.

Justice signed the count.

So did Mr. Vane.

I was surprised he agreed.

He said, "A valid process is a valid process."

Perhaps systems were his way of caring.

He just forgot the people inside them sometimes.

THE BOX UNDER THE STAGE

After the count, the caretaker examined the stolen ballot box.

Something rattled underneath its false bottom.

Not ballots.

A tiny digital recorder.

It had been running during every argument, private conversation, and planning session near the registration table.

Justice checked its memory.

The recordings included me discussing the showcase layout.

Sophie discussing ballot security.

Lucas talking about his father.

Mr. Vane talking to Helen.

And a voice nobody recognised saying, "Take it when the crowd moves."

The thief had not wanted empty ballots.

They had wanted the recorder removed before anyone found it.

Why?

Because the recorder contained evidence of who had been directing them.

Justice copied the file.

Near the end, a second voice answered.

"Leave it behind the Westbridge display."

That voice belonged to Richard Stone.

He was under investigation.

He should not have been at Promise Day.

But the recording was dated before his suspension.

Three days earlier.

The theft had been planned then.

The ballot-box grab was only about removing the recorder.

The real operation had already happened at Westbridge.

Something had been left behind our display.

We called Lucas.

He was at the showcase hall.

"Don't touch anything," Justice told him.

Too late.

The Brookfield display had just been opened by city safety officers.

Inside was a plastic folder marked:

STOLEN BALLOT ORIGINALS.

And a smoke device.

THE HALL EVACUATION

The smoke device was not a bomb.

It was a theatrical smoke cartridge from our own drama club.

It produced enough smoke to fill the Westbridge hall and trigger an evacuation.

Everyone got out safely.

The displays did not.

Water from the sprinklers soaked the cardboard booths.

Posters collapsed.

Photographs ran.

The joint map dissolved into blue and red streaks.

Three weeks of work became wet paper in ten minutes.

No injuries.

No fire.

One ruined showcase.

Lucas stood outside in his wet Westbridge jacket.

"They'll postpone the event."

Justice shook her head.

"The city says the schedule cannot change. The showcase is tomorrow morning."

Noah looked at his ruined poster.

"We have fifteen hours."

Sophie took out her phone.

"Then we need every club."

Brad called the team.

Mia called the homework club.

Ethan called the fundraising volunteers.

Lucas called the Westbridge council.

I called Daniel and Emily.

Within an hour, both schools' dining halls were full of students, parents, teachers, and neighbours.

We did not rebuild the displays exactly.

There was no time.

We printed the photographs from the digital archive.

We used plain paper.

We wrote the promises by hand.

Justice brought the original register under security.

Clara brought the first programme.

Mrs. Moyo brought Martha's album.

Dr. Rahman brought the building report.

The kitchen staff brought food.

At midnight, the new booth looked less professional.

It looked better.

Because you could see the fingerprints.

THE FOLDER

The stolen ballot folder contained copies.

Not originals.

Someone wanted us to think we had recovered the missing votes.

Why?

So we would stop searching.

Justice held the copies up to the light.

Each page had the same faint line across the top.

A photocopier defect.

The line matched Westbridge's records-centre machine.

Lucas remembered seeing his father use it.

Richard had copied the ballots before hiding the originals.

Which meant the originals might still exist.

And the machine's internal storage might contain a scan.

The technicians checked.

One file remained.

A complete scan of every ballot.

All rejected development.

The full proof.

At 1:12 in the morning, Justice certified the digital evidence and sent it to the city.

No more missing pages.

No more claim that the community had approved development.

We had the truth.

But the school review was still not over.

Mr. Vane's final report had been submitted that evening.

It recommended Brookfield remain open only if the student council was replaced and the merger remained available for future consideration.

He had accepted the vote.

Accepted the building evidence.

Accepted the ballots.

And still thought we were the problem.

Tomorrow, at the showcase, I would have to answer him.

Not with a clue.

With a speech.

I hate speeches.

CHAPTER 25

The Showcase Begins

Sunday

I slept for two hours.

Noah slept under a table.

Brad said he didn't sleep because athletes understood pressure, then yawned so widely he nearly fell over.

Sophie did not sleep at all.

She checked the new ballot records, the display labels, the emergency contacts, and the projector.

At six in the morning, Justice made her eat breakfast.

At seven, we returned to Westbridge.

The damaged hall had been cleaned.

The wet booths were gone.

Our replacement display stood in the centre.

Handwritten promises.

Printed photographs.

The Founders' Register inside a clear case.

And one rubber chicken sitting on the community-council diagram.

"Greg is not part of the display," Sophie said.

Brad removed him.

At eight, the doors opened.

THE OTHER SCHOOLS

Westbridge's main booth had working screens and a video about science.

North Park School had built a robot.

St. Anne's had a choir.

Riverside had a garden with actual vegetables.

Our booth had tape on the corners.

Noah looked at the robot.

"Can it play basketball?"

"No," its designer said.

"Can it squeak?"

"No."

"Then I think we're okay."

Judges moved between booths.

They asked about attendance, budgets, leadership, safety, and community impact.

Sophie answered the technical questions.

Lucas explained the partnership.

I spoke about the review.

Then Justice announced that the final presentations would happen at eleven.

Each school had eight minutes.

Ours would be judged by the city panel and a public audience.

Mr. Vane sat in the second row.

Richard Stone was absent.

Helen watched from the back with a city investigator beside her.

Daniel, Emily, and Clara sat together.

Three generations of Brookfield students filled the room.

I had written a speech.

Twelve pages.

Sophie said it was too long.

I reduced it to six.

Justice said it was too defensive.

I reduced it to three.

Noah said it had no jokes.

I put the pages away.

THE FIRST DISASTER

At 10:42, the projector failed.

Westbridge technicians tried a cable.

Nothing.

Our video would not play.

The presentation included attendance graphs, club photographs, and Dr. Rahman's building report.

Without it, we had a folder and eight students.

Lucas offered Westbridge's backup laptop.

Mr. Vane pointed out that only authorised city equipment could connect to the system.

Justice overruled him.

The backup laptop worked.

Then the file opened blank.

Someone had replaced our presentation with an empty document.

Sophie checked the version history.

The file had been edited at 6:14 that morning.

From my account.

I had been asleep.

Everyone looked at me.

Mr. Vane leaned back.

Another password failure.

Another convenient scandal.

But this time, Sophie smiled.

"I removed your editing access last night."

"What?"

"You kept changing headings after the final checks. Your account has read-only access."

She opened the access log.

My old credentials had been used on a different device.

The system rejected the edit.

The blank document was only a locally saved file, not our real presentation.

The original was safe in Justice's sealed folder.

Sophie plugged in the drive.

The slides appeared.

Noah whispered, "I love spreadsheets."

The audience did not hear him.

I did.

I had never loved one more.

EIGHT MINUTES

At eleven, they called our names.

Brookfield and Westbridge walked onto the stage together.

Lucas stood at one microphone.

I stood at the other.

The presentation began with the photograph from my first festival.

Greg above my head.

The principal smiling nervously.

People laughed.

Good.

Then the screen showed the first Brookfield charter.

Lucas spoke about Westbridge's achievements.

Sophie explained the community-council trial.

Noah described the lunch queues.

Brad talked about training at Westbridge while playing for Brookfield.

Mia shared the homework-club numbers.

My turn came.

I looked at my three pages.

Then at Mr. Vane.

He had asked whether everything depended on me.

The answer stood all around the stage.

I folded the speech.

"Brookfield isn't perfect," I said.

The room went quiet.

"Our hall has a crack. Our attendance dropped. We lost forms. We used the wrong room-booking forms. Our council made mistakes that are not mysterious or exciting. They were just mistakes."

Sophie watched me carefully.

"But when something went wrong, we didn't wait for someone important to fix it. Students measured the problem. Teachers helped. Families came. Neighbours brought documents they had kept for decades. Westbridge students helped rebuild this display after someone tried to ruin it."

Lucas nodded.

"The ninth promise says the school stays while students can show it serves the community. I used to think that meant proving we deserved to win. It doesn't. It means doing the work."

I pointed to the community-council diagram.

"This is our plan. Public decisions. Shared records. Class representatives. Neighbourhood forums. No hidden votes. No secret changes. It will still work after we leave."

Mr. Vane's expression did not change.

"And if the city decides Brookfield should merge, we'll argue with evidence. If it decides we stay open, we'll keep fixing the roof. Either way, nobody gets to call applause permission."

The audience was silent for one second.

Then Martha Moyo's mother started clapping.

Everyone else followed.

Not a vote.

Just applause.

Exactly what it should be.

THE SCORES

North Park's robot won the innovation prize.

St. Anne's choir won the arts prize.

Westbridge and Brookfield won the community-leadership prize together.

Lucas held one side of the certificate.

I held the other.

Noah held Greg in the middle.

The judges praised the partnership.

They did not announce the school decision.

That would happen at a formal city meeting the following Friday.

We had six days.

Mr. Vane approached after the ceremony.

"That was a better answer."

"To whether it depends on me?"

"Yes."

"Did it change your report?"

"No."

He looked at the students taking down the booth.

"My recommendation concerns governance standards, not whether I like your speech."

"Will you explain that at the meeting?"

"Yes."

"Will you tell them about the damage, the hidden votes, and Helen?"

"Yes."

"Even if it hurts the city department?"

He paused.

"Yes."

For the first time, I believed him.

That evening, the city published his full report online.

Every criticism.

Every failure.

Every piece of evidence.

Including an appendix nobody expected.

A second structural report commissioned by Mr. Vane after Dr. Rahman's findings.

It confirmed Brookfield could be repaired for less than the cost of building temporary classrooms.

He had submitted it before our presentation.

He had not told us.

Perhaps Mr. Vane did not want to be liked.

Perhaps he wanted the decision to survive every challenge.

Either way, his final recommendation no longer said the council should be replaced.

Someone had changed it after submission.

And the change had been approved by the only person still authorised to sign for the review.

Justice Moyo.

CHAPTER 26

Justice's Signature

Monday

Justice Moyo did not change Mr. Vane's report.

She showed us the signed version in her own case.

The recommendation was clear.

Brookfield remains open under its elected council, subject to normal building and financial reviews.

The online version said the opposite.

Someone had replaced page fourteen.

Justice's digital signature appeared at the bottom.

Her handwritten initials were on every page.

The altered page had a slightly different font.

Sophie spotted it in ten seconds.

"The line spacing is wrong."

Noah looked at the page.

"You can identify a crime by line spacing?"

"Yes."

He nodded as if this was normal.

Justice notified the city immediately.

The document system showed that she had edited the report at 11:36 on Sunday night.

At that time, she had been on stage presenting the community award.

Two thousand witnesses could confirm it.

Her account had been used remotely.

Again.

Another password.

Another forged approval.

Another person made to look dishonest.

Justice closed her laptop.

"Someone has access to the review system itself."

"Can you trace it?" I asked.

"The city can. You cannot."

For once, nobody argued.

We were tired.

Also, the system was not hidden under a tree.

THE ADMINISTRATOR

The review platform had three system administrators.

One worked for the city.

One worked for the company that supplied the software.

One was an emergency account created for the original review.

The emergency account belonged to Mr. Vane.

He handed over his credentials before anyone asked.

"I haven't used it since the inquiry began."

The access log showed the account had been used every week.

By someone who knew his old password.

The password was:

BROOKFIELD9.

Noah stared at the screen.

"That's a terrible password."

Mr. Vane looked offended.

"It was temporary."

"It was also written on the first review folder," Sophie said.

She had a photograph.

The password appeared on a sticky note inside the cover.

Anyone who photographed the folder could have used it.

Helen.

Richard.

Lucas.

Me.

Sophie.

Every member of the review panel.

Even Noah had taken a picture of the folder because he liked the colour of the label.

The suspect list was now basically the whole cast.

JUSTICE STEPS BACK

Justice suspended her own role while the city examined the altered report.

A new oversight officer would attend the final meeting.

Students and parents reacted badly.

Justice had become the person everyone trusted.

Now she looked like another compromised official.

At lunch, students gathered outside the council room.

"Is the decision fixed?"

"Will the school close?"

"Did Justice lie?"

"Can we still have Promise Day?"

I stood on a chair.

Then I remembered Greg was not available and had to get everyone's attention by clapping.

"The report was altered. Justice reported it herself. The original says Brookfield stays open under our council. The city has to investigate."

"Who do we trust now?" someone asked.

It was the question underneath every argument.

Not which school was better.

Not which adult was guilty.

Who could we trust?

I looked at Sophie.

She shook her head slightly.

Don't make another promise you can't prove.

"Trust the public records," I said. "Not just me. The original report, the building evidence, and the ballot copies are available in the library. Read them. Ask questions. Come to the meeting."

It was not a dramatic answer.

It was the right one.

THE PUBLIC READING ROOM

We turned Room 14 into a public reading room.

The cupboard where the register page had been found was sealed.

The tables held copies of every review document.

Sophie created an index.

Mia organised student volunteers.

Ethan made sure financial papers had no private account numbers.

Lucas brought Westbridge's records.

Noah made a sign:

READ BEFORE YOU SHOUT.

Sophie changed it to:

READ. ASK. DISCUSS.

Noah said his version was more realistic.

Parents visited after school.

Teachers checked the reports.

Students who had never cared about council meetings read the land deed.

Mr. Vane came alone.

He sat beside a Year Seven and explained the difference between a recommendation and a decision.

I watched from the doorway.

He was a better teacher than he was a director.

Perhaps he knew it.

THE ONE PAGE WITHOUT A COPY

On Wednesday, Sophie discovered a gap.

The original engineering invoice was missing.

I had the report.

I had Dr. Rahman's response.

But not the invoice showing who had requested the first inspection.

The city system said it was restricted.

Justice requested it.

The invoice named the person who ordered the inspection.

Not Mr. Vane.

Justice Moyo.

She admitted signing it.

"I asked Adrian to arrange an inspection after parents contacted me."

"When?"

"Two months ago. Before I was appointed to the review."

"Why didn't you mention it?"

"Because it was routine. My sister went to Brookfield. Neighbours know my family. They asked me to help."

The inspector who wrote the alarming report had been chosen by Justice.

Not Mr. Vane.

Not Richard.

Her family connection was no longer just an interesting clue.

It was a possible conflict.

Justice looked tired.

"I should have declared it."

"Did you tell the inspector what to write?" Sophie asked.

"No."

"Did you know him before?"

Justice hesitated.

"He was my student."

Another connection.

Another reason for the city to doubt the whole review.

The final meeting was in two days.

And now both directors were compromised.

THE STUDENT REQUEST

The city proposed postponing the decision for three months.

Temporary classrooms would still arrive.

The merger would remain possible.

Everyone would wait again.

Sophie called an emergency community council.

Not a secret meeting.

A public one.

Two hundred people joined online or sat in the dining hall.

She presented one proposal.

No postponement without student and community consent.

The evidence was ready.

The public was ready.

The city should hear the decision on Friday as scheduled.

People voted.

One hundred and sixty-three agreed.

Twenty-two disagreed.

The rest requested more information.

We published every response.

Mr. Vane supported the request.

So did Justice.

So did Westbridge's council.

The city accepted.

Friday would happen.

Then an email arrived from the new oversight officer.

The meeting would be closed to the public for legal reasons.

No students.

No parents.

No community.

Only officials.

The same people who had spent weeks demanding a voice were now locked out again.

Sophie read the message and put down her phone.

"Then we bring the meeting to them."

CHAPTER 27

The Meeting Outside the Meeting

Thursday

We could not force the city to open its meeting.

We checked.

Sophie read the regulations.

Justice read the regulations.

Mr. Vane read the regulations.

Even Noah read one page before declaring that regulations were why people invented rubber chickens.

The meeting could be closed if legal advice was being discussed.

The decision still had to be published afterwards.

Nothing required the city to hear us first.

So we held our own meeting outside.

Not a protest.

A public evidence session.

Every speaker had three minutes.

Every claim had to name its evidence.

Every disagreement had to be recorded accurately.

The city officials could listen if they wanted.

The whole session would be streamed online.

No hidden votes.

No misleading forms.

Exactly what we had promised.

THE LONGEST THREE MINUTES

Parents spoke about walking distance and childcare.

Teachers spoke about class sizes.

Students spoke about friends.

A Westbridge teacher explained why combined science classes could help both schools.

A Brookfield student said she did not want to be moved just because adults had failed to repair a roof.

Dr. Rahman explained the building options.

Mrs. Patel explained the archive.

Lucas described the partnership.

Brad described training at both schools.

Mr. Vane sat in the front row.

Justice sat beside him.

Neither tried to control the discussion.

My three minutes came last.

I had prepared another speech.

This time, I kept one sentence.

"We are not asking you to promise nothing will change. We are asking you not to change everything without us."

Then I sat down.

Noah looked disappointed.

"That's it?"

"Yes."

"No chicken joke?"

"No."

"Tim, are you feeling well?"

The audience laughed.

Perhaps it was a chicken joke after all.

THE OFFICIALS WHO LISTENED

The new oversight officer arrived at eleven.

Her name was Ms. Dube.

She stood at the back for forty minutes.

Then she asked to speak.

"The city meeting remains closed for the legal section. The evidence section can be opened. Student and community representatives may attend."

Sophie stood.

"How many?"

"Six from Brookfield. Three from Westbridge. Three community representatives."

It was not everyone.

It was not nothing.

We elected representatives publicly.

Sophie, Noah, and I would represent the council.

Mia would represent younger students.

Oliver would represent clubs.

Brad would represent sports.

Lucas and two Westbridge students would attend.

Daniel, Clara, and Mrs. Moyo would represent the community.

Justice and Mr. Vane would give evidence but not vote.

Dr. Rahman would answer building questions.

No one was selected because of a note.

No one was chosen by a hidden account.

It felt different.

WHAT WE LEFT OUTSIDE

Not everyone could fit into the evidence session, so we placed two speakers outside the city building.

Students sat on the steps with notebooks.

Parents watched from the cafe across the road.

Every contribution was streamed without edits.

When someone disagreed, the minutes showed both arguments.

One city official complained that the process looked untidy.

Justice answered, "Public decisions are often untidy. Secret ones merely look tidy afterwards."

Mr. Vane did not comment, but he moved his chair closer to the speaker.

For the first time, the meeting outside was not a backup plan. It was part of the decision.

THE COMMUNITY TRANSLATORS

Mia noticed that some parents were watching the stream without joining the discussion.

The evidence session was in English, and the technical documents were difficult even for fluent speakers.

Three bilingual students and two parents volunteered to provide summaries in other languages.

Every translation was checked by a second person.

No private information was included.

The translated versions appeared beside the official minutes, clearly labelled as community summaries.

One parent who had never spoken at a school meeting submitted her first question that afternoon.

It was about transport costs if students were moved.

Ms. Dube added it to the public agenda.

Leaving the door open also meant making sure people could understand what was happening inside.

THE LEGAL OBJECTION

On Friday morning, Richard Stone's lawyers objected to student attendance.

They said confidential commercial information might be discussed.

Ms. Dube separated the agenda.

Legal contracts in private.

School evidence in public.

The lawyers objected again.

Ms. Dube overruled them.

Mr. Vane's former department objected to Helen Ward's evidence because she was under investigation.

Ms. Dube allowed written testimony.

Justice's conflict was declared publicly.

Her evidence would be checked like everyone else's.

Every objection had an answer.

Not always the answer I wanted.

But an answer on record.

Then Richard Stone submitted a new document.

A signed agreement between Brookfield's student council and Stonebridge Learning Group.

It supported the merger.

The signature at the bottom was mine.

The date was two weeks earlier.

The paper included my correct name, council title, and a copy of my signature.

Noah read it.

"Please tell me this is the old signature trick."

I stared at it.

It was my current signature.

Not an old one.

Not a clumsy copy.

Exactly mine.

And I remembered signing something with the same shape.

The showcase attendance form.

Someone had scanned my signature and placed it on an agreement I had never seen.

Sophie asked for the original.

The lawyers only had a scan.

The ink signature did not exist.

Ms. Dube rejected the document.

That should have ended it.

Then the lawyers produced a video.

It showed me sitting at a table saying, "We support the proposal."

The clip was three seconds long.

No context.

No question.

No full recording.

But it was my face.

And my voice.

THE THREE-SECOND VIDEO

The video came from Promise Day.

I had spoken to a reporter about the community-council proposal.

Not the merger.

My full sentence had been, "We support the proposal to hold a community vote before any merger."

They had cut the first and last parts.

Justice found the original recording on the public stream.

Ms. Dube watched both.

The lawyers withdrew the agreement.

Richard Stone had tried one last trick.

It had lasted twelve minutes.

Still, the clip spread online.

Students argued.

Parents called the school.

Westbridge asked whether I had changed sides.

The truth was public, but the lie was shorter.

Noah looked at his phone.

"People like three seconds better than three pages."

"Then we make the truth easy to find," Sophie said.

We posted both clips together.

The full sentence.

The signed ballot question.

The public evidence index.

No insults.

No dramatic music.

Within an hour, the original reporter shared it too.

The lie did not disappear.

It just stopped being the only version.

Ms. Dube opened the evidence meeting at ten.

And Richard Stone's lawyers asked for one more private session.

They claimed Helen Ward had confessed to altering the votes.

If that was true, everything we had proved could collapse again.

CHAPTER 28

Helen Tells the Whole Truth

Friday

Helen's confession was not what Richard's lawyers claimed.

She admitted forging signatures, moving records, and creating anonymous posts.

She did not admit changing the vote.

She named the person who had.

Harold Harper.

Mr. Harper had been gone all term.

No school.

No festival.

No mysterious appearances.

I had almost forgotten him.

Helen's written statement explained that five years ago, Harper had removed the original ballots after the community rejected development.

Richard Stone kept copies.

Adrian Vane submitted the false summary without checking it.

Helen, then Richard's assistant, transported the box.

"I knew the summary was wrong," she wrote. "I told myself keeping my job mattered because one day I could return the documents. That was cowardice disguised as patience."

Noah read the paragraph twice.

"That's the most adult thing I've ever heard."

It was.

Helen had spent five years preparing to fix a mistake instead of admitting it immediately.

Every new secret made the next one easier.

THE FIRST HAWK'S MISTAKE

Daniel's statement followed.

The Black Hawks had hidden evidence instead of taking it to families.

Some of that was necessary.

Some of it was fear.

They had accused Harper but protected Adrian because they were not sure.

They had trusted Clara with the register but never told the principal everything.

Their secrecy saved the cup.

It also helped the lie survive.

Emily added her own statement.

"I told myself protecting students meant keeping them ignorant. I was wrong."

Clara wrote that she had hidden the register and left town.

Justice wrote that she should have declared her connection.

Mr. Vane wrote that he had treated public opposition as a management problem rather than information.

For the first time, the adults were not just blaming one villain.

They were admitting how each of them had helped.

The meeting room became very quiet.

Ms. Dube read every statement into the record.

No edits.

No three-second clips.

RICHARD'S DEFENCE

Richard Stone appeared by video.

He denied instructing anyone to damage the hall.

He denied altering the ballots.

He said every project had been intended to improve education.

His lawyer argued that Westbridge offered better opportunities and that Brookfield's campaign was driven by nostalgia.

Lucas asked to respond.

His father warned him not to.

Ms. Dube allowed it.

Lucas looked at the camera.

"Westbridge does offer good opportunities. So does Brookfield. You don't have to damage one to prove the other is good."

Richard's face hardened.

"You don't understand the finances."

"Then explain them publicly."

The lawyer interrupted.

Lucas kept going.

"You told me students would choose. Then you hid every choice they made. That's not a better school. That's just a bigger one."

He stopped.

His hands were shaking.

I knew that feeling.

Standing on a stage was easy compared with disagreeing with your father in public.

Ms. Dube thanked him.

Richard ended his video connection.

THE CITY FINANCE QUESTION

The financial director presented the actual costs.

Repairing Brookfield was cheaper than temporary classrooms.

Keeping both schools open cost more than merging in the long term.

But merging required transport, building work at Westbridge, and additional staff.

The savings were smaller than the original proposal claimed.

Much smaller.

Over five years, the difference was almost nothing.

Mr. Vane had known the long-term figures.

He had not hidden them.

They were in appendix forty-two of his report.

Nobody had read appendix forty-two.

Sophie looked betrayed by her own filing system.

Noah shook his head.

"The real mystery was page four hundred."

The financial director explained that both options were possible.

This was not a forced closure.

It was a choice.

And choices required consultation.

THE STUDENT EVIDENCE

Sophie presented the council records.

Noah presented the lunch-queue trial.

Mia presented the homework club.

Oliver presented club participation.

Brad presented the joint sports programme.

I presented the community council.

Mr. Vane gave evidence next.

He did not call our methods unusual.

He called them initially inadequate but substantially improved.

From him, this was practically a love letter.

Then he said something unexpected.

"The strongest argument for keeping Brookfield open is not its history. It is that its current students have demonstrated the capacity to manage change without concealment. The city should learn from that."

Sophie looked at me.

I looked at Lucas.

Had Adrian Vane just supported us?

Yes.

On record.

Without enjoying it.

Justice presented the ballot evidence and declared her connections again.

Dr. Rahman confirmed repairs were practical.

Ms. Dube closed the public session at three.

The private legal discussion would last one hour.

The decision would be announced at five.

THE PAPER TRAIL

Before the private session began, Ms. Dube asked Sophie whether the council wanted anything corrected in the public minutes.

Sophie checked the names, dates, and attachments.

Noah checked whether his lunch comment had been included.

It had.

He asked for it to be removed.

The audience voted to keep it because it demonstrated that the meeting had allowed informal contributions.

Noah said democracy had gone too far.

Ms. Dube smiled but approved the minutes with the comment included.

Nothing about the decision would depend on anyone's memory of that afternoon. Every statement had an owner, every document a source, and every correction a time.

TWO HOURS

We waited in the Westbridge dining hall.

Students played chess.

Brad shot baskets.

Noah drank hot chocolate.

Sophie checked the time every forty seconds.

Lucas sat alone near the window.

I sat beside him.

"Whatever happens, you did the right thing."

"That doesn't make it feel good."

"No."

He looked at his phone.

No message from his father.

Daniel and Emily sat with Clara.

Three old Black Hawks and a whole lifetime of secrets.

Justice spoke with her mother.

Mr. Vane corrected a spelling error in the public minutes.

Of course he did.

At 4:58, Ms. Dube returned.

She carried one sheet of paper.

One sheet for fifty years of promises and two months of chaos.

"The city has reached a decision."

Everyone stood.

Then the fire alarm went off.

Not smoke this time.

Not a theatrical cartridge.

A real alarm triggered by an electrical fault.

We had to evacuate.

Ms. Dube still held the paper.

Two hundred people groaned as one.

Noah looked at the ceiling.

"I am going to become allergic to alarms."

We walked outside.

The decision stayed unread.

And across the road, a removal van was already parked outside Brookfield.

CHAPTER 29

The Removal Van

Friday

The removal van was empty.

It had arrived early to collect temporary classroom furniture if the merger was approved.

The driver knew nothing about the decision.

He had simply been told to wait.

Noah walked up to him.

"Can you wait somewhere less symbolic?"

The driver moved around the corner.

The fire alarm stopped at 5:20.

No fire.

Just a faulty wire in the Westbridge dining hall.

Nothing to do with Richard.

Nothing to do with the review.

Sometimes a broken wire was only a broken wire.

We returned inside.

Ms. Dube picked up the paper again.

"Before the interruption, I was about to announce the decision."

Noah nodded.

"We remember."

THE DECISION

"Brookfield School will remain open."

Cheering exploded.

Sophie hugged Mia.

Brad lifted Noah.

Lucas smiled.

Daniel put both hands on Clara's shoulders.

Emily cried.

I didn't hear the next sentence.

Neither did most people.

Ms. Dube waited.

Eventually, Justice raised one finger.

The room became silent.

"Westbridge will also remain open. The proposed merger is withdrawn. Both schools will participate in a formal partnership. Brookfield's hall will be repaired, and the community council will operate as a one-year pilot."

More cheering.

Ms. Dube continued.

"These decisions are subject to standard financial oversight and annual review. They are not exemptions from future change."

Mr. Vane nodded.

That was fair.

No promise meant nothing would ever happen.

It meant decisions would happen honestly.

"The city's investigation into record alteration and property damage continues. That is separate from the educational decision."

Richard's part was not over.

Neither was Helen's.

Or Mr. Vane's.

But the school was safe.

Noah turned to me.

"We did it."

"We did it," I said.

Then Sophie hugged me.

Then Noah joined.

Then Brad.

I couldn't breathe.

It was excellent.

THE REMOVAL VAN'S CARGO

As we left Westbridge, the removal driver approached.

He had a box in his van.

Not furniture.

A Brookfield archive box.

His company had collected it from Richard Stone's office that morning.

The delivery instruction said:

Dispose after decision.

Justice called Ms. Dube.

The driver handed it over.

Inside were the original ballot pages.

Not copies.

The actual signed pages.

Richard had kept them until the final decision.

Perhaps as insurance.

Perhaps as proof he could control the story.

Now they were evidence.

At the bottom of the box was the missing page from Mr. Vane's report.

The original recommendation.

And a list of instructions for altering the online version.

The emergency password was written on it.

Richard had planned the final forgery himself.

He had almost succeeded.

Not because his lies were perfect.

Because everyone was tired of checking.

Sophie photographed every item.

Justice sealed the box.

Mr. Vane stood beside the van looking at his old password.

"BROOKFIELD9," Noah said.

Mr. Vane sighed.

"I have changed it."

"To what?"

"Something considerably longer."

Good.

Some lessons were small but important.

THE RIDE HOME

We did not have a victory bus.

We had Daniel's old car, the public bus, and Brad on his bicycle.

Noah, Sophie, and I walked back to Brookfield.

Students had already heard.

Someone had put a sign on the front doors.

STILL OURS.

Underneath, another person had written:

ALSO NEEDS REPAIRS.

That was accurate.

The Festival Cup stood in the display cabinet.

The Founders' Register would join it after the investigation.

The oak tree cast a long shadow across the field.

Room 75 was locked.

The hall was supported by red steel.

Everything looked the same.

It wasn't.

Mr. Vane met us at the entrance.

"Congratulations."

"Thank you."

"Do not become unbearable."

"No promises."

He almost smiled.

Then he handed me a folder.

The official closure of the review.

On the first page, beneath Brookfield remains open, someone had written:

Recommendation approved with student and community consultation.

No forged signature.

No altered page.

No secret condition.

Just a decision.

Mum called before I reached home.

She had watched the announcement.

She cried.

I pretended I had something in my eye.

Noah did not pretend at all.

THE PARTY THAT WASN'T A PARTY

That evening, everyone gathered in the cafe.

Daniel said it was not a party.

It was a community debrief.

There were balloons.

Cake.

Emergency biscuits.

And Frank wearing a tiny paper badge.

It was a party.

Clara brought Martha Moyo's album.

Justice brought her mother.

Lucas arrived late.

The room became quiet when he entered.

His father was under investigation.

Some people did not know whether to welcome him.

Brad solved the problem by throwing him a basketball.

"You're on my team."

Lucas caught it.

"Westbridge or Brookfield?"

"The cafe team. We need players."

Conversation started again.

Mr. Vane did not stay.

He left a envelope for Justice.

Inside was his resignation from the city review department.

Not from education.

He planned to return to teaching.

"Where?" I asked.

Justice read the letter.

"Here, if Brookfield will have him."

Everyone looked at me.

Why did everyone look at me?

"The council doesn't hire teachers."

"No," the principal said. "But the school community can provide a reference."

Noah nearly choked on his biscuit.

"Tim has to give Mr. Vane a reference?"

"All of us do," Sophie said.

This was going to be difficult.

Then Noah grinned.

"Excellent punctuality. Strong folder skills. Suspicious eyebrows."

Sophie took the pen away from him.

CHAPTER 30

The Normal Week

Monday

After saving the school, I expected at least one day without homework.

This did not happen.

On Monday morning, my maths teacher gave us a test.

She said saving Brookfield did not change algebra.

This seemed unfair.

The school celebrated anyway.

Students signed a huge banner in the entrance.

Teachers brought cake to the staffroom.

The local newspaper printed a photograph of both councils.

Westbridge and Brookfield.

One certificate.

Two schools.

No merger.

The headline said:

STUDENTS KEEP THE NINTH PROMISE.

Noah bought six copies.

Brad's grandmother bought twelve.

Mr. Vane bought one and corrected a factual error in the caption.

Some things stayed normal.

MONDAY MORNING ASSEMBLY

The principal began assembly without mentioning the review at all.

He talked about a lost lunchbox, the library rota, and a football found on the roof.

Students laughed.

Then he said, "These are the announcements I hoped to make again."

For once, an ordinary week felt like an achievement.

Mia returned a library book she had borrowed before the showcase.

Noah returned three emergency-biscuit packets to Daniel.

Brad returned Lucas's spare Westbridge jersey.

I returned Mr. Vane's review folder with every page still inside.

No mysteries arrived. No notes appeared. The bell rang and we went to class.

THE NEW PROBLEM

At lunch, Sophie called a council meeting.

I thought it would be easy.

A thank-you list.

A party plan.

Perhaps a discussion about pizza Friday.

Instead, she put forty-three new requests on the table.

Now that people knew the community council worked, everyone wanted something.

A new basketball hoop.

Longer library hours.

More vegetarian food.

A chess championship.

A quiet room.

A louder music room.

A better school app.

A ban on homework before holidays.

A rule that Frank could attend assemblies.

Noah supported the last one.

Sophie looked at me.

"We saved the school. Now we have to run it."

Right.

That part.

We elected temporary working groups.

Each request needed evidence, cost, and a person responsible.

No more agreeing to everything because people cheered.

The community council had its first real test.

Could it make boring decisions after the exciting decision was over?

THE BUDGET VOTE

The first budget meeting lasted two hours.

The basketball group wanted hoops.

The coding club wanted laptops.

The drama club wanted curtains.

The library wanted chairs.

I could afford two of the four.

Everyone had evidence.

Everyone had a good reason.

Last term, I would have promised all of it and worried later.

This time, we published the budget.

Students voted on priorities.

The coding club and library won.

Brad was annoyed.

The drama club was furious.

Noah suggested a rubber-chicken tournament to raise the rest.

Sophie actually agreed.

"With receipts."

"Everything has receipts now," Noah complained.

"Yes."

Brad agreed to help if the sports fund received half.

The drama club agreed if their curtain fund received the other half.

I had a compromise.

Not everyone was happy.

Everyone understood why.

That was new.

THE CHICKEN TOURNAMENT

Greg and Frank had become famous.

Students paid to enter teams in a rubber-chicken obstacle course.

There were throwing events.

Relay events.

A accuracy contest involving buckets.

No real animals.

No school property used as weapons.

Sophie checked the rules twice.

Lucas brought a Westbridge chicken named Winston.

It was yellow, formal, and had a small navy ribbon.

Noah said it looked like it paid taxes.

The final was Greg versus Winston.

Brad threw Frank with incredible confidence.

Frank hit the bucket rim and flew into the announcer's table.

The announcer dove aside.

Greg landed directly in the centre bucket.

Brookfield won.

Westbridge demanded a rematch.

We raised enough for the curtains and the basketball hoop.

The accounts were published the same evening.

Mr. Vane attended as a visitor.

He did not enter.

He did buy a cake.

"Assessment?" I asked.

"No."

"Observing?"

"No."

"Then why are you here?"

He looked at the crowded field.

"Learning."

That was enough.

THE FIRST REFERENCE

The principal asked the council for Mr. Vane's teaching reference.

We wrote it together.

Mr. Vane is rigorous, prepared, and committed to public standards.

He listens when evidence changes.

He needs to remember that students are not administrative risks.

He would be a good history teacher if he does not turn every lesson into a review.

Sophie deleted the last sentence.

Noah put it back.

Justice added:

He has demonstrated an ability to change his position without changing his principles.

The principal accepted the reference.

Mr. Vane would teach part-time history at Brookfield after the repairs began.

His first class would be mine.

Noah laughed for ten minutes.

I did not laugh at all.

THE NOTE I SIGNED

On Friday, I found one final folded-wing hawk note in my locker.

For a second, my stomach tightened.

Then I saw the signature.

Emily.

It said:

THANK YOU FOR FINISHING WHAT WE COULDN'T. NO MYSTERY THIS TIME.

Below it, Daniel, Clara, and Helen had signed too.

Helen's signature was followed by one sentence:

I am returning the bookshop key to Clara. Some things should not stay hidden.

No clue.

No instruction.

No emergency.

Just people telling the truth.

I put the note in the new public archive folder.

Not because it was evidence.

Because it belonged to the story.

Then I went to maths.

Mr. Vane was waiting outside the classroom with a stack of history books.

He looked at me.

"Your council reference described my eyebrows as suspicious."

"Noah wrote that."

"Ah."

"Was it wrong?"

He raised one eyebrow.

I went inside.

Saving the school had not made my life less weird.

It had just given the weirdness a timetable.

CHAPTER 31

Mr. Vane's First Lesson

Monday

Mr. Vane wrote his name on the board.

MR. VANE.

Then he underlined it once.

Noah leaned toward me.

"He really does have suspicious eyebrows."

Mr. Vane heard him.

"And you have a voice that carries, Mr. Noah. Please use it to answer the first question."

Noah sat up.

"What question?"

"Exactly."

The class laughed.

Mr. Vane did not send anyone out.

He did not give a speech about standards.

He put two photographs on the screen.

One showed Brookfield's first promise day.

The other showed the recent community meeting outside Westbridge.

"What is the difference between history and memory?"

A student said history was written down.

Another said memory was personal.

Noah said history happened before snacks and memory happened after.

Mr. Vane wrote all three answers on the board.

Then he asked me whether the ninth promise was history or memory.

"Both," I said. "The document is history. What people think it means is memory."

"Can memory change history?"

"It can change what we do about it."

He nodded.

"Good."

I nearly fell off my chair.

Adrian Vane had said my answer was good.

Saving the school really had changed everything.

THE SOURCE TEST

The lesson became an investigation.

Not a secret one.

A history one.

Mr. Vane gave us four accounts of the same school event.

A teacher's report.

A student diary.

A newspaper article.

A photograph.

They disagreed.

The teacher said a debate ended early because of bad behaviour.

The diary said it ended because the fire alarm sounded.

The newspaper said students protested.

The photograph showed everyone leaving calmly.

"Which is true?" Mr. Vane asked.

"Parts of all of them," Sophie said.

"How do you decide?"

"Check the alarm log."

Noah groaned.

"Even history has evidence folders."

Mr. Vane gave him another photograph.

This one showed Mr. Vane as a trainee teacher beside the Black Hawks.

The class went quiet.

He had put himself into the source test.

"What does this photograph prove?" he asked.

"That you were there," I said.

"Does it prove I supported the Black Hawks?"

"No."

"Does it prove I betrayed them?"

"No."

"Does it prove I taught at Brookfield?"

"Yes."

He nodded.

"A photograph has limits. So does a report. So does a person."

For the first time, he wasn't defending his record.

He was teaching us to examine it.

THE QUESTION NO ONE ASKED

After class, I stayed behind.

"Why did you really support the merger?"

Mr. Vane stacked the photographs.

"Because Westbridge had better systems."

"That's the report answer."

He looked at me.

"You want the personal answer?"

"Yes."

"I taught here during the Black Hawks year. Meetings were secret. Students disappeared into rooms. Teachers hid documents. Everyone believed their intentions excused their methods. I thought Brookfield needed order."

"So you came back to fix it?"

"I came back to prove I had been right."

That was honest.

Not flattering.

Honest.

"Did you?"

"No."

He closed the folder.

"I discovered that Westbridge's systems worked because nobody had tested them with a serious disagreement. Brookfield's systems failed publicly. Yours improved publicly. That is more useful."

"Are you going to write that in a report?"

"Yes."

"Please don't call my methods initially inadequate."

"They were."

"Fair."

THE STUDENT SOURCE

Mr. Vane assigned homework.

Write a history of one school event using at least three sources.

Noah chose the Great Pizza Shortage of Last Winter.

Brad chose Greg's first chicken tournament.

Sophie chose the lunch-queue reform.

I chose the first day I found my name on the student-council election list.

My sources were the original poster, Noah's memory, and my own diary.

Noah remembered me being excited.

I remembered being horrified.

The poster proved someone had added my name in different ink.

I had never discovered who.

For one whole year, it had not mattered.

Now it bothered me.

Who had started everything?

I asked Noah.

"I thought you did it."

"No."

"Brad?"

Brad laughed.

"I didn't even want you running. Why would I sign you up?"

"Sophie?"

"I wasn't on the council yet."

"Mom?"

She denied it.

The principal said the list had been left on his desk.

Mr. Vane had not been at the school then.

Daniel had no idea.

Emily smiled when I asked her.

"Some mysteries stay small."

That was not an answer.

THE ELECTION LIST

The original election list was in the council archive.

I pulled it out during lunch.

My name was written in blue pen.

The others were black.

Beside my name was a tiny mark I had never noticed.

A chicken foot.

Greg had not existed then.

Frank had belonged to Brad's cousin.

Noah owned a rubber chicken before either of them.

Mr. Squeaks.

Mr. Squeaks had disappeared before the election.

Noah claimed he had lost him.

I held up the list.

"Noah."

He looked at the chicken foot.

"Oh."

"Did you add my name?"

"Yes."

Everything stopped.

"You?"

"I thought you'd be good."

"You laughed when I found it."

"I was nervous."

"You told me to run."

"Because you were good."

"You let me investigate everyone?"

"There wasn't an investigation. You just complained for a week."

I couldn't believe it.

My whole leadership career had started because Noah forged my name.

"Why?"

He stopped smiling.

"You kept saying school was boring and nobody listened. I thought if your name was there, you'd have to try."

"That wasn't your choice."

"I know."

He looked down.

The same problem again.

Someone using a secret because they believed they knew best.

This time, it was my best friend.

And this time, it had changed my life for the better.

That didn't make the method right.

I put the list back.

"You're buying lunch."

"For how long?"

"A week."

"Fair."

"And you're telling everyone at the reunion."

Noah went pale.

"Not that."

"One week and a public confession."

He nodded.

History was written down.

Memory was personal.

And lunch was expensive.

CHAPTER 32

Noah's Public Confession

Friday

The Black Hawks reunion was supposed to be dignified.

Justice brought photographs.

Clara brought the first charter.

Daniel brought emergency biscuits.

Emily brought the old cassette player.

The principal brought a microphone that worked.

Noah brought a confession.

We had invited current students, former students, families, and neighbours to the library.

The repaired hall was not ready yet.

Mr. Vane sat at the back with a notebook.

He was probably checking historical accuracy.

Noah waited until Emily finished speaking about the old Black Hawks.

Then he stood up.

"I have something to admit about the current Black Hawks."

"We are not the current Black Hawks," Sophie said.

"The current school mystery team."

"We are not that either."

Noah pointed at her.

"See? This is why I kept it secret."

He held up the original election list.

"I added Tim's name."

Everyone turned to me.

I folded my arms.

Noah continued.

"I thought he would be a good leader. Also, Brad was being annoying."

Brad nodded.

"Fair."

"And I didn't think Tim would actually win."

"Thanks," I said.

"But then he did. And everything got out of control. There were chickens and tunnels and criminal investigations. So, technically, this is all my fault."

Noah sat down.

For a second, nobody spoke.

Then Daniel started laughing.

Emily joined.

Clara laughed so hard she had to take off her glasses.

Even Mr. Vane smiled.

I did not laugh.

Okay, I laughed a little.

THE FIRST HAWK'S ADVICE

Daniel stood beside Noah.

"I nominated myself for the Black Hawks. Nobody asked me to lead. I just started making lists and telling people where to hide things."

Emily looked at him.

"You were terrible."

"I was enthusiastic."

"You put the account records inside a cookbook."

"It worked."

"Only because Noah later tried to eat the cookbook."

Noah raised his hand.

"Evidence should not smell like biscuits."

Everyone laughed again.

Daniel turned to the audience.

"Secrets feel clever when you are scared. They feel necessary when you think nobody will listen. But they make other people carry choices they never agreed to."

He looked at Noah.

"Confession is a good start."

Noah nodded.

"And lunch," I added.

"Yes. Lunch."

THE REUNION PHOTOGRAPH

We recreated the Black Hawks photograph beside the oak tree.

Daniel, Emily, and Clara stood in front.

Justice and her mother stood with them.

The current council stood behind.

Lucas joined even though he was Westbridge.

Mr. Vane took the photograph.

Then someone called for him to join.

He refused.

Sophie set the camera timer.

The principal pulled him into the group.

At the last second, Brad held up Frank.

I held up Greg.

The shutter clicked.

Years later, people would look at that photograph and wonder why everyone was laughing.

They would not know about the forged election list, the emergency biscuits, or Mr. Vane trying to escape.

They would see a school community.

That was enough.

HELEN'S RETURN

Helen arrived after the photograph.

No city badge.

No document bag.

No anonymous account.

She carried a box of books for the public archive.

Some students moved away from her.

Sophie stayed beside me.

Helen put the box down.

"I came to return these and apologise."

Clara accepted the books.

Helen turned to Sophie.

"I forged your signature. I made people doubt you. I'm sorry."

Sophie didn't answer immediately.

"Are you sorry because it went wrong or because you did it?"

"Because I did it. Going wrong just made me admit it."

Sophie nodded.

"Then you can help with the archive inventory. Publicly. With another person checking your work."

It was not instant forgiveness.

It was a path back.

Helen agreed.

Noah leaned toward me.

"Sophie is nicer than I am."

"You made me buy lunch."

"For a week. She gave her community service."

"That's not nicer."

"True."

NOAH'S LUNCH ACCOUNT

Noah paid his lunch debt in six instalments.

Monday: chips.

Tuesday: a sandwich.

Wednesday: soup he did not spill on my notebook.

Thursday: pizza, because some traditions deserved respect.

Friday: a printed receipt labelled ELECTION-NOMINATION COMPENSATION.

Sophie filed the receipt as a joke, then removed it from the official archive and put it in the community diary instead.

Noah said the debt had taught him an important lesson about consent.

I said it had taught him that my lunch cost more than he expected.

He agreed both things were true.

THE PUBLIC ARCHIVE

We catalogued every document.

The register stayed in Justice's legal custody until the investigation finished.

The copied charter went on display.

The ballot copies were scanned.

Mr. Vane's altered report appeared beside the original.

Helen's forged signature sheet appeared with her statement.

My own mistakes appeared too.

Missing forms.

Poor receipts.

Unapproved investigations.

The principal asked whether we were sure we wanted everything public.

"Yes," I said. "Otherwise people will think we saved the school by being perfect."

Noah pointed to the election list.

"Especially not perfect."

The archive opened the following week.

Students used it for history projects.

Parents added photographs.

The kitchen staff donated old menus.

The caretaker donated building maps.

For the first time, Brookfield's history did not depend on one hidden book.

It belonged to everyone.

THE SMALL MYSTERY

On Friday afternoon, the archive scanner produced an extra page.

Nobody had placed it on the glass.

The page showed a map of Room 75.

In the corner was a message.

ONE DRAWER REMAINS CLOSED.

No signature.

No hawk.

Just the words.

I looked at Sophie.

She looked at Noah.

Noah raised both hands.

"Not me."

I picked up the page.

Then I turned it over.

On the back was a printer error code.

The map had been stuck in the scanner's memory from an old scan.

The message was part of a historical worksheet Daniel made years ago.

Not a new clue.

Noah looked disappointed.

"So we don't investigate?"

"No."

"Not even one drawer?"

"No."

Sophie put the page in the archive.

For once, a mystery could stay old.

I had a school to run.

And Noah owed me lunch.

CHAPTER 33

The Big Rematch

Saturday

The Brookfield–Westbridge basketball rematch had nothing to do with saving the school.

That was why everyone cared so much.

No lawyers.

No ballots.

No city review.

Just two teams, one court, and Brad's extremely serious face.

Lucas had organised a joint warm-up.

Both councils sold food.

Money went to the sports fund.

Mr. Vane volunteered as scorekeeper.

Noah asked whether he could review the score instead.

Mr. Vane gave him a whistle.

Noah immediately blew it.

Everyone jumped.

"That," Mr. Vane said, "is why you do not get a whistle."

THE FIRST HALF

Westbridge scored first.

Then again.

Brookfield missed three shots.

Brad shouted instructions.

Our players listened for about two minutes.

Then everyone tried to score individually.

By halftime, Westbridge led by twelve.

Brad sat on the bench with a towel over his head.

I sat beside him.

"What's wrong?"

"They're playing like the school depends on it."

"It doesn't."

"I know."

"Then why are you?"

He pulled the towel down.

"Because I want to win."

Fair.

Lucas came over with the Westbridge captain.

I expected a speech about partnership.

Brad spoke first.

"Second half, we do joint defence drills after the game. Right now, I'm beating you."

Lucas grinned.

"There he is."

Some friendships are built on trust.

Some are built on trying to destroy each other at sports.

THE SECOND HALF

Brookfield stopped playing as individuals.

Brad passed more.

Mia defended.

Ethan scored twice.

Noah shouted advice that had nothing to do with basketball.

"Use the lunch-queue strategy!"

Amazingly, Brad understood.

He moved a defender out of the narrow space near the basket.

We scored.

The crowd cheered.

With one minute left, the scores were tied.

Westbridge had the ball.

Lucas called a timeout.

Both teams huddled separately.

Mr. Vane checked the clock.

Sophie held the fundraising total.

Frank and Greg sat in matching tiny jerseys.

Winston watched from Lucas's bag.

The whistle blew.

Westbridge passed.

Brad intercepted.

He ran down the court.

Two defenders blocked him.

For a second, he could have forced the shot.

Instead, he passed to Mia.

She scored as the buzzer sounded.

Brookfield won by two.

The gym erupted.

Brad lifted Mia onto his shoulders.

Noah ran onto the court.

Mr. Vane blew the whistle at him.

Nobody cared.

THE TROPHY QUESTION

There was one trophy.

Both captains reached for it.

Then Brad stepped back.

"Westbridge gets it first."

Lucas looked surprised.

"Why?"

"Because you hosted. And because my dad's company..." He stopped and corrected himself. "Because your school helped when we needed it."

Lucas shook his head.

"You won."

"So?"

"So take the trophy."

They argued for thirty seconds.

Noah suggested a chicken battle.

Sophie suggested sharing it for six months each.

Mr. Vane suggested recording the arrangement in writing.

Everyone groaned.

We shared it.

Six months at Brookfield.

Six at Westbridge.

The first inter-school trophy that was not a cup someone had to hide.

THE REAL VICTORY

After the game, both teams practised together.

Westbridge players taught shooting drills.

Brookfield players taught defensive formations.

Brad trained harder than anyone.

He wore his Brookfield shirt under his Westbridge development-squad jacket.

It looked ridiculous.

It also looked exactly right.

A parent told him he was disloyal for training with Westbridge.

Brad pointed to both groups sharing water.

"No. This is what not being merged looks like. We choose what to share."

The parent had no answer.

Lucas heard.

"You're getting good at speeches."

"Don't tell Tim."

"I already did."

Brad threw a basketball at me.

I caught it badly.

Some things had not improved.

THE TEAM MEAL

After the game, both teams ate in the Brookfield dining hall.

The kitchen staff made pasta for forty players and somehow produced extra when Westbridge's substitutes arrived.

Brad sat between the two captains.

For the first ten minutes, everyone discussed the final shot.

Then the conversation moved to training schedules, homework, and whether Mr. Vane had ever played basketball.

Mr. Vane said he had played exactly once at school.

Noah asked what happened.

"I discovered that height was not the same as coordination."

Brad said that was the most honest scouting report he had ever heard.

The coaches exchanged practice plans. Brookfield would share its defensive drills; Westbridge would host shooting sessions. Nobody surrendered a team, a badge, or a trophy.

At the end of the meal, Mia returned the ball she had used to score the winning basket.

Brad told her to keep it.

"Why?"

"So you remember to pass next time."

She threw it back to him.

He caught it. I didn't. The ball hit my plate.

Lucas said Brookfield's leadership training still needed work.

THE PHOTOGRAPH

Someone took a photograph of both teams after the final drill.

Brad stood in the centre with the shared trophy.

Lucas stood beside him.

Mia held the game ball.

Noah held two cups and Frank.

The photograph showed muddy shoes, wet hair, and players wearing different uniforms.

The student newspaper wanted the caption TWO SCHOOLS, ONE TEAM.

Brad objected.

"Two teams. That's why the game was fun."

They changed it to TWO SCHOOLS, TWO TEAMS, ONE GOOD GAME.

Lucas said it was not poetic.

Brad said it was accurate.

Mr. Vane approved the correction and then complained that he had blinked in the photograph.

Noah said some historical sources could not be improved.

THE NEW SCOREBOARD

The sports fund bought a small electronic scoreboard.

Before installation, Mr. Vane checked the receipt.

Sophie checked the warranty.

Noah checked whether it could display TIM RULES.

It could.

During the first test, the screen flashed:

HOME 00 — VISITORS 00.

Underneath, Noah typed:

TIM 75 — NOAH 75.

"Why am I seventy-five?" I asked.

"First book."

"What about the sequel?"

He changed it to:

TIM 50 — NOAH 50.

"Better."

Sophie deleted the message.

The scoreboard returned to zero.

"That feels symbolic," Noah said.

It wasn't.

It was just a scoreboard.

Not everything had to be a mystery.

CHAPTER 34

The Repairs Begin

Monday

Repairing a school is louder than saving one.

Drills started at seven.

Workmen moved desks.

Dust covered everything.

The red supports in the hall were replaced by larger yellow supports.

Noah asked why the colours changed.

Dr. Rahman said they were different load ratings.

Noah said yellow meant caution and red meant mystery.

Dr. Rahman ignored him.

Classes moved into the library and dining hall.

The council shared Room 14 with chess club.

Every meeting included background arguments about whether a bishop could move backwards.

It could.

Noah still objected.

THE NOISE COMPLAINT

Students began complaining about the drilling.

Teachers complained about the dust.

Parents complained about parking.

The workmen complained that students kept touching barriers.

I had asked for repairs.

Now everyone wanted us to stop repairing things so loudly.

Sophie put the complaints on the community-council agenda.

I held a meeting with Dr. Rahman, the caretaker, student representatives, and the contractor.

The solution was not secret.

No drilling during tests.

Quiet work during reading lessons.

Daily dust cleaning.

A pedestrian path through the side gate.

Public repair schedules.

Complaints dropped by half.

The other half were about maths.

We could not fix maths.

THE MISSING MONEY

The repair budget included new lights for the hall.

The city finance officer removed them to save money.

The drama club protested.

Without proper lights, performances would be difficult.

The sports department wanted the money spent on a new floor instead.

The library wanted roof insulation.

Everyone had a priority again.

Sophie proposed a public options meeting.

Mr. Vane warned us that too much consultation could delay the work.

He was right.

Endless meetings could become another way of avoiding decisions.

We set a deadline.

One week for evidence.

One meeting.

One vote.

No secret extensions.

The clubs presented costs.

The contractors explained safety requirements.

Students voted for the floor and insulation.

The drama lights came last.

The drama club accepted the result but asked to fundraise separately.

Fair.

Not every loss was sabotage.

Not every disagreement was a plot.

Sometimes democracy meant your favourite thing did not happen.

THE LIGHTS WE ALREADY HAD

While clearing the storage room, Ethan found twelve stage lights.

They had been bought for the festival two years earlier and never installed.

The receipts were in the archive.

The warranty had expired, but an electrician confirmed they worked.

No fundraising needed.

No new expense.

The drama club got its lights.

Noah held one up.

"So the real treasure was the equipment we forgot we owned."

"Yes," I said.

"Can we put that on the charter?"

"No."

The lights were installed after the floor and insulation.

Every club got something.

Nobody got everything.

The public budget explained why.

Mr. Vane called it a satisfactory process.

Sophie framed the comment.

Not literally.

But she wanted to.

THE HOLE IN THE FLOOR

On Thursday, a workman found a metal plate beneath the old stage.

Everyone looked at me.

I did not touch it.

I did not even suggest it might contain treasure.

Dr. Rahman checked the building plans.

It was an access cover for electrical cables.

Not secret.

Not historical.

Just cables.

Noah sighed.

"This school is becoming very disappointing."

The caretaker opened it during a scheduled inspection.

Inside were wires and one old soda can.

No note.

No key.

No ballot pages.

We photographed it for the repair record and closed it again.

Sophie looked proud of me.

"You didn't even try to climb in."

"I thought about it."

"That's not the same."

"It's progress."

THE DUST DAY

The worst repair day happened during a history test.

At 10:14, a drill started above the classroom.

At 10:15, dust fell onto Noah's paper.

At 10:16, Mr. Vane stopped the test and moved everyone into the library.

Nobody panicked. The caretaker closed the work area. Dr. Rahman inspected the ceiling. The contractor cleaned the room and changed the drilling schedule.

The test continued thirty minutes later.

Noah claimed the dust had erased his best answer.

Mr. Vane gave him a fresh sheet and said the answer could now achieve its full potential elsewhere.

After school, the students involved received a clear explanation and a new test time if they needed it. No rumours. No hidden report. Just an incident, a correction, and a revised timetable.

Sophie added it to the maintenance log. Mia checked that no club had lost its room without warning.

By Friday, the noise complaints had a proper form, a response deadline, and a public summary. It was not dramatic enough for a mystery, which suited everyone.

THE STUDENT WALKTHROUGH

Before the hall reopened, Dr. Rahman invited class representatives to inspect it with her.

She showed them the repaired beams, the new floor, the emergency exits, and the inspection certificates.

Students asked why one yellow support remained near the store cupboard.

It was temporary, unrelated to the roof, and scheduled for removal after the electrical work.

Another question appeared in the public log and received a public answer.

Noah asked whether the new lights could flash during chicken battles.

The electrician demonstrated that they could.

Sophie said they would not.

The walkthrough ended with every representative signing the same form: I KNOW WHERE TO FIND THE SAFETY REPORT.

Not I PROMISE NOTHING WILL EVER BREAK.

That was not a promise anyone could make.

The difference mattered.

THE REPAIR LESSON

Mr. Vane used the repair schedule for a lesson about cause and effect.

Students compared the first alarming report, the new drilling photographs, and Dr. Rahman's final certificate.

The documents did not simply contradict one another. They described different moments and different evidence.

Noah said this explained why his old homework could not be used to prove his new homework was finished.

Mr. Vane said no analogy was perfect.

The class learned to ask who wrote a report, when they wrote it, and what had changed since. Those questions worked for history, buildings, and council decisions.

They also worked for rumours, which was why the next dramatic message about the hall received five requests for a source and no panic.

THE NEW HALL

The repairs finished on schedule.

The crack above the stage was gone.

Gerald had been plastered over.

Noah held a small farewell ceremony.

He read a poem.

"Gerald the crack,

You were at our back.

Then people drilled,

And the hall got filled."

Sophie stopped him before verse two.

Dr. Rahman certified the building safe.

The city removed the closure order.

We could use the hall again.

The first event would be the community council's annual Promise Assembly.

The second would be a joint performance with Westbridge.

The third would be the student-council election.

Sophie put the dates on the board.

Election.

I had forgotten.

My term ended in two weeks.

If I wanted to remain leader, I had to run again.

And this time, my name would not be added secretly.

CHAPTER 35

The Election Announcement

Friday

The principal announced the student-council election at assembly.

Every student could nominate one candidate.

Candidates would present their plans.

Class representatives would organise debates.

Votes would be counted publicly.

No posters with moustaches.

No free chocolate bribery.

No push-up contests.

Brad objected to the last rule.

"Physical fitness is part of leadership."

"No," Sophie said.

Noah raised his hand.

"Can candidates have slogans?"

"Yes."

He looked at me.

"TIM STILL RULES."

Everyone laughed.

I smiled.

Then Mia stood up.

"I want to run."

The hall became quiet.

Mia had helped with the archive, the homework club, the basketball game, and the community meetings.

She was organised.

Kind.

Brave enough to disagree with adults.

She would be an excellent leader.

My smile disappeared.

Not because she couldn't do it.

Because I suddenly realised other people could.

THE FIRST CAMPAIGN MEETING

Noah wanted to be my campaign manager again.

Sophie said she would remain neutral as council secretary.

Brad said he would support whoever gave him a basketball.

Mia offered him a fair sports budget instead.

He said that sounded like a bribe with receipts.

Lucas sent a message wishing both of us luck.

Mr. Vane gave no candidate any advantage.

He assigned the whole class a lesson about elections.

Noah said this was cruel.

I wrote my plan.

More clubs.

Better lunches.

Longer breaks.

Pizza Fridays.

Then I read it.

It could have been my campaign from last year.

Before the festival.

Before the review.

Before the community council.

I had learned so much, but my first instinct was still to promise things people liked.

Mia's plan was different.

A homework club in every year.

Mental-health quiet times.

Better class-representative training.

Shared events with Westbridge.

A public dashboard for council promises.

It was good.

Very good.

Annoyingly good.

THE POPULARITY PROBLEM

Students told me I had saved the school.

They said I deserved another term.

They promised to vote for me.

It felt good.

Then a Year Seven asked what I would do if the school needed saving again.

"That's not the plan," I said.

"Why not? You're good at mysteries."

Mia was standing nearby.

She didn't say anything.

I realised people saw me as the mystery leader.

Chicken battles.

Secret rooms.

Big speeches.

Mia was the person who remembered which students needed help with homework.

Both mattered.

They were not the same job.

At lunch, Noah found me staring at my plan.

"Are you worried?"

"No."

"You've written 'pizza' six times."

"I'm developing policy."

"On cheese?"

I put the paper away.

"Maybe I should run for a different role."

Noah stopped smiling.

"Because Mia might win?"

"Because she might be better."

"That sounds like losing with extra words."

He was right.

I was trying to protect myself from losing by pretending I didn't want the job.

I had done it before the first election too.

"Okay," I said. "I'll run properly."

Noah grinned.

"Pizza?"

"One pizza."

"Democracy is back."

POSTER INSPECTION

Before the first poster went up, Sophie checked the campaign rules.

Maximum size.

Recycled paper.

No insults.

No unapproved photographs.

No promises outside the council's budget.

Noah read the last rule twice.

"So I can't promise every voter a personal pizza?"

"No."

"A shared pizza?"

"No."

"A philosophical pizza?"

Sophie took his marker away.

Mia's posters passed first. Mine needed one correction: BETTER LUNCHES had to become REVIEW LUNCH CHOICES WITH THE KITCHEN STAFF.

Noah said mine had become less catchy.

It had also become possible.

The kitchen staff appreciated being consulted before students promised to change their jobs. They joined the campaign question panel and explained why some popular ideas cost more than people expected.

The election was already teaching us something: slogans were easy. Budgets were not.

THE DEBATE

The first debate took place in the repaired hall.

Mia spoke first.

She did not mention secret rooms.

She talked about students who never attended clubs, never asked for help, and never felt that council meetings belonged to them.

"I don't want the council to be famous," she said. "I want it to be useful."

People clapped.

Then it was my turn.

I talked about the festival, the review, and the partnership.

I talked about public records and student voice.

Then someone asked why I should lead if the council was supposed to work without me.

It was Mr. Vane's question again.

This time, there was no emergency to prove the answer.

"Because leadership isn't being necessary forever," I said. "It's helping other people become ready. If I win, my job is to train the next council. If I lose, my job is to help Mia."

Noah looked shocked.

I was shocked too.

But I meant it.

Mia smiled at me.

Not like a rival.

Like someone who understood.

THE SECOND NOMINATION

After the debate, Sophie made an announcement.

The community-council pilot needed a student coordinator separate from the school council leader.

The coordinator would manage public records, class representatives, and neighbourhood forums.

It was a bigger administrative job than council leader.

Naturally, everyone looked at Sophie.

She shook her head.

"I'm running the election, not applying."

Then she looked at me.

"You should apply."

Noah nodded.

"You like public records now."

"I don't."

"You like stopping people from hiding them."

That was true.

A new role.

Not a consolation prize.

A different way to lead.

But the application deadline was after the election.

I had to choose whether to campaign for one job while considering another.

And Mia deserved a fair election, not a candidate waiting for a better offer.

I decided to stay in the race.

One campaign.

One result.

Then the next decision.

The first poster went up on Monday.

Mia's said:

USEFUL, NOT FAMOUS.

Mine said:

TIM RULES — AND SO DOES EVERYONE ELSE.

Noah said mine was too long.

Sophie said it was accurate.

Brad said it needed a basketball.

I left it alone.

CHAPTER 36

Tim Versus Mia

Tuesday

Running against Mia was much harder than running against Brad.

Brad had called himself stronger, cooler, and better at push-ups.

I knew how to argue with that.

Mia helped younger students with homework and remembered everyone's name.

I could not defeat that with a moustache on her poster.

Noah suggested one anyway.

Sophie banned him from the art cupboard.

My campaign had three promises.

Publish every council decision.

Train class representatives.

Keep the Westbridge partnership active.

Mia's campaign had three promises too.

Make help easier to find.

Make meetings easier to join.

Make sure quiet students were heard.

They sounded similar.

That was because they were both sensible.

Very inconvenient.

THE CAMPAIGN QUESTION BOX

Students submitted anonymous questions.

Some were serious.

How will you help students who fall behind?

How will you stop clubs from favouring popular students?

What happens if Westbridge stops cooperating?

Some were not.

Can the council declare a national chips day?

Is Greg eligible to vote?

Why does Mr. Vane underline his name?

Mia answered the serious questions carefully.

I answered the serious questions and then said Greg could observe elections but not vote.

Noah objected.

"Specist."

"Greg is a rubber chicken."

"Still."

Mr. Vane answered the last question himself.

"Because clarity matters."

Noah wrote another question.

Why do you answer anonymous questions when you know who wrote them?

Mr. Vane gave him extra homework.

Democracy had limits.

THE POPULAR SPEECH

On Wednesday, I tried a new campaign strategy.

Humour.

At lunch, I stood beside my poster and performed the dying-printer noise.

BEEP. BEEP. KRRRR. EEEEE. BZZZZZ.

Students cheered.

Someone shouted, "TIM RULES!"

Noah started a chant.

It felt like the old talent show.

For five minutes, everyone loved me.

Then Mia opened a table near the library and helped a Year Seven fill out a homework-club request.

No performance.

No audience.

Just help.

I stopped making the noise.

My campaign problem was not that Mia was better.

It was that I kept trying to win moments instead of doing the work.

I took down the sign advertising another performance.

Noah looked confused.

"Where's the show?"

"At the homework table."

We spent lunch there.

Twelve students signed up.

Three asked to volunteer.

One student told me my printer noise was better in the first book.

Fair.

THE JOINT PROMISE

Mia and I agreed on one campaign rule ourselves.

Neither of us would use private conversations as campaign material.

If a student asked for help, the conversation would not become a poster quotation without permission.

If one of us made a mistake, the other would not turn it into a rumour.

Noah asked whether embarrassing printer-noise stories counted.

I said public performances were fair game.

Mia said she would not use them anyway.

Sophie wrote the agreement into the campaign guidance for future elections.

The race became less entertaining and much more useful. Students asked questions instead of choosing teams. Brad said he still preferred push-ups, but even he admitted there were fewer arguments at lunch.

THE OLD BRAD METHOD

Brad offered to endorse me.

He stood beside my poster with his arms folded.

"Vote Tim. He saved the school."

Mia's campaign supporter, Oliver, stood beside hers.

"Vote Mia. She helped me join chess club."

Brad looked at him.

"Tim helped save the chess club."

"Mia booked my room."

"Tim found the register."

"Mia found my missing chess clock."

Brad came back to our table.

"This is difficult. She does small things."

"Yes."

"Very useful small things."

"Yes."

"Are you sure you want me to keep endorsing you?"

"Yes."

He tried again.

"Vote Tim. He also does small things, but they're harder to remember."

Noah put his head on the table.

I decided to campaign without endorsements.

THE MISSED MEETING

On Thursday, I forgot a council budget meeting.

I was preparing my debate answers.

Mia attended in my place.

She presented the club requests, took minutes, and published them before I arrived.

Nobody criticised me.

That made it worse.

Sophie handed me the minutes.

"Mia followed the process."

"I know."

"Everything is correct."

"I know."

Noah read over my shoulder.

"Even her notes are nice."

"I know."

I went to find Mia.

"Sorry I missed the meeting."

"It's okay. Campaigns take time."

"No. The meeting was my job."

She nodded.

"Then apologise to the council, not just me."

I did.

At the next meeting, I read the correction into the record.

No excuses.

No mystery.

Just responsibility.

Students saw it.

Some said it proved I was unreliable.

Others said it proved I admitted mistakes.

Both were true.

Elections were annoying like that.

THE FINAL DEBATE

The final question came from a Year Seven.

"What if we vote for you and you leave for another job?"

Everyone looked at me.

The community-coordinator application was public.

I could not pretend it didn't exist.

"I've applied for the coordinator role too," I said. "If I win council leader, I won't take the other job. If Mia wins, I may apply to support her."

Mia answered next.

"If I win, I'll offer Tim the coordinator role regardless of whether he applies. If I lose, I'll run the homework programme and support him."

No tricks.

No hidden plan.

The audience applauded both of us.

Afterwards, Noah said the debate lacked a clear villain.

"Good," Sophie said.

"But how do people know who to boo?"

"They don't boo."

"What kind of election is this?"

"A better one."

Voting would take place Friday.

Every class would use paper ballots.

Representatives would count with teachers.

Results would be posted immediately.

No signature-only scans.

No false bottoms.

No smoke devices.

I had asked for simple public elections.

Now I had to trust one.

Even if I lost.

CHAPTER 37

The Count

Friday

Election day smelled like pencil shavings.

Every classroom had a ballot box.

Every ballot had two names.

MIA.

TIM.

No slogans.

No chickens.

No secret third option, although Noah wrote GREG on his ballot and had to request a replacement.

Sophie supervised the count.

Mr. Vane checked the process.

Representatives from both campaigns watched.

Mia and I sat outside the hall.

"Nervous?" she asked.

"No."

My leg was bouncing so hard my shoe squeaked.

Mia smiled.

"Me too."

I wanted to tell her she would be great if she won.

I also wanted to win.

Both things sat in my stomach and argued.

THE FIRST CLASS

The first ballot box came from Year Seven.

Mia received twenty-four votes.

I received nineteen.

Noah looked at the numbers.

"A strong start for pizza."

The second box favoured me.

The third favoured Mia.

The fourth tied.

Students crowded around the results board.

Each class total appeared publicly.

No secret spreadsheet.

No delayed announcement.

Mia led by six.

Then I led by two.

Then Mia led by four.

Brad watched the board like it was a basketball score.

"Timeout."

"No," Sophie said.

"Substitution?"

"No."

"Push-up contest?"

"Definitely no."

THE LAST BOX

The final box came from my own class.

Mia and I were not allowed to watch the opening.

We waited in the corridor.

Noah paced.

Brad leaned against the wall pretending not to care.

Lucas had messaged me good luck.

Daniel, Emily, and Clara waited in the library.

Mr. Vane stood beside the ballot table, completely calm.

I hated calm people.

Sophie brought out the final tally sheet.

She looked at me.

Then at Mia.

No expression.

Professional election officials are terrible for blood pressure.

"The result is verified."

Everyone leaned forward.

"Total votes: four hundred and twelve. Valid ballots: four hundred and nine. Spoiled ballots: three."

Noah raised his hand.

"Was one Greg?"

"Yes."

"Just checking."

Sophie continued.

"Mia: two hundred and seven."

I did the maths.

Two hundred and seven out of four hundred and nine.

More than half.

Mia had won.

"Tim: two hundred and two."

Five votes.

Five.

The room erupted.

Some students cheered.

Some groaned.

Mia put her hands over her mouth.

I stared at the tally.

Five votes was one table at lunch.

Five votes was the chess club minus Oliver.

Five votes was probably everyone who preferred shorter posters.

Noah put a hand on my shoulder.

I waited to feel devastated.

I did feel bad.

But mostly I felt strange.

The school had not ended.

The council had not ended.

Mia was smiling and crying at the same time.

I walked over and hugged her.

"Congratulations."

"Thank you."

"You're going to be great."

She shook her head.

"Not without your help."

"No. With my help. There's a difference."

THE LOSER'S SPEECH

Sophie asked me to say something.

I had not prepared a losing speech.

My only experience was the talent show, where losing push-ups had somehow made people cheer.

This time, I did not make a dying-printer noise.

"Thank you for voting. Mia won. The count was public, and I agree with it."

Students laughed.

Not much.

Enough.

"I started as leader because somebody added my name without asking. This time, students chose. That matters more than whether they chose me."

Noah looked guilty.

I pointed at him.

"He's still buying lunch."

The room laughed properly.

Then I congratulated Mia again.

She gave her first speech as leader.

"I will publish every council decision. I will train class representatives. I will keep the Westbridge partnership active."

Those were my promises.

She continued.

"And I will make help easier to find, meetings easier to join, and quiet students easier to hear."

Those were hers.

She hadn't defeated my ideas.

She had taken the useful ones and added more.

That was what a good council should do.

Afterwards, students tried to analyse the result.

Brad said I needed more sports policies.

Noah said I needed more pizza.

Sophie said the turnout among younger students favoured Mia.

Mr. Vane said the margin was small but the result was clear.

Mum said she was proud of me.

That was the most annoying response because it made me emotional.

At home, I took down my campaign notebook.

The first page said:

MAKE THEM VOTE FOR ME.

The last page said:

MAKE SURE THEY KNOW WHAT HAPPENS NEXT.

The second goal had survived losing.

Perhaps that meant it was the better one.

Mia called at eight.

"Are you okay?"

"Yes."

"Really?"

"Mostly."

"Good. I need you at the council room at seven-thirty on Monday."

"Why so early?"

"Because you're the new community coordinator."

"I haven't applied."

"Your application is on my desk."

"Sophie submitted it?"

"Noah."

Of course.

"Did he forge my signature?"

"No. He made you sign it during lunch by saying it was a pizza petition."

I closed my eyes.

"Noah."

Mia laughed.

"Read it before you accept. The job description is real."

I did.

It was everything I cared about.

Public records.

Community forums.

Training representatives.

No secret votes.

I signed properly.

Then I accepted.

Five votes had changed my job.

They had not changed who I was.

CHAPTER 38

Tim Is Not the Leader

Monday

My chair had a new label.

COMMUNITY COORDINATOR.

Mia sat at the head of the table.

Noah sat beside her with the snack agenda.

Sophie sat on the other side with the minutes.

Brad arrived late and asked me where the leader should sit.

"Mia's chair," I said.

He looked at me.

Then at Mia.

"Oh. Right."

The meeting began.

I waited for Mia to ask me what to do.

She didn't.

She followed her agenda.

Class-representative training.

Homework-club rooms.

Community archive.

Sports budget.

Lunch survey.

All sensible.

All organised.

She was good.

That made it easier.

And harder.

THE FIRST INTERRUPTION

During the homework-club discussion, I interrupted.

"Room 14 won't work on Thursdays. The archive volunteers use it."

Mia stopped.

"I was about to check the room calendar."

"Sorry."

She checked.

Room 14 was available.

The archive volunteers had moved to Wednesday.

I had used old information.

In public.

Mia marked the booking.

No argument.

No embarrassment.

Just a correction.

I felt my face get hot.

Sophie slid me a note.

YOU CAN BE WRONG WITHOUT IT BECOMING A MYSTERY.

I wrote back:

RUDE.

She smiled.

THE FIRST GOOD CONTRIBUTION

The community-forum plan had a problem.

Parents wanted evening meetings.

Students wanted lunchtime meetings.

Teachers could not supervise both every week.

I proposed alternating.

One lunchtime student forum.

One evening community forum each month.

Shared minutes.

Shared agenda items.

No decision made in one meeting without being open for comment before the next.

Mia approved it.

Noah called it the Two Meetings, One Argument system.

Sophie called it asynchronous consultation.

Noah said my name was better.

We agreed.

For the first time in the meeting, I stopped trying to prove I belonged.

I just did my job.

THE BADGE

After the meeting, Mia asked for my leader badge.

The current one, not the original.

I had worn it for a year.

Student Council Leader.

Tiny letters.

Huge feeling.

I took it off.

The principal stood nearby.

So did Noah and Sophie.

I handed it over.

Mia pinned it on.

"Does it feel weird?" she asked.

"Yes."

"Good. It felt weird when I won."

She gave me the coordinator badge.

It was new.

Smaller.

Less shiny.

Better.

Noah took a photograph.

Then he asked whether I could still call myself Mr. President.

"No," everyone said.

Worth trying.

THE STUDENT WHO ASKED FOR TIM

On Tuesday, a Year Seven came to the council room and asked for me by name.

Mia pointed to my desk.

The student looked surprised.

"I wanted the council leader."

"Mia is the council leader," I said.

"Oh."

There was a pause while he reconsidered his entire plan.

Then he explained that the football club kept taking the basketball court. Mia listened, checked the booking calendar, and arranged a shared practice schedule.

He left happy.

Noah said being unrecognised was good for my humility.

I said being recognised was not necessary for solving a problem.

Mia thanked me for answering the question without taking over.

The strange thing was that I enjoyed watching her solve it. Not as much as solving it myself, perhaps. But enough.

THE OLD HABIT

On Wednesday, a teacher emailed both Mia and me about the winter concert.

She was used to asking me.

I drafted an answer immediately.

Then I deleted it and forwarded the message to Mia without adding instructions.

She replied herself and copied me as coordinator.

The teacher thanked her.

No crisis.

No confusion.

Just a small habit corrected.

That evening, Noah admitted he still sometimes called me Mr. President in his head.

I admitted I sometimes answered before remembering the title was gone.

Sophie said titles were not identity.

Noah said identity was easier when it came with cake.

Mia brought cake to the next meeting and made it clear it was for everyone, not the chair.

THE FIRST CRISIS

At lunch, the homework-club room flooded.

A pipe leaked above Room 14.

Sixty students needed somewhere to go.

Mia looked at the timetable.

The library was full.

The dining hall had cooking club.

The hall was being prepared for assembly.

I opened my mouth to suggest splitting the group.

Mia spoke first.

"Library takes Year Seven. Cooking club moves to the food room. Dining hall takes Year Eight. Hall lobby takes volunteers. Tim, check the archive boxes. Noah, tell parents the club is still running. Brad, carry chairs."

Everyone moved.

No panic.

No chicken required.

She had it.

I checked the archive.

Everything dry.

The pipe was repaired by afternoon.

The club continued.

Mia did not make a speech.

She updated the room calendar and thanked the caretaker.

This was leadership.

Not the kind people put on posters.

THE EMPTY NOTEBOOK

That evening, I opened my diary.

For a year, I had written everything as if the story happened to me.

The election happened to me.

The festival happened to me.

The Black Hawks mystery happened to me.

The review happened to me.

Now someone else was writing the council's next chapter.

I could be jealous.

Or I could help make it good.

I wrote one sentence.

Mia handled the flood better than I would have.

Then another.

I carried three archive boxes and did not find a single clue.

Progress.

Noah messaged me a photograph of the leader badge.

He had drawn a moustache on it.

Not on Mia.

On the badge itself.

Some people resisted growth.

Mia changed the council room lock code the next morning.

Probably wise.

CHAPTER 39

The New Rules Meeting

Wednesday

Mia's first full community meeting began with no chairs.

The caretaker had delivered them to the hall instead of the dining room.

Noah said this proved Mia's leadership was already collapsing.

Mia asked him to help carry chairs.

He stopped commenting.

Parents arrived.

Teachers arrived.

Westbridge representatives arrived.

Mr. Vane arrived with a notebook.

Justice Moyo attended as a community member, not an official.

Daniel, Emily, and Clara sat together.

For the first time, I was not in charge.

I stood beside the public-records table with three new volunteers.

My job was to make sure every proposal had a number, every speaker had a turn, and every decision was recorded.

Simple.

Until everyone started talking.

THE PROPOSAL PROBLEM

The first proposal was about the school field.

Neighbours wanted weekend access.

Sports clubs wanted protected practice time.

Parents wanted safe supervision.

The caretaker wanted a lock that actually worked.

Everyone agreed in principle.

Nobody agreed on hours.

Mia let each group speak.

Noah tried to crack a joke.

Sophie stopped him.

Brad argued for Saturday mornings.

A neighbour argued for Saturday afternoons.

The discussion went nowhere.

Mia looked at me.

Not for an answer.

For the process.

"Proposal 1 has three options," I said. "We'll publish each option with costs and supervision requirements. No vote today. Comments close next Wednesday."

The room settled.

People did not need an immediate answer.

They needed to know what happened next.

That was my job.

Useful, not famous.

Mia had been right.

THE QUIET STUDENT

A Year Seven named Ella stood at the back with a piece of paper.

She did not raise her hand.

Nobody noticed her except Mia.

"Did you want to add something?"

Ella shook her head.

Mia did not pressure her.

"You can leave it with the records table if you prefer."

Ella gave me the paper.

It was a proposal for a quiet lunch space.

Not a big school-saving issue.

Just a place where students could eat without noise, crowds, or basketballs hitting the wall.

Two teachers had said there was no room.

Ella had found an unused office beside the library.

She had measured it.

Listed the furniture.

Asked twelve students whether they would use it.

All twelve said yes.

I read the proposal twice.

"This is excellent."

Ella looked surprised.

"Will it happen?"

"I don't know. But it will be Proposal 2, and everyone will see it."

She smiled.

At the next meeting, the quiet room was approved.

No secret investigation.

No dramatic speech.

Just a student with evidence and a process that made space for her.

Mia's campaign promise worked.

THE FIELD VOTE

The field proposal returned the following week.

Option A protected weekday practices and allowed supervised weekend access.

Option B opened the field every weekend but reduced club time.

Option C kept the field students-only.

The caretaker priced the lock and supervision.

The sports clubs published their practice schedules.

Neighbours proposed a volunteer rota.

Option A won.

Brad did not get every hour he wanted. The neighbours did not get unrestricted access. Both groups could see exactly why the decision worked.

Noah asked whether the lock code could be nine.

Mr. Vane said no.

The new lock was installed on Friday. Its code was long, random, and not written on a folder.

Justice called that measurable progress.

THE MEETING THAT ENDED EARLY

By the fourth meeting, the agenda finished twelve minutes early.

Every proposal had a next step.

Every speaker had a turn.

Every budget figure was already published.

Noah suspected a trap.

Mia closed the meeting and let everyone go.

Students remained in the corridor talking because they wanted to, not because another argument had started.

Mr. Vane reviewed the minutes and found nothing missing.

Sophie looked disappointed there were no corrections.

Ella used the extra twelve minutes to interview a student who had never attended before.

That became the best use of an early finish: not adding more business, but making room for someone new.

The next agenda included one open question with no decision attached.

WHAT SHOULD WE TALK ABOUT NEXT?

It received more responses than any budget proposal.

THE VOLUNTEER ROTA

The records table became popular enough to need a rota.

Ella trained two students from each year.

They learned to number proposals, save corrections, and ask speakers to repeat unclear figures.

My job became checking that nobody needed me.

At the next meeting, I arrived five minutes late and discovered the volunteers had already opened the session, distributed the agenda, and recorded the first decision.

No catastrophic clues.

No confused silence.

Just competent students doing the work.

Mia had left an empty chair for me, but the process had not left a gap. That was exactly what the handover was supposed to achieve.

THE PUBLIC MINUTES

Publishing minutes sounds easy until people read them.

A parent objected to being recorded as opposed to field access.

She had opposed one schedule, not the whole idea.

A teacher said a budget figure was wrong.

Noah objected to the phrase "Noah made an unhelpful comment."

Sophie said it was accurate.

I corrected the first two.

The third stayed.

Noah demanded an appeal.

The appeal was recorded.

He objected to that too.

By Friday, everyone could see the final version online and in the library.

Mia checked every correction.

The volunteers learned how to separate fact from opinion.

I learned that transparency involved a lot of apologising for typos.

Mr. Vane reviewed the minutes.

He found two ambiguous sentences.

Sophie found three missing commas.

Noah found his name fourteen times.

"Why am I in the minutes so much?"

"Because you keep talking," Mia said.

He nodded.

"Fair."

THE COORDINATOR'S RULE

At the end of the week, I added one rule to the records table.

NO DECISION WITHOUT A NEXT STEP.

If something needed research, name the researcher.

If it needed money, name the budget.

If it needed a vote, name the date.

If it was impossible, explain why.

No disappearing proposals.

No promises left in drawers.

No mysterious empty boxes.

Mia approved the rule.

Sophie put it on the wall.

Noah added:

NO FOOD IN THE ARCHIVE.

He was looking at me.

I had eaten one biscuit near one folder one time.

Some rules are personal.

Ella visited on Friday to see her quiet-room proposal on the board.

"Did you write it?" she asked me.

"No. You did."

"But you made it important."

"No. The meeting made it visible. You made it good."

She thought about that.

Then she asked whether she could volunteer at the records table.

I gave her a badge.

Not leader.

Not coordinator.

ARCHIVE ASSISTANT.

She wore it like a medal.

Perhaps that was how it started.

Not a forged name.

Not a huge mystery.

Just someone being invited in.

CHAPTER 40

The Night Before Promise Day

Monday

Promise Day was one week away.

The hall was repaired.

The community council worked.

Mia had survived her first month.

Noah had survived only being mentioned fourteen times in the minutes.

Then the principal announced that the city would use Promise Day for its first annual review.

Not Adrian Vane's review.

A normal one.

Attendance.

Budgets.

Safety.

Student participation.

Ms. Dube would attend.

So would city officials, parents, Westbridge students, and neighbours.

The ninth-promise celebration had become an assessment again.

Noah groaned.

"We saved the school. Why are people still reviewing it?"

"Because schools are always reviewed," Sophie said.

"That sounds exhausting."

"That's called running a school."

Mia took it calmly.

Too calmly.

On Tuesday, she rewrote the programme three times.

On Wednesday, she checked every club display herself.

On Thursday, she stayed after school to repair a poster.

On Friday, she snapped at Noah for moving a chair.

Noah looked shocked.

"It was one chair."

"It was the accessible aisle chair."

He put it back immediately.

Mia apologised.

Then she went outside.

I found her beside the oak.

"You're doing the Tim thing," I said.

"What Tim thing?"

"Trying to make everything depend on you."

She laughed without humour.

"That's easy for you to say. Everyone keeps comparing me to you."

I hadn't expected that.

"Who?"

"Teachers say your showcase was bigger. Students say your election was more exciting. Noah keeps asking whether you've solved anything mysterious this week."

"Noah asks everyone that."

"Still."

She looked at the hall windows.

"If Promise Day fails, they'll say the school was safer with you leading."

There it was.

Not a mystery.

Not sabotage.

Pressure.

THE ADVICE I FINALLY UNDERSTOOD

I sat beside her.

"When I led the festival, I thought being in charge meant having the answer. Then everyone started doing useful things without me, and I thought it meant I wasn't needed."

"What changed?"

"I realised leaders don't have to do everything. They have to make sure nobody has to do everything alone."

Mia rolled a leaf between her fingers.

"That sounds like something Sophie wrote for you."

"She did. On a folder."

"I knew it."

We laughed.

Then I gave her the practical version.

"Cancel half your jobs."

"Which half?"

"The ones other people can do."

THE JOB SWAP

We returned to the council room.

Mia had seventeen tasks.

Sophie took the programme.

Noah took signage, with spelling supervision.

Brad took equipment.

I took the city evidence table.

Mia took speakers, student support, and one final check.

Nine tasks remained unassigned.

Ella took the records volunteers.

Oliver took club registration.

Lucas took Westbridge coordination.

Daniel took alumni displays.

Mrs. Patel took archive materials.

The principal took safety.

Mr. Vane took the official timetable.

Mia's list now had four items.

She looked relieved.

Then worried.

"What if they do it wrong?"

"They will," I said.

She stared at me.

"That's your advice?"

"Some of it will be wrong. We fix it. If everything depends on it being perfect, we'll fail."

Sophie nodded.

"That's the first sensible thing you've said all term."

"I've said lots of sensible things."

Noah shook his head.

"Not really."

THE MISSING PROGRAMME

At six, the printed programmes arrived.

They said Promise Day was on Saturday at 10:00.

Promise Day was on Sunday at 11:00.

Every copy was wrong.

Mia looked at the printer boxes.

Two hundred programmes.

Noah checked the order form.

He had entered the old date.

Everyone looked at him.

"I said some of it would be wrong," I reminded Mia.

Noah raised his hand.

"Good news. The paper is recyclable."

We did not reprint.

The environment had suffered enough.

Ella designed a sticker with the correct details.

Students formed an assembly line.

Two hundred stickers.

Two hundred programmes.

Twenty minutes.

Noah applied every sticker upside down until Sophie moved him to box folding.

At seven, we finished.

Mia stood in the empty hall.

Rows of chairs.

Club tables.

Archive display.

Correct programmes.

Everything ready.

Not perfect.

Ready.

"Thank you," she said.

"For what?"

"For losing."

I laughed.

"You're welcome."

She smiled.

"If you had won, I'd still be helping homework club and wondering whether you needed help. Now we're both doing the right jobs."

It was true.

Five votes had not just changed me.

They had changed her.

And the council.

And maybe the school.

PROMISE DAY EVE

Before leaving, I checked the public archive.

The Founders' Register was back.

Justice had released it after the investigation.

Its missing-ballot section now contained certified copies and a note explaining what happened.

The original pages remained legal evidence.

Nothing hidden.

On the register's last blank page, students had begun adding new promises.

Mia wrote:

I will ask who is missing.

Sophie wrote:

I will keep the record.

Noah wrote:

I will not eat evidence.

Brad wrote:

I will pass the ball.

Lucas wrote:

I will choose partnership.

My page was still blank.

I had one night to decide what to promise.

Not a slogan.

Not a campaign.

Something I could actually do.

I closed the register and went home.

The answer came while I was brushing my teeth.

Unfortunately, toothpaste got on the notebook.

But the promise was good.

CHAPTER 41

Promise Day

Sunday

Promise Day began with rain.

Not dramatic storm rain.

Annoying light rain that made everyone carry displays inside while saying the weather forecast had promised sunshine.

The oak tree dripped.

The outdoor programmes got wet.

Noah's correct-date stickers began peeling off.

Sophie looked at the sky like she wanted it to complete an incident form.

"Move everything inside," Mia said.

No panic.

No list of seventeen jobs.

Everyone already knew theirs.

Brad moved chairs.

Lucas directed Westbridge visitors.

Ella protected the archive.

Noah held an umbrella over Greg.

Frank got wet.

Brad said Frank liked rain.

Frank squeaked in disagreement.

By eleven, the repaired hall was full.

The new floor shone.

The old stage had new lights.

The place where Gerald the crack had been was smooth and white.

Noah put a small plaque beneath it.

GERALD WAS HERE.

Dr. Rahman removed it before the city officials arrived.

THE FIRST PROMISE

Mia opened the assembly.

She did not talk about winning the election.

She talked about the people who had kept Brookfield's promises before us.

Martha Moyo and the Ninth Class.

The first students who planted the oak.

The Black Hawks who protected evidence.

The families who kept copies.

The current students who made decisions public.

Then she invited Ella to read the first promise.

Ella walked onto the stage with her paper shaking.

"I promise to ask who is missing."

The hall became quiet.

She continued.

"Not just who is absent from school. Who is missing from the meeting. Who doesn't join the club. Who never puts their hand up. Who goes home before anyone asks whether they wanted to stay."

Mia smiled.

That was Ella's promise.

Not Mia's.

Not mine.

It belonged on the stage.

One by one, others followed.

Sophie promised to keep honest records even when they made her look bad.

Noah promised to check whether a cookie was evidence before eating it.

Brad promised to pass the ball.

Lucas promised that partnership would never require one school to disappear.

Daniel promised to tell the truth earlier.

Emily promised not to confuse secrecy with protection.

Clara promised to keep the bookshop open to students.

Justice promised to declare her connections before someone had to ask.

Mr. Vane promised to change his mind when the evidence required it.

That got applause.

He looked uncomfortable.

Good.

MY PROMISE

My turn came near the end.

I walked to the microphone with one index card.

The audience waited.

Noah was already grinning because he thought I would make a noise.

I didn't.

"Last year, I promised myself that Tim Rules. It was a good slogan. It was not a good system."

People laughed.

I looked at the register on its stand.

"My promise is shorter. I will leave the door open."

Some people thought it was a joke about Room 75.

They laughed again.

I explained.

"If I know something useful, I'll share it. If I make a decision, I'll record it. If someone wants to help, I'll show them how. If I have to keep something private, I'll explain why. And when I leave a job, I won't take the keys with me."

Mia nodded.

Sophie wrote it down.

Ella added it to the promise list.

It was not the best speech ever.

It was mine.

And it could be checked.

THE OAK TREE CEREMONY

The rain stopped after lunch.

We moved outside.

Each class tied a paper promise to a temporary string beside the oak, not to the tree itself.

The gardening club had explained that tying things to bark could damage it.

Even traditions had evidence-based updates now.

The original stone marker had been cleaned.

WHAT WE PROMISE, WE BECOME.

Justice's mother stood beside it.

She read Martha's final sentence.

"A promise unused does not disappear. It waits for the next students to carry it."

Then she handed the original council badge to Mia.

Not to keep.

To use during Promise Day and return to the archive.

A public object with a public purpose.

Mia held it up.

Students cheered.

Noah started chanting, "MIA RULES."

She shook her head.

"Everyone rules."

Noah changed the chant.

It did not rhyme.

Nobody cared.

THE PROMISE LUNCH

Between the assembly and the oak-tree ceremony, the kitchen staff served lunch.

They used the same serving layout Noah had tested months earlier.

The drinks stayed away from the queue.

Year Sevens reached the front before the bell.

A visitor asked whether we had hired a queue consultant.

Noah pointed to himself.

"Unpaid."

The kitchen staff pointed to the suggestion box where their original idea had waited for two years.

"Next time, read it sooner," one of them said.

Mia added that sentence to the community-council training notes.

Even the celebration lunch became evidence. A system was not successful because it looked good during an inspection. It was successful when people ate while it was raining and nobody missed the next speech.

THE FIRST-TIME SPEAKERS

After Ella spoke, the programme included students who had never stood on a stage.

One read a promise about making friends.

Another read a promise about learning to apologise.

A boy who stammered chose to have his friend stand beside him while he read.

Nobody hurried him.

The applause afterwards was not louder because he struggled.

It was warm because he finished.

Noah had planned to perform a comic promise about homework. He still did, and people laughed.

The day had room for both.

When I helped clear the stage, Ella said she had been more nervous reading eleven words than submitting her first proposal.

"Would you do it again?" I asked.

"Yes. But next year someone else gets a turn first."

Leaving the door open sometimes meant stepping away from the microphone.

THE CITY OFFICIAL

Ms. Dube watched the ceremony.

Afterwards, she addressed the school.

"Last year, the city treated consultation as a requirement to complete. You treated it as a practice to improve. We will use your community-council model in three other school pilots."

Sophie looked stunned.

Mr. Vane nodded.

Lucas smiled.

Mia thanked her.

Then Ms. Dube added, "The model will be adapted. It will not be copied exactly."

I liked that.

Different schools could make their own promises.

Not Tim Rules everywhere.

Everyone rules, differently.

THE LAST TABLE

At the end of the day, I found a small child sitting beside the archive table.

She was too young for Brookfield.

Her older sister was in Year Seven.

She pointed at the rubber chicken in the display photograph.

"Is that Greg?"

"Yes."

"Can I meet him?"

Brad brought Greg over.

The child squeezed him.

SQUEAK.

She laughed.

Then she picked up a blank promise card and drew a picture of a school with a very large door.

"What does it say?" I asked.

"Come in."

Ella pinned it to the board.

Best promise of the day.

No signatures.

No evidence required.

Just an open door.

CHAPTER 42

The Ordinary Inspection

Monday

The city inspectors arrived at 8:30.

No smoke.

No secret files.

No silver-haired director with a hidden agenda.

Just Ms. Dube, a finance officer, and an attendance officer carrying clipboards.

They observed lessons.

They checked the hall repairs.

They read the lunch-queue data.

They visited the quiet room.

They interviewed students.

One inspector asked Noah whether the council had changed.

"Yes. We have more folders and less pizza."

"Is that better?"

"The folders are better. The pizza situation is under review."

The inspector wrote it down.

Noah looked worried.

"That was a joke."

"Then it will be recorded as one."

Transparency was difficult.

THE ATTENDANCE QUESTION

Attendance had improved by one point two percent.

Not a miracle.

Enough to show progress.

Mia explained the homework club and mentoring programme.

The attendance officer asked whether the improvement depended on free food.

"Partly," Mia said. "Students come earlier when breakfast is available. They also come because someone notices when they don't."

The officer asked how we knew.

Mia showed her interviews, not just numbers.

The officer smiled.

"Good."

No drama.

No trap.

Just evidence.

THE FINANCE QUESTION

The finance officer found an error.

Of course.

A twelve-pound stationery purchase appeared in both the archive and council budgets.

Sophie went pale.

Duplicate entry.

Not theft.

Not fraud.

A spreadsheet mistake.

The officer asked how it happened.

Sophie explained.

The officer asked how she would prevent it.

Sophie proposed a receipt-reference field.

The officer agreed.

Twelve pounds corrected.

No accusation.

No forged signature.

No emergency.

After the officer left, Sophie stared at the table.

"I made a mistake."

"Yes," I said.

"People will see it."

"Yes."

"And?"

I smiled.

"And now they'll see the correction."

She nodded slowly.

"That is extremely annoying."

"Welcome to my entire life."

THE SAFETY QUESTION

Dr. Rahman's repairs passed inspection.

The hall certificate was issued.

The sports field needed a new gate lock.

The library needed one more fire sign.

Room 75 required a clear label and an updated inventory.

The principal looked relieved that nobody wanted to enter it.

The inspectors did enter it.

They found old boxes, a wobbly table, and nine drawers.

No treasure.

No mystery.

The caretaker labelled the shelves.

Noah stayed outside.

"Are you feeling okay?" I asked.

"I don't want to be the person who discovers another plot during an ordinary inspection."

"That's very responsible."

"It's also very boring."

"Yes."

He thought about it.

"Can we at least keep one drawer mysteriously empty?"

"No."

THE COMPLAINT ABOUT COMPLAINTS

The inspectors' only difficult interview was with a parent who said the complaints process was impossible to understand.

She had submitted the same concern to the council, the office, and a teacher because nobody explained who owned it.

Mia did not defend the system.

She asked the parent to demonstrate what happened.

Three forms.

Two email addresses.

No tracking number.

The attendance officer watched the demonstration and agreed it was confusing.

By lunch, Mia, Sophie, and the office manager had drafted one route: one form, one reference number, one named owner, one response date.

Noah called it the Four Ones.

Sophie called it a single-point complaint workflow.

Noah said his name would be more popular.

The parent tested the new form and understood it in under a minute. Her original complaint finally received an answer.

The inspectors did not mark us down for finding the problem. They recorded how we fixed it.

THE FINANCE CORRECTION

Sophie published the twelve-pound correction with a short explanation.

No hiding it in an appendix.

No dramatic apology.

DUPLICATE ENTRY FOUND DURING INSPECTION. TOTAL CORRECTED. RECEIPT REFERENCES ADDED TO ALL FUTURE ENTRIES.

A student asked whether that meant the council had stolen money.

Sophie showed him both entries, the single receipt, and the corrected total.

He understood in two minutes.

Then he asked whether she could check his maths homework.

She said that was not part of the public-finance service.

The correction became an example in Mr. Vane's source lesson. An honest record was not one without mistakes. It was one where a mistake could be traced, understood, and repaired.

Sophie put that sentence above her desk.

Noah put a smaller sign beneath it: STILL CHECK THE MATHS.

THE RETURN VISIT

Before leaving, the inspectors returned to the quiet room.

Three students were reading. One was drawing. Nobody was performing engagement for the visitors.

The attendance officer asked Ella whether the room was used every day.

She showed the booking record instead of answering from memory.

Some days were full. Some had only two students. All were useful.

The inspector wrote that small services should not be judged by crowd size alone.

Ella put the comment in the archive. It supported something she had argued from the beginning: a school did not only serve the students who could fill a hall.

THE STUDENT INTERVIEWS

The inspectors asked me whether losing the election had weakened the council.

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because leadership changed without the work stopping."

They asked Ella whether students felt heard.

"More than before."

"What would make it better?"

"Shorter meetings."

The inspector wrote it down.

Sophie agreed.

Noah cheered.

Mia proposed time limits for routine items.

The change was approved at the next meeting.

An inspection had produced an improvement without anyone panicking.

That was the point.

THE ORDINARY RESULT

The final report arrived on Friday.

Brookfield met its requirements.

The community council was effective.

Finances were accurate after correction.

Buildings were safe with routine maintenance.

Student participation was strong.

One recommendation asked us to improve support for new representatives.

Another asked us to simplify the complaints process.

Neither threatened closure.

Neither required a mystery.

Mia read the report at assembly.

"Next year, we'll have another inspection. We'll probably have more corrections. That's not failure. That's maintenance."

Mr. Vane nodded.

Justice smiled.

Noah asked whether maintenance could include a hot-chocolate machine.

Lucas offered to share Westbridge's instructions.

Sophie said no before anyone could calculate the cost.

After assembly, I filed the report in the public archive.

Next to Mr. Vane's old review.

Two documents.

Two very different processes.

Same school.

Still here.

CHAPTER 43

The First History Project

Wednesday

Mr. Vane's history class had to create an exhibition about Brookfield.

Not a poster with three facts.

A real exhibition using primary sources, conflicting accounts, and corrections.

Noah chose the Black Hawks.

Sophie chose the first council.

Brad chose the history of school sports, mostly so he could bring basketballs to class.

Ella chose the quiet-room proposal.

Mia chose the election.

I chose Room 75.

The principal asked whether that was wise.

Mr. Vane said history was not wise or unwise. It was evidence.

Then he told me I could not use the phrase "probably haunted" anywhere.

Fair.

THE CONFLICTING ACCOUNTS

Daniel said Room 75 was a meeting place for the Black Hawks.

Emily said it was mostly storage.

Clara said it was where they kept the register for two nights.

Mr. Vane said he had never entered it.

The principal said he had known about it and kept it locked.

The caretaker said everyone had used it at some point and nobody admitted it.

Six people.

Six different rooms.

I put their accounts side by side.

The exhibition did not choose one hero.

It showed what each person knew and what each person feared.

Daniel feared losing the evidence.

Emily feared hurting students.

Clara feared Harper.

Mr. Vane feared disorder.

The principal feared the truth about his own inaction.

The caretaker feared nobody would fix the radiator.

The radiator had never worked.

Some details mattered only to one person.

They still belonged.

THE MISSING VOICE

My exhibition had no account from Mr. Harper.

He was still under investigation and declined to participate.

I could have written that he was simply the villain.

But history required more than that.

His old reports showed he believed development would bring money and recognition to the school.

He had done harmful things.

He had also started two clubs and improved the library years earlier.

Those facts did not excuse him.

They explained why people trusted him.

Mr. Vane read my draft.

"Are you defending him?"

"No. I'm explaining why hiding evidence worked."

"Why?"

"Because people thought he was only good or only bad. They stopped checking."

He nodded.

"That is a useful historical argument."

Noah looked at my board.

"It's less fun when the villain has a library programme."

"History is annoying."

"So is this class."

Mr. Vane gave him another source.

THE ELECTION PROJECT

Mia's exhibition included my original election poster, her campaign plan, the public count, and Noah's confession.

She interviewed me about losing.

I said it had helped.

She asked whether I would have said that on election night.

"No."

She included both answers.

Noah complained that the exhibition made him look like a criminal mastermind.

"You forged an election nomination," I said.

"One."

"And my coordinator application."

"Two."

"And you put Greg on the ballot."

"That was a spoiled ballot, not a forgery."

Mr. Vane gave him a source-criticism exercise.

Noah said the school needed a museum of his suffering.

THE SOURCE CARD BOX

Mr. Vane placed a blank-card box beside the exhibition.

Visitors could add memories, corrections, or questions.

By lunch, the box was full.

One former student remembered Daniel forgetting the lines of his first speech.

Another said the old hall had always smelled of dust and oranges.

A parent corrected the date on a sports photograph.

A teacher disputed Noah's account of the Great Pizza Shortage.

Every card received a number. The Promise Team checked which ones could be verified and which should remain personal memories.

Mr. Vane insisted both categories could be included if they were labelled honestly.

Noah wrote a card saying he had always been an excellent historian.

Sophie labelled it PERSONAL OPINION — NOT INDEPENDENTLY VERIFIED.

He said source criticism was being used against him.

That was the point.

THE FIRST VISITORS

The first booked visitors to the new Room 75 were a Year Seven class.

They did not gasp when the door opened.

They asked why the table had a glass top, who Martha Moyo was, and why one drawer contained chalk.

Mr. Vane answered with sources instead of legends.

A student asked whether anyone had ever been locked inside.

Noah looked at Brad.

Brad looked at me.

I said, "Yes, briefly, and that is why the new door has a window."

The class laughed.

The student asked whether the room was haunted.

The caretaker said the only frightening thing had been the radiator bill.

History became less frightening and more interesting. Real people had made choices there. Some were brave. Some were wrong. All could be discussed without whispering.

At the end of the visit, each student wrote one question on an index card.

The most common question was not about treasure.

It was: WHAT WILL WE USE THIS ROOM FOR NEXT?

THE QUIET ROOM INTERVIEW

Ella interviewed the first student who used the quiet room.

He did not want his name printed.

She asked whether she could record his experience anonymously.

He agreed, provided she showed him the exact words first.

His statement was simple: I USED TO EAT IN THE CORRIDOR. NOW I EAT WITH TWO FRIENDS.

No statistics.

No dramatic transformation.

Just lunch becoming easier.

Ella added the statement only after he approved it.

Mr. Vane used it as an example of consent in oral history.

Ella realised an archive was not only about preserving voices. It was about giving people control over how their voices were used.

She added a permission line to every future interview form.

THE ROOM 75 RULES

The history room needed rules, but Sophie refused to cover the wall with forty warnings.

The students chose five.

Book before visiting.

Leave the door unlocked during open hours.

Record anything moved from the shelves.

No food near the documents.

No story is too ordinary to investigate.

Noah tried to add DO NOT LOCK BRAD INSIDE.

Brad said that rule was historically specific.

Mia changed it to CHECK THE ROOM BEFORE CLOSING.

It covered everyone.

The caretaker tested the closing procedure twice.

The first time, he found Noah behind the table looking for a secret drawer.

The second time, everyone left correctly.

Progress was recorded in the inventory log.

Above the rules, June placed a photograph of the old heavy door beside the new glass one.

Students could see the difference without needing to be frightened by it.

THE OPENING

Parents visited the exhibition on Friday.

They read the mistakes as well as the achievements.

Some former students were upset that the Black Hawks were not shown as perfect heroes.

Daniel answered them.

"We weren't."

Emily stood beside him.

"We were brave sometimes. Frightened most of the time. Right about some things. Wrong about others."

Clara pointed to her own statement.

"I left. That mattered too."

The visitors listened.

A former teacher admitted she had ignored students' warnings.

She wrote a new source statement and added it to the display.

History changed while we watched.

Not the past.

Our understanding of it.

Ella's quiet-room project received the most visitor comments.

Not because it was the biggest story.

Because everyone remembered wanting a quiet place at school.

Her exhibition included the original proposal, the approved plan, and a photograph of students reading there.

One line at the bottom said:

THIS HAPPENED WITHOUT A MYSTERY.

Noah objected.

"It could use a mystery."

"No," everyone said.

THE TEACHER'S GRADE

Mr. Vane gave my exhibition an A-minus.

I stared at the minus.

"Why?"

"Your conclusion says the room no longer holds secrets."

"It doesn't."

"You cannot prove a negative. You can say no further secret materials were found during the documented inventory."

Noah laughed.

"Minus for saying no more mysteries."

I changed the sentence.

NO FURTHER SECRET MATERIALS WERE FOUND DURING THE DOCUMENTED INVENTORY.

Mr. Vane changed the grade to an A.

Then he handed me a blank source card.

"For your own account."

I wrote:

I used to think every locked room needed opening. Now I think every decision needs explaining.

He read it.

"Better."

The card joined the exhibition.

My voice in history.

Not the whole story.

One source.

Exactly right.

CHAPTER 44

The Talent Returns

Saturday

The repaired hall needed a proper celebration.

Not a review.

Not a council meeting.

Not a historical exhibition.

A talent show.

Mia announced it on Monday.

Students cheered.

Noah looked at me.

"Printer."

"No."

"Duck."

"No."

"Dying printer."

"No."

"Car engine."

"Maybe."

Sophie put me down as stage coordinator instead of performer.

This was supposed to keep me backstage.

It did not.

THE WESTBRIDGE DUET

Lucas signed up to perform with Westbridge's music club.

Oliver signed up for speed chess with live commentary.

Mia and Sophie prepared a presentation called "How to Run a Meeting in Under Ten Minutes."

Nobody knew whether it was comedy.

Sophie insisted it was educational.

Noah signed up for a dramatic reading of council minutes.

Brad entered a basketball routine with Frank.

The drama club used the new lights.

The cooking club ran the snack stall.

The whole event became a joint Brookfield–Westbridge programme without anyone calling it a merger.

Good.

THE MISSING PERFORMER

On Thursday, the piano player became ill.

A ten-minute gap opened in the programme.

Sophie looked at me.

"No."

"You don't even have to prepare."

"No."

"The duck noise is ready."

"No."

Mia joined in.

"We could use a host for the final act."

"That sounds like a trick."

"It is a small trick."

I agreed to host.

Not perform.

Host.

At the show, everything ran smoothly until Brad's basketball routine.

His music stopped.

The hall went silent.

Brad stood in the centre holding Frank.

The audience waited.

Without thinking, I made the car noise.

BRRRRRMMMMM.

Noah joined with a siren.

Brad started dribbling in rhythm.

The audience clapped.

Then I made the duck noise.

QUAAAAAK-HRRRRK.

Frank squeaked.

Brad spun the ball.

The music came back on.

The routine ended with Frank landing in a bucket.

The crowd exploded.

So much for hosting.

THE ENCORE

At the end, students chanted for one more performance.

Mia looked at me from the wings.

"You don't have to."

I knew that.

That was why I did it.

I walked to the microphone.

"My talent is making weird noises and getting involved in things I said I wouldn't do."

Everyone laughed.

Then I performed the full sequence.

Duck.

Car.

Squeak.

Police siren.

Dying printer.

The audience laughed exactly like last year.

Except now I wasn't performing to win an election or prove Brad wrong.

I was doing it because it was funny.

Noah joined for the final printer noise.

His sounded more like a vacuum cleaner.

Lucas attempted the duck.

It was terrible.

Brad did a backflip.

Nobody knew why.

Sophie timed the whole encore and announced it had lasted four minutes and twelve seconds.

Educational.

THE BACKSTAGE EMERGENCY

The shared stage nearly did not happen.

Five minutes before the final song, two Westbridge students and three Brookfield students refused to stand beside each other.

An online argument about the basketball rematch had returned.

Brad was furious.

Lucas looked tired of mediating.

Sophie reached for the incident form.

Mia did something simpler. She asked each group to explain what the other had said.

The accusations were almost identical.

"He called my team cheats."

"She said my school only cared about winning."

Then Mia asked what the song was actually about.

Nobody answered.

Noah quietly said, "Sharing a stage and questionable rhymes."

One student laughed.

The tension broke.

Mia did not force apologies or pretend the argument was solved. She offered a choice: perform together now and discuss the issue on Monday, or step aside without being punished.

Everyone stayed.

During the song, the students who had argued stood at opposite ends at first. By the final chorus, someone moved to make room for a late performer and the groups mixed naturally.

On Monday, the discussion happened. The online posts were corrected. No mystery account. Just students learning that a rivalry could survive without becoming hatred.

THE AUDIENCE PARTICIPATION PROBLEM

During Noah's dramatic reading of the council minutes, he invited the audience to shout whenever they heard his name.

There were fourteen mentions.

The audience shouted fourteen times.

Sophie said the performance was not an authorised consultation.

Noah said it was performance art.

Mr. Vane said the vote on whether it was funny had not been properly conducted.

For once, everyone agreed with Mr. Vane: some people had laughed and some had not.

The student newspaper ran an anonymous poll.

Noah lost by five votes.

He demanded a recount.

Mia told him the result was not binding.

He accepted defeat and bought himself emergency biscuits with his own money.

Historical parallels were not always flattering.

THE CAST PARTY

After the show, both schools shared food backstage.

There was no formal review of performances.

Students exchanged songs, compared stage-fright stories, and tried to imitate Mr. Vane's serious applause.

Mr. Vane applauded again to demonstrate that he had been sincere.

Noah recorded him and promised to preserve the footage for history.

Sophie made him ask permission first.

Mr. Vane granted it on condition that the caption mention his contribution to stage discipline.

Brad said his basketball routine had required the most discipline.

Mia said surviving Noah's dramatic minutes had required more.

The argument continued until the food arrived. Then everyone agreed the cooking club had won the evening.

THE SHARED STAGE

The final act included students from both schools.

A song about keeping your own colours while sharing a stage.

It was not a great song.

The rhyme "Westbridge" with "best bridge" was used twice.

But everyone sang.

I stood backstage holding Greg.

Mia stood beside me.

"Still not the leader?" she asked.

"Not tonight."

"Looks like you're leading."

"No. I'm holding poultry."

Greg squeaked.

The song ended.

Students took their bows.

No trophy.

No vote.

No city decision.

Just applause.

The best kind.

CHAPTER 45

The Bookshop Promise

Friday

Clara's bookshop reopened every Saturday.

The front room sold books.

The back room became Brookfield's neighbourhood archive reading space.

Students could research family histories.

Former students could donate photographs.

Nobody needed an appointment to ask a question.

Helen worked there as part of her community-restitution agreement.

Two volunteers supervised archive access.

Every item was logged.

Every copy stayed public.

No locked bags.

No secret transport.

No anonymous notes.

At first, people watched her carefully.

Then they began asking for help.

THE PHOTOGRAPH BOX

One Saturday, an elderly woman brought a box of Brookfield photographs.

Most showed ordinary days.

Students in the dinner queue.

Teachers beside the gate.

Children playing beneath the oak.

None contained secret maps.

All were valuable.

Helen scanned each one and wrote down the woman's memories.

Clara made tea.

I helped label dates.

Noah helped by eating the emergency biscuits until Daniel moved them.

The woman found a photograph of her own mother in the first Ninth Class.

She had never known her mother represented the school.

On the back was a promise.

MAKE ROOM FOR THE CHILD WHO ARRIVES LATE.

Not one of the nine official promises.

A personal one.

Ella copied it for the quiet-room display.

Another old promise carried by new students.

THE FAMILY QUESTION

Lucas came to the bookshop alone.

His father's case was still ongoing.

Richard had admitted altering records and faced professional penalties.

The criminal building-damage investigation continued.

Lucas did not want to defend him.

He also did not want to pretend he no longer had a father.

I understood why he looked tired.

Helen gave him a folder.

Inside were photographs of Richard as a parent governor.

In one, he helped paint the library.

In another, he stood beside a fundraising stall.

"He did good things too," Helen said.

Lucas looked angry.

"That doesn't help."

"No. It doesn't erase anything. But you don't have to turn your whole childhood into a lie to tell the truth about what he did."

He sat with the photographs for a long time.

Then he scanned them.

His own history could include both.

The father who taught him to organise a tournament.

The man who hid community votes.

Love and disappointment in the same folder.

No simple villain.

No simple forgiveness.

Just truth.

THE KEY RETURN

Helen returned the last archive key to Clara.

Not in secret.

During the Saturday opening.

She placed it in the public key register.

Clara signed.

Mrs. Patel witnessed.

Justice approved the record.

Noah watched the whole ceremony.

"That's a lot of paperwork for one key."

"Yes," Helen said.

"Was it worth hiding everything?"

"No."

She answered without defending herself.

Good.

Later, she asked Sophie whether she could help train archive volunteers.

Sophie agreed.

"With a checklist."

Helen smiled.

"I expected nothing less."

THE BOOK WITH NO LABEL

At closing time, I found an unlabelled book beneath the reading table.

Old green cover.

No title.

My heart jumped.

For a second, I thought I had found another register.

Then I opened it.

It was a blank notebook.

Someone had started a new community diary.

On the first page were instructions.

WRITE WHAT HAPPENED TODAY. SIGN YOUR NAME IF YOU WANT. LEAVE ROOM FOR OTHER PEOPLE'S VERSIONS.

No mystery.

An invitation.

I wrote about the photograph box.

Lucas wrote about his father without naming every detail.

Helen wrote about returning the key.

Noah wrote that the emergency biscuits were underprotected.

Daniel added a note that emergency biscuits were not historical property.

Clara wrote that in a bookshop, every object told a story, but not every story needed to become a secret.

I liked that.

THE READING GROUP

The bookshop started a Thursday reading group for students who said they did not like history.

Clara did not begin with dates.

She began with objects.

A lunch token.

A torn sports shirt.

A library card.

A cracked trophy.

Students chose one object and imagined the person who owned it. Then they checked the archive to see what could actually be proved.

Noah imagined a heroic biscuit thief.

The archive revealed that the lunch token belonged to a student who later became a chef.

He admitted the real story was better.

Helen showed the group how to record uncertainty without turning it into a dramatic clue.

"Perhaps means perhaps," she said. "Write it down and keep looking."

It was the most useful lesson she could teach after everything that had happened.

THE OPEN-HOURS QUESTION

More visitors created a new problem.

Clara could not run the bookshop and archive alone.

Students proposed longer opening hours, but Helen warned that access without enough supervision would damage trust again.

The Promise Team created a rota.

Two trained volunteers per shift.

One adult always present.

Clear closing times.

No exceptions because a story sounded urgent.

On the first Saturday, the system felt slow.

Then a visitor arrived with a box of private family letters.

Because the process was calm, Clara had time to explain what could be copied, what should remain private, and who would have access.

The visitor chose to donate three letters and keep the rest.

A good archive did not collect everything.

It helped people make informed choices about their own history.

THE FIRST COMMUNITY QUESTION

A visitor asked whether the bookshop would keep documents about unflattering events.

Clara pointed to the altered report, the forged signatures, and the statements of apology on the public shelves.

"Especially those," she said.

The visitor asked whether displaying mistakes made the school look weak.

Helen answered before anyone else.

"Hiding them made us weak. Letting people check them is how we became trustworthy again."

It was not a defence of what she had done. It was an explanation of why she would not do it again.

The visitor donated a photograph after all.

On the back, she wrote her name, the date, and one instruction: SHOW BOTH SIDES.

THE NEXT SATURDAY

The following week, more people came.

Not because of a clue.

Because someone had told them the door was open.

A student found her grandfather in a sports photograph.

A teacher found his first classroom.

A neighbour donated an old lunch menu.

Ella started a section called SMALL PROMISES.

The quiet room.

The breakfast club.

The chess clock.

The lunch queue.

The hot-chocolate machine that had not been adopted by Brookfield despite Noah's campaign.

History was becoming ordinary.

That made it easier to keep.

Before I left, I read my own promise in the community diary.

Leave the door open.

The bookshop door was propped wide.

People walked past.

Some came in.

Exactly how it should be.

CHAPTER 46

The New Black Hawks

Monday

Daniel wanted to re-form the Black Hawks.

Not as a secret society.

As a public history-and-service club.

Students would maintain the archive, interview former residents, protect school traditions, and help with community events.

Membership open to everyone.

Meetings advertised.

Minutes published.

No hidden ranks.

No coded messages.

No secret handshakes.

Noah objected to the last one.

"A club without a secret handshake is just a timetable."

Daniel said he could invent a public handshake.

Noah proposed three claps, a chicken squeak, and an emergency biscuit.

It became the official greeting.

Sophie recorded it in the constitution.

Mr. Vane checked the historical section.

Mia approved the club.

The Black Hawks were back.

THE FIRST MEETING

Twenty-four students joined.

Some loved history.

Some loved mysteries.

Some came because Noah mentioned biscuits.

Ella joined to preserve small promises.

Oliver joined to document the chess club.

Brad joined because Frank needed a legacy.

Lucas attended as a Westbridge partner.

I joined as an ordinary member.

Daniel sat at the front and realised he had no plan.

For all his experience with secret societies, he had never run a normal after-school club.

Sophie handed him an agenda.

"Welcome to transparency."

He looked terrified.

The first decision was the club name.

Black Hawks History Society.

Black Hawks Community Archive.

Black Hawks Promise Team.

Noah suggested Black Hawks and Snacks.

Students voted.

Black Hawks Promise Team won.

No secret ballot.

A show of hands counted by two volunteers.

Daniel smiled.

"The old Black Hawks would have hated this."

"Why?" Emily asked.

"No mysterious symbols."

Clara drew the folded-wing hawk on the whiteboard.

"One symbol. Publicly explained."

Underneath, she wrote:

PROTECT THE TRUTH. SHARE THE RECORD.

No hidden meaning.

Good.

THE FIRST PROJECT

The team chose to record the history of the oak tree.

Everyone knew its official story.

Founders planted it.

Promises happened there.

A metal box had been hidden nearby.

But students had their own stories.

Brad got stuck in its branches.

Noah ate lunch beneath it every day.

A teacher had her first class outdoors there.

A neighbour proposed to his wife beside it.

Ella interviewed students who used its shade when they felt overwhelmed.

The tree became more than a symbol.

It became a collection of lives.

The gardening club measured its roots and explained how to protect them.

The art club made rubbings of its bark without damaging it.

The coding club built an online map where people could add memories.

No password secrets.

Moderated by two adults and two students.

Every contribution credited.

THE DISAGREEMENT

Daniel wanted the original Black Hawks' photograph at the top of the map.

Ella wanted the newest students' promises there instead.

Daniel said history should begin with the founders.

Ella said the map should begin with people using the tree now.

They argued.

Daniel looked at me.

I was the experienced mystery person.

The former leader.

The obvious tie-breaker.

I almost gave an answer.

Then I stopped.

"What does the club constitution say?"

Sophie smiled.

"Community decisions require student and alumni agreement."

"So find a shared design."

They did.

The map opened on a split image.

The first promise day and the latest one.

Old and new.

Same tree.

Different students.

Daniel admitted the design was better.

Ella thanked him for suggesting the photograph placement.

Compromise without a secret winner.

Useful.

THE NAME BADGES

The Promise Team made badges for every member.

Daniel's said FOUNDER.

Emily's said FIRST ARCHIVIST.

Clara's said KEEPER OF THE BOOKSHOP.

Noah wanted his to say CHIEF SNACK HAWK.

Sophie changed it to REFRESHMENTS VOLUNTEER.

My badge said MEMBER.

I liked it more than I expected.

There was no special title for solving old mysteries. No rank for knowing where the cup had been hidden. New members could ask questions without feeling they had joined a story too late.

June chose MEMBER too.

"Titles are for jobs," she said. "Membership is for belonging."

Daniel put that sentence in the club constitution.

Noah asked whether belonging included biscuits.

The constitution remained silent on that issue.

THE NEW MEMBER

At the second meeting, a new student sat beside the door.

She had joined Brookfield after the review.

Her name was June.

She knew nothing about the Festival Cup, Room 75, or the election.

When Noah started telling the whole story at high speed, she looked overwhelmed.

I interrupted.

"Short version. The school had problems. People hid things. We found them. Now we try not to hide things."

June nodded.

"Why are they called Black Hawks?"

Clara explained the original symbol.

Why black?

Because the first hawk was drawn with a black marker.

Why hawks?

Because one nested near the school roof the year the group formed.

Not an ancient code.

Not a prophecy.

A bird and a marker.

Noah looked disappointed.

"Sometimes the truth is disappointingly simple."

June laughed.

Then she volunteered to digitise the newest photographs.

No investigation required.

Just a job.

THE PUBLIC CABINET

The Promise Team received a display cabinet outside the library.

It had two locks.

Both keys were logged in the office.

The cabinet held copies, not originals.

A label explained where the originals were stored and who could access them.

No false bottom.

No hidden panels.

Brad checked anyway.

Nothing.

On opening day, June placed her first scanned photograph inside.

Students leaving Brookfield that year.

Families at the oak.

The new hall.

The quiet room.

Mr. Vane teaching.

Mia leading.

Me at the records table.

Noah holding an emergency biscuit like evidence.

Under the photograph, June wrote:

WE WERE HERE TOO.

That became the cabinet's motto.

Better than any secret code.

CHAPTER 47

The Last Locked Room

Friday

The principal decided Room 75 needed a new purpose.

It could not remain a dusty monument to secrets.

It could not become a random cupboard again either.

The community council discussed options.

Archive storage.

Club room.

History display.

Quiet study space.

Noah suggested emergency-biscuit headquarters.

That proposal received one vote.

Noah's.

The final decision was a student history room.

Open during supervised hours.

Booked through the library.

Public inventory.

Glass panels in the door.

No more dark entrance.

No more mystery about who had keys.

THE CLEAN-OUT

Every item was removed and catalogued.

Festival ribbons.

Broken trophies.

Attendance registers.

Cameras.

Maps.

Nine drawers.

The wobbly table.

Students repaired what could be repaired.

The archive preserved what mattered.

The rest was recycled with permission.

No clue ignored.

No clue invented.

At the back of drawer six, I found a small folded paper.

Everyone stopped.

The room had a sense of humour.

Sophie put on gloves.

Justice watched.

The principal sighed.

I opened the paper.

It was a shopping list from 1998.

Tea.

Chalk.

Light bulbs.

Biscuits.

Noah pointed.

"Historical evidence that snacks matter."

It went into the archive.

All history.

No mystery.

THE TABLE

The wobbly table had belonged to the first council.

One leg was damaged.

The woodworking club repaired it.

Underneath, students had carved initials over decades.

Some were famous now.

Martha Moyo.

Daniel Cross.

Clara Bell.

Some belonged to people nobody remembered.

Justice said that was why the room should stay open.

A table could hold more than documents.

It could hold evidence of ordinary students.

We added a protective glass top instead of sanding the initials away.

New students could write in a book instead of carving the wood.

Noah asked whether chicken footprints counted.

No.

THE DOOR

The old lock was removed.

The heavy door was replaced with one that had a glass window.

Room 75 suddenly looked less frightening.

Light entered from the corridor.

Shelves were labelled.

The repaired table stood in the centre.

On the wall, a timeline explained what had happened there without turning anyone into a perfect hero.

The Black Hawks.

Harper.

The principal's silence.

The festival.

The register.

The current inventory.

At the bottom was a blank space.

FUTURE HISTORY.

Not for another mystery.

For whatever students did next.

THE FIRST PROJECT INSIDE THE ROOM

June's first Room 75 project was a record of the room itself.

Students photographed each shelf before touching it.

They interviewed the caretaker about repairs and the principal about his decision to keep it locked.

No one edited out the uncomfortable answers.

One student asked whether keeping the room secret had ever been necessary.

The principal said yes at first, when evidence was unsafe. Then no, when silence had become a habit.

That distinction became the centre of the display.

A place could be protected for a good reason and remain closed for a bad one. The only way to tell the difference was to keep asking.

Noah asked whether his old locker deserved the same historical treatment.

Sophie said no until he removed the food.

THE PUBLIC INVENTORY

Mrs. Patel published the complete inventory online.

Students could search by object, year, donor, or storage shelf.

Every entry included what was known and what remained uncertain.

The shopping list had a date but no named owner.

The broken camera had a serial number but no explanation for the crack.

The wobbly table had dozens of initials and not enough evidence to identify them all.

Instead of inventing answers, the Promise Team marked those entries UNCONFIRMED.

Noah said an archive with unanswered questions was just a mystery with better lighting.

Mr. Vane said it was an honest archive.

The inventory also recorded what had been thrown away. Broken cardboard, unusable pens, and moldy paper received disposal entries with dates and witnesses.

That sounded boring until a former student asked about a box that had been discarded. Because the entry existed, she could learn exactly what happened without accusing anyone of hiding it.

Transparency was not only about treasures. It was about ordinary objects and ordinary decisions.

THE FIRST RETURNED OBJECT

A week after the room opened, Daniel returned a small metal box he had taken home years earlier.

It contained blank promise cards from the first festival.

He had kept them because he thought they might be useful for another secret meeting. Then he forgot them in a drawer.

The Promise Team logged the return, photographed the box, and placed it beside the new cards students were using.

June wrote the catalogue entry herself: RETURNED BY DANIEL CROSS. NO MYSTERY. JUST A DRAWER.

Daniel signed beneath it.

Everyone laughed, including him.

The last object did not reveal a new plot. It simply completed the inventory and gave one more ordinary thing its proper place.

THE OPENING

The principal unlocked the new door during a public ceremony.

Then he handed the key to Mrs. Patel.

She logged it and placed it on the library key board.

That was the whole ceremony.

No dramatic speech.

No hidden compartment.

No one got locked inside.

Noah checked the handle twice.

"Disappointingly functional."

"Yes," the principal said with relief.

June and Ella held the first history-club meeting in the room.

They discussed a scan of the first lunch menu.

Daniel sat in the corner listening.

Mr. Vane helped a student compare dates.

I stood outside with Sophie.

"Are you okay?" she asked.

"Yes."

"You look like you want one more secret."

"Maybe a small one."

She pointed to the glass door.

"Not that room."

"I know."

And I did.

The important thing was not that Room 75 had no secrets.

It was that students no longer needed secrets to use it.

THE KEY IN MY POCKET

As I walked away, I found something cold in my jacket.

A key.

For one second, my heart jumped.

Then I remembered.

My house key.

Mum had given it to me that morning.

I laughed out loud.

Sophie shook her head.

"You're hopeless."

"Probably."

"Normal keys are allowed."

"Good."

I put it back in my pocket.

Not every key opened a mystery.

Some just got you home in time for dinner.

CHAPTER 48

The Second Festival

Saturday

The new Brookfield festival happened exactly one year after the first.

No missing cup.

No sabotage.

No criminal running between stalls.

Just a school field full of people.

Westbridge had its own section.

So did the public library, the bookshop, the sports clubs, and the neighbourhood groups.

The Festival Cup stood in a public display with its full story.

The Founders' Register stood beside it under protective glass.

Copies were available to touch.

Originals were preserved.

No one had to break into anything.

THE COUNCIL STALL

Mia ran the council information stall.

Ella showed students how to submit proposals.

Sophie displayed the public budget.

Noah ran a game called Guess the Meeting Length.

Participants guessed how long a council decision would take.

The answer was always longer than Noah wanted.

Brad ran the basketball challenge.

Lucas ran the Westbridge chess-and-sports table.

I managed the lost-and-found.

Former council leader.

Mystery solver.

School saver.

Now responsible for three water bottles, one scarf, and a left shoe.

It was honest work.

THE MYSTERIOUS SHOE

The shoe had no partner.

No name.

No size label.

For five minutes, I considered investigating.

Then a Year Seven hopped over wearing one shoe.

Problem solved.

Noah looked disappointed.

"You didn't even form a team."

"No."

"Or check the cameras."

"No."

"Or interrogate the scarf."

"The scarf has an owner too."

I returned it.

Normal service was excellent.

THE BLACK HAWKS DISPLAY

The Promise Team presented the oak-tree history map.

Daniel, Emily, and Clara answered questions.

Helen volunteered at the archive stall.

Justice and her mother recorded memories.

Mr. Vane checked source labels until students told him to enjoy the festival.

He bought a cake.

Then checked whether the stall had a receipt book.

It did.

Sophie had trained everyone.

The old Black Hawks took a photograph beside the new team.

No secrets.

No matching jackets.

No ranks.

Just people who cared about the same school at different times.

June stood in the centre holding the public cabinet key log.

Ella held the small-promises book.

Noah held Mr. Squeaks, who had finally been returned after his mysterious disappearance last year.

Where had he been?

Under Noah's bed.

Some mysteries solved themselves when you cleaned your room.

THE COMMUNITY MEAL

Before the afternoon events, every stall contributed something to a shared meal.

The cooking club made bread.

Westbridge families brought salads.

The gardening club supplied herbs.

The public library donated nothing edible but provided clean tablecloths and a very detailed plan.

Noah brought emergency biscuits.

Daniel checked they were not evidence.

There was no head table.

Teachers ate beside students. Former Black Hawks sat beside new Year Sevens. Mr. Vane shared a table with the kitchen staff who had solved the lunch-queue problem.

A neighbour said the festival felt different because nobody was performing importance.

Mia heard him and wrote the phrase in her notebook.

I understood. The first festival had proved we could survive chaos. The second proved we could enjoy each other without it.

When the rain began briefly, nobody ran. We moved the paper displays under cover and kept eating.

THE LOST-AND-FOUND REUNION

My lost-and-found table became unexpectedly popular.

Not because more things were lost.

Because people kept finding their owners.

A teacher found the scarf she had lost during Open Week.

Lucas found the Westbridge water bottle he had accused Brad of keeping.

Noah found a notebook containing his first campaign slogans.

One read VOTE NOAH BECAUSE TIM IS BUSY.

He claimed it was a historical document.

Ella photographed it for the archive.

At closing time, only one object remained: a small toy hawk.

A primary-school child returned five minutes after we packed the table.

She had been crying because she thought it was gone forever.

I handed it back.

Best recovery of the festival.

No code required.

THE VOLUNTEER PHOTOGRAPH

Before the principal spoke, Sophie gathered every volunteer for a photograph.

There were too many people for the first frame.

Students moved closer. Parents stood on the steps. The kitchen staff joined from behind their stalls. Daniel carried the emergency biscuits. Mr. Vane held the public first-aid folder because he refused to leave it unattended.

Noah asked whether the volunteers who only came for food counted.

Mia said yes if they had helped carry something.

Brad pointed to the three boxes Noah had moved.

Noah stood proudly in the front.

The photograph became a record of how much work an ordinary festival required. No single person at the centre. No room for everyone to be a hero. Everyone visible anyway.

THE PRINCIPAL'S ANNOUNCEMENT

At three, the principal stepped onto the stage.

Everyone became quiet out of habit.

He smiled.

"Nothing is missing."

The crowd laughed.

"Nothing has been stolen. No secret message has arrived. The accounts balance. The hall is safe. And the festival is on budget."

Sophie wiped away a fake tear.

The principal continued.

"Last year, we thanked students for saving a festival. This year, I want to thank them for making it ordinary again."

Applause filled the field.

He was right.

An ordinary festival was an achievement.

People could enjoy the day without worrying what disaster came next.

Mia joined him on stage.

She announced that festival profits would fund next year's community programmes.

Every amount would be published.

Noah shouted, "Including hot chocolate?"

Mia said, "No."

The crowd laughed.

Some promises would never be kept.

THE CHICKEN FINAL

The last event was the inter-school rubber-chicken championship.

Greg.

Frank.

Winston.

And a newcomer named Junebug, belonging to June.

The final required throwing chickens through a hoop while answering one history question.

Noah asked the questions.

"Who wrote the ninth promise?"

"Martha Moyo and the first student representatives."

Correct.

"What does BPL stand for?"

"Brookfield Public Library."

Correct.

"Who added Tim to the election list?"

Noah looked at me.

The crowd shouted, "NOAH!"

Correct.

My turn.

"Who owes Tim lunch for a week?"

"Noah," I said.

Correct.

Greg flew through the hoop.

Winston landed on the rim.

Frank bounced off Brad's head.

Junebug went backwards and landed in the cake stall.

No real cakes were harmed.

Much.

Greg won again.

The crowd chanted, "TIM RULES."

I held up Greg.

Then I handed him to June.

"Your turn next year."

She grinned.

Traditions survived when you passed them on.

CHAPTER 49

The Actual Final Rule

Friday

At the end of term, the council met to write its final report.

Mia's first term.

My first term as coordinator.

Ella's first term as archive assistant.

Noah's first term without eating evidence, according to Noah.

Sophie challenged that claim.

The report included achievements and failures.

Homework club expanded.

Quiet room opened.

Westbridge partnership continued.

Community forums held.

Budget corrections made.

Field access still unresolved.

Three proposals missed their deadlines.

The complaints process remained confusing.

No hot-chocolate machine.

Noah added the last item personally.

Mia removed it.

He put it back under community concerns.

THE LEADERSHIP REVIEW

Justice asked each of us to name one thing we had learned.

Mia said leadership was not being indispensable.

Sophie said a perfect record mattered less than a correctable one.

Noah said public confessions were cheaper than private investigations, but lunch made them expensive.

Brad said passing the ball sometimes won games.

Lucas said defending your school did not require attacking another.

Ella said quiet people still needed an invitation.

Daniel said old mysteries became useful only when people stopped repeating their mistakes.

Emily said protection without consent could become control.

Clara said archives needed open hours, not secret addresses.

Mr. Vane said institutions improved when their standards applied to the people running them.

Justice said a conflict declared early was a fact; a conflict discovered late became a scandal.

Everyone looked at me.

"I learned that I like mysteries more than meetings."

Noah nodded.

"Finally, honesty."

"But meetings help more people."

Sophie nodded.

"Also honesty."

"And if you leave the door open, people bring better ideas than the ones you had."

Mia smiled.

"Put that in the report."

I did.

THE NEW RULE LIST

At the start of the year, Sophie had written rules for me.

Don't enter secret rooms without permission.

Don't investigate alone.

Don't touch mysterious USB drives.

Don't use festival equipment as weapons.

Don't keep food in lockers.

Don't eat evidence.

Now I wrote a new list for the next council.

Rule 1: Put the decision where everyone can see it.

Rule 2: Ask who is missing.

Rule 3: Return what you borrow.

Rule 4: Check the signature, but check the person too.

Rule 5: Keep the receipts.

Noah approved of that one.

Rule 6: If a room is locked, find out why before opening it.

Brad said that rule lacked excitement.

Rule 7: If someone disagrees, record their argument properly.

Mr. Vane approved.

Rule 8: Leave the school better than you found it.

The old Black Hawks' seventh rule.

Still good.

Rule 9: Leave the door open.

My promise.

The ninth promise made practical.

Noah waited.

"Where's 'Tim Rules'?"

I looked at the list.

It did not need to be there.

Then Brad picked up the pen.

At the bottom, he wrote:

Rule 10: Chicken battles are optional, but recommended.

Sophie sighed.

Mia kept it.

Democracy.

THE LAST PAGE

The community diary had one blank page left before a new volume began.

Everyone wanted me to write the final entry.

I thought about the first book.

The election.

Brad's posters.

The talent show.

The Festival Cup.

Room 75.

The Black Hawks.

Then the sequel.

The review.

Westbridge.

The register.

The forged votes.

The damaged hall.

The election I lost.

The ordinary inspections.

The second festival.

I had spent two years thinking a good story needed one more mystery.

It didn't.

Sometimes it needed a meeting that ended on time.

Sometimes it needed someone else to sit in your chair.

Sometimes it needed a rubber chicken landing in a bucket.

On the last page, I wrote:

Being leader was never the whole story. The story was everyone who walked through the door after I opened it.

Then Noah took the pen.

And everyone who carried snacks.

Sophie took it.

And everyone who checked the records.

Brad took it.

And everyone who passed.

Mia took it.

And everyone who asked what happened next.

Ella wrote last.

And everyone who thought they didn't belong until someone made room.

We signed the page.

All of us.

No single hero.

No secret authorship.

THE HANDOVER TEST

Mia made me complete one final test before signing my handover.

Ella pretended to be a new coordinator.

She asked where the public minutes were stored, who controlled the archive keys, how to correct a mistake, and what to do if someone demanded a private decision.

I answered every question without opening my notebook.

Then she asked where the emergency biscuits were.

Daniel answered before I could.

Noah objected that their location was classified.

Ella marked that answer as incorrect.

The test ended when she found every document herself. No Tim required. No secret knowledge. No single person holding the system together.

Mia signed the handover.

Sophie witnessed it.

Mr. Vane checked the date.

It was the proudest administrative moment of my life.

THE NEXT VOLUME

The new community diary began with a contents page.

Ella insisted even diaries needed to be findable.

Volume One contained the review, the register, and the election.

Volume Two would contain ordinary promises, club records, interviews, and corrections.

Noah suggested a mystery index.

Sophie suggested an index of completed actions.

Mia included both.

The completed-action index was longer.

Much longer.

I liked looking at it.

Every entry pointed to something finished: a room opened, a budget corrected, a student heard, a record returned.

Not all stories ended with THE END.

Most ended with a date, a signature, and someone taking responsibility for what happened next.

THE BADGE ON THE TABLE

After the meeting, Mia placed the original council badge in its archive case.

The current leader badge stayed on her jacket.

My coordinator badge stayed on mine until the new volunteers were trained.

Then I would hand that over too.

No dramatic retirement.

Just a handover checklist.

Passwords transferred.

Keys logged.

Folders labelled.

Contacts shared.

Promises with deadlines assigned.

Noah said it was the least dramatic ending ever.

"Good," the principal said.

He had earned a quiet year.

I packed my notebook.

Greg sat beside the report.

For once, nobody started a chicken battle.

Brad looked disappointed.

Then Frank squeaked inside his bag.

The battle began three seconds later.

Some rules did not need writing down.

CHAPTER 50

Everyone Rules

One year later

Brookfield was still open.

That sentence still made me smile.

The hall had not fallen down.

Westbridge had not taken us over.

The community council had not collapsed under the weight of its own minutes, although Noah said it had come close several times.

Mia remained council leader for a second term.

Ella became archive coordinator.

June led the Black Hawks Promise Team.

Oliver organised the first joint chess league.

Brad captained Brookfield and trained with Westbridge, and nobody called him a traitor anymore except Noah during games.

Lucas remained my rival in chess and my friend everywhere else.

Sophie went to every meeting with two pens, three folders, and an expression that suggested she had already found your mistake.

Mr. Vane taught history.

His first homework assignment each year was still about the difference between history and memory.

His eyebrows remained suspicious.

THE NEW STUDENT

On the first morning of term, a new Year Seven stood outside the council room.

She looked at the open door.

Then at me.

"Is this where you ask to start a club?"

"Yes."

"Any club?"

"Within reason."

"A detective club?"

Noah appeared from nowhere.

"Yes."

Sophie appeared behind him.

"Maybe."

Mia came to the door.

"What do you want to investigate?"

The student held up a notebook.

"The old tree by the field. Someone carved numbers into the fence."

Noah's eyes lit up.

Sophie reached for a site-inspection form.

Mia asked whether the student had told the caretaker.

She had.

Good start.

Then she looked at me.

"Are you Tim?"

"Yes."

"The one who solves mysteries?"

"Sometimes."

"The one who saved the school?"

"Lots of people saved the school."

She looked disappointed by the responsible answer.

Noah leaned toward her.

"He also makes a dying-printer noise."

That impressed her much more.

THE FENCE NUMBERS

The numbers on the fence were not a code.

They were measurements from the gardening club.

Each marked the distance between young trees planted after the repairs.

The gardening-club label had fallen off.

We put up a new one.

Mystery solved in seven minutes.

No secret room.

No missing register.

No forged vote.

The new student looked disappointed.

"That's it?"

"That's it," I said.

"Are all school mysteries like that?"

"No. Some take seventy-five chapters."

Noah coughed.

"And fifty."

Sophie added, "And several public inquiries."

The student opened her notebook.

"Can I still start the club?"

Mia handed her a proposal form.

"Yes. First rule: record what actually happened, not what you hoped happened."

The student wrote it down.

Second rule, according to Noah:

"Always bring snacks."

Third rule, according to Sophie:

"Label your snacks separately from evidence."

Fourth rule, according to me:

"Don't investigate alone."

I knew that one from experience.

THE COUNCIL ROOM

After school, the Promise Team met in Room 75.

Light came through the glass door.

The repaired first-council table stood in the centre.

June led the meeting.

Ella published the agenda.

The new student presented her detective-club proposal.

It was approved with a safety plan and a library supervisor.

No secret society.

No mysterious nomination.

Just a club.

Outside, students crossed the field toward the festival stalls.

The Festival Cup was on display.

The register was available on the archive computer.

The community diary had reached volume four.

The oak tree had a new ring of young plants around it, each adopted by a class.

The stone marker remained.

WHAT WE PROMISE, WE BECOME.

For once, I understood that becoming something was not a single moment.

Not winning an election.

Not finding a cup.

Not saving a school.

It was all the ordinary days afterwards.

THE LAST CHICKEN BATTLE

Brad called me before I left.

"One more battle?"

Greg was older now.

One wing had torn and been repaired with yellow tape.

Frank had a dent near his beak.

Winston still looked like he paid taxes.

Junebug had become surprisingly competitive.

We met beside the oak.

Noah refereed.

Sophie timed the rounds.

Mia kept score.

Lucas complained about the rules.

Ella recorded the result for the archive.

June held the chickens.

Brad threw Frank first.

Frank landed in the bucket.

Perfect.

I threw Greg.

Greg hit the rim, bounced into the air, and landed on Mr. Vane's shoulder.

Mr. Vane had arrived with a stack of history books.

He looked at Greg.

Greg squeaked as he slid to the ground.

Everyone went silent.

Then Mr. Vane picked him up and threw him into the bucket.

Perfect shot.

Noah fell over laughing.

Brad demanded a professional league.

Mia awarded Mr. Vane one point and a cake voucher.

Mr. Vane said the throw was based on a straightforward trajectory calculation.

Nobody believed him.

Even Adrian Vane had learned to enjoy a festival.

THE FINAL ENTRY

That evening, I opened my notebook.

Not the community diary.

My own.

The first page still had the old slogan written in huge letters.

TIM RULES.

I used to think it meant I should be in charge.

Then it meant I should solve everything.

Then it meant I should win.

Now it meant something else.

Tim listened.

Tim shared.

Tim admitted mistakes.

Tim passed the badge on.

Tim left the door open.

Those things ruled too.

On the last blank page, I wrote my final rule.

Not Rule 1.

Not Rule 9.

Just the one I wanted the next student to find.

YOU DON'T HAVE TO BE THE LEADER TO CHANGE WHAT HAPPENS NEXT.

I closed the notebook.

Outside, I could hear Noah laughing, Brad arguing about the score, and Sophie telling everyone the meeting had ended twenty minutes ago.

Mia called my name.

Ella asked whether I was coming.

June held the door open.

For me this time.

I walked through.

And honestly...

Everyone rules.

THE END.